



THE FLAVOR EQUATION

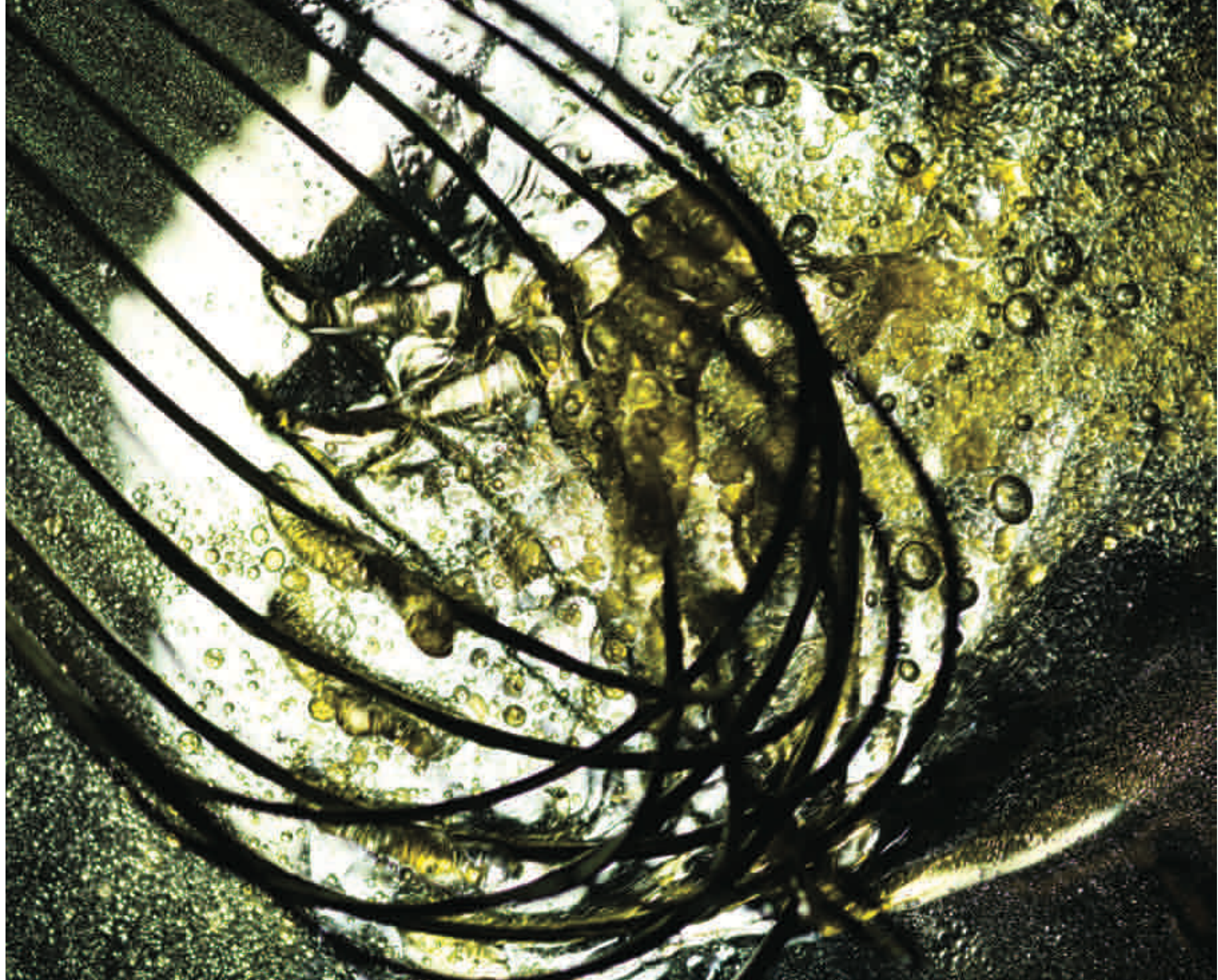
THE SCIENCE OF GREAT COOKING EXPLAINED
+ MORE THAN 100 ESSENTIAL RECIPES

Nik Sharma

Foreword by Christopher Kimball

Illustrations by Matteo Riva

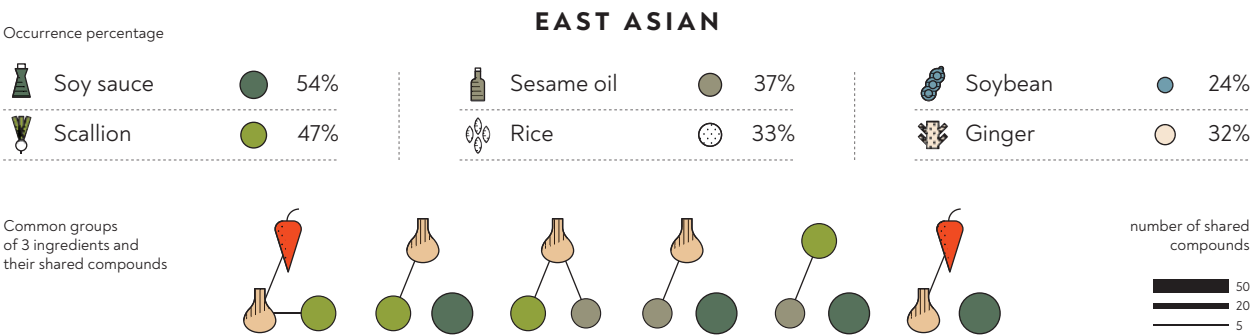
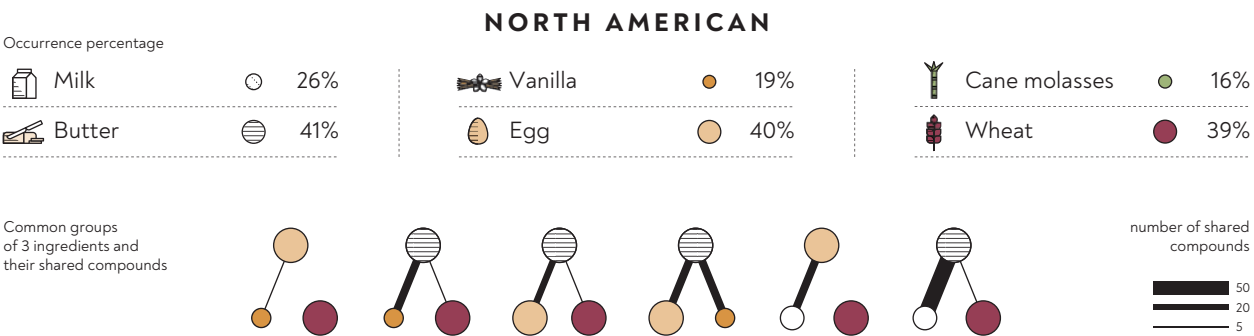

CHRONICLE BOOKS
SAN FRANCISCO



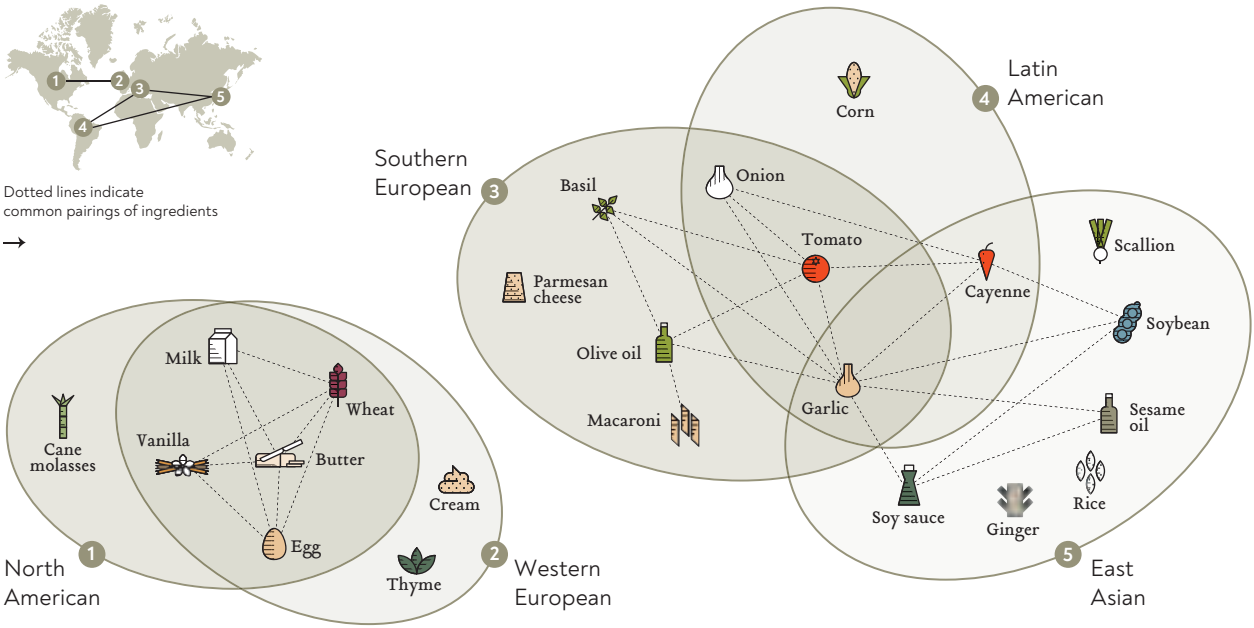


CULTURAL AND REGIONAL DIFFERENCES IN FLAVOR PAIRING

Cultural and regional diversity affects the way we combine ingredients and pair the flavors we cook with.



REGIONAL CO-OCCURRENCE OF COMMON INGREDIENTS



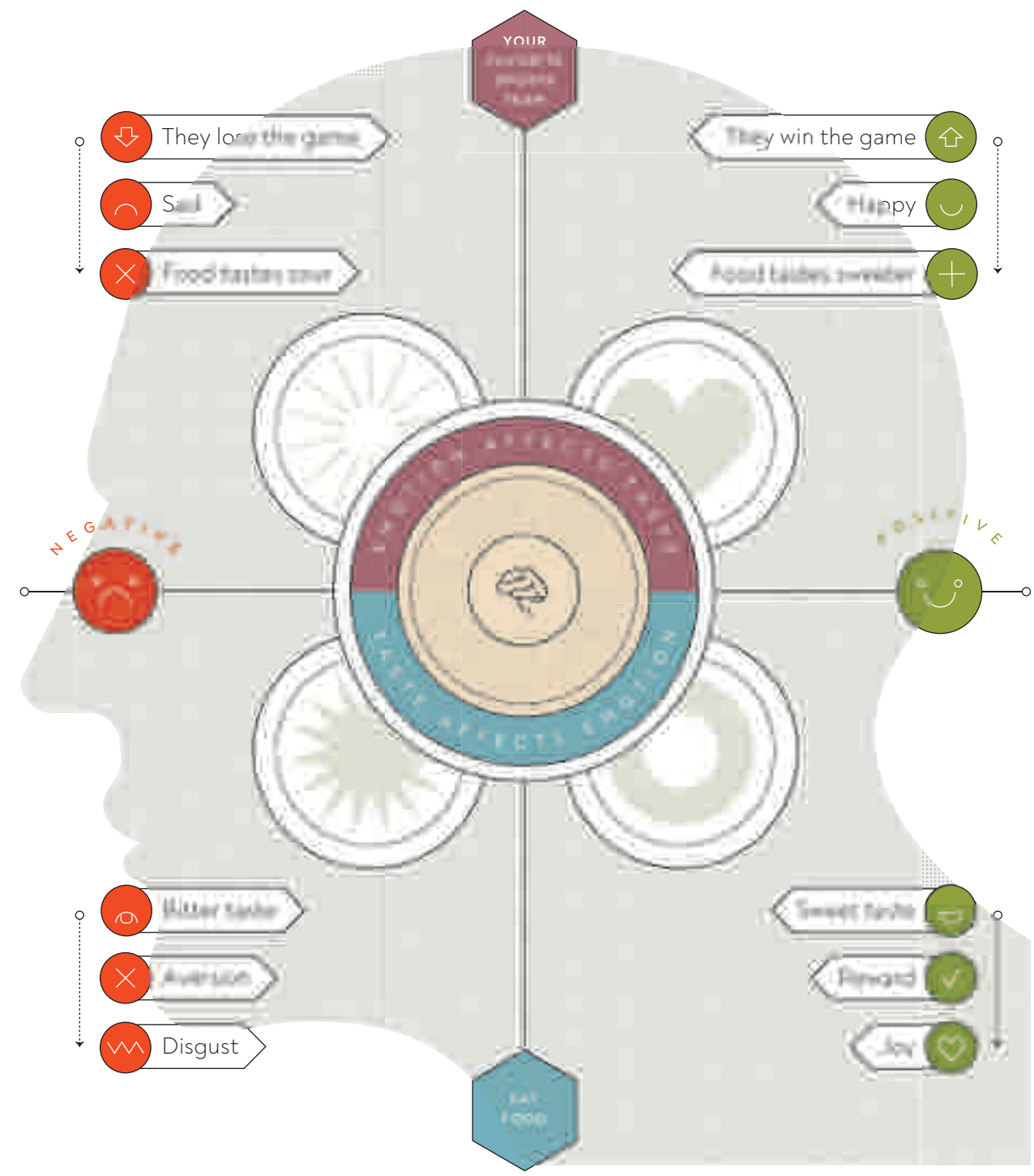
Adapted from Ahn, Y., Ahnert, S., Bagrow, J. et al. "Flavor network and the principles of food pairing." *Scientific Reports* 1, 196 (2011).

I. THE FLAVOR EQUATION



EMOTION AND TASTE

Emotion and taste influence each other.

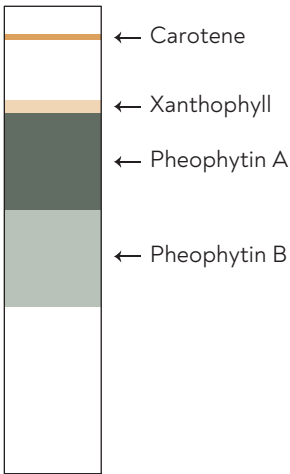
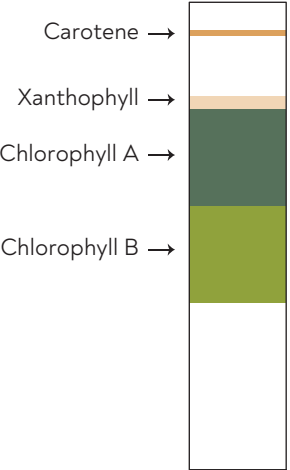


SPINACH OXIDATION

Cooking by heat changes the color of pigments in spinach leaves.



FRESH SPINACH



CANNED SPINACH

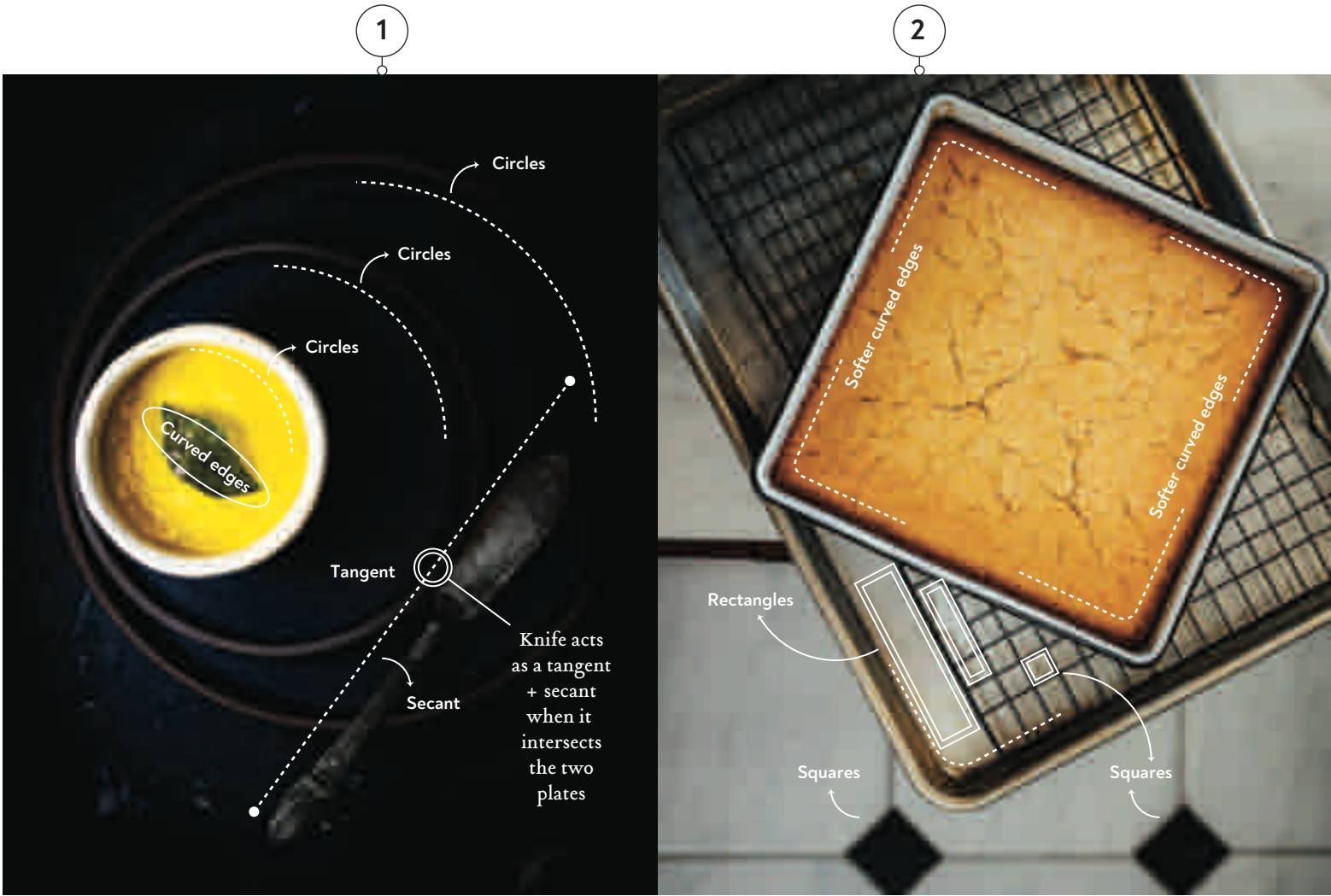
TABLE OF COMMON FOOD PIGMENTS

The pigments responsible for the different types of colors naturally present in our fruits, vegetables, and meats can be sorted into two groups based on whether they dissolve in water or fat.

Water-Soluble Food Pigments	Pigment Subtypes	Color	Found In
Anthocyanins			Blueberries, Pomegranates, Grapes, Purple beans
Anthoxanthins			Cauliflower, Spinach, Onions, Green leafy vegetables
Betalains	Betacyanin		Beets, Amaranth, Rhubarb, Swiss chard, Prickly pear cactus
	Betaxanthin		Red and yellow beets, Yellow Swiss chard, Yellow-orange pear cactus
Myoglobin			Meat
Hemoglobin			Blood, Meat that comes into contact with blood
Polyphenols and tannins			Quince, Red wine, Sumac
Fat-soluble food pigments			
Chlorophylls	Chlorophyll-a		Green leafy vegetables, Bell peppers, Beans, Peas, Green chillies
	Chlorophyll-b		Chicories
Carotenoids	Carotenes	Alpha-carotene	Carrots, Sweet potatoes, Green leafy vegetables, Mangoes
		Beta-carotene	Carrots, Oranges, Green leafy vegetables, Apricots
	Xanthophylls	Lycopene	Tomatoes, Watermelon
		Lutein	Egg yolks
		Capsanthin	Paprika, Red chillies
	Xanthophylls	Crocin	Saffron
		Bixin	Annatto
	Curcumin		Turmeric
		Orange-yellow turns red when exposed to an alkaline pH (e.g., baking soda)	

GEOMETRIC SHAPES + COMPOSITION

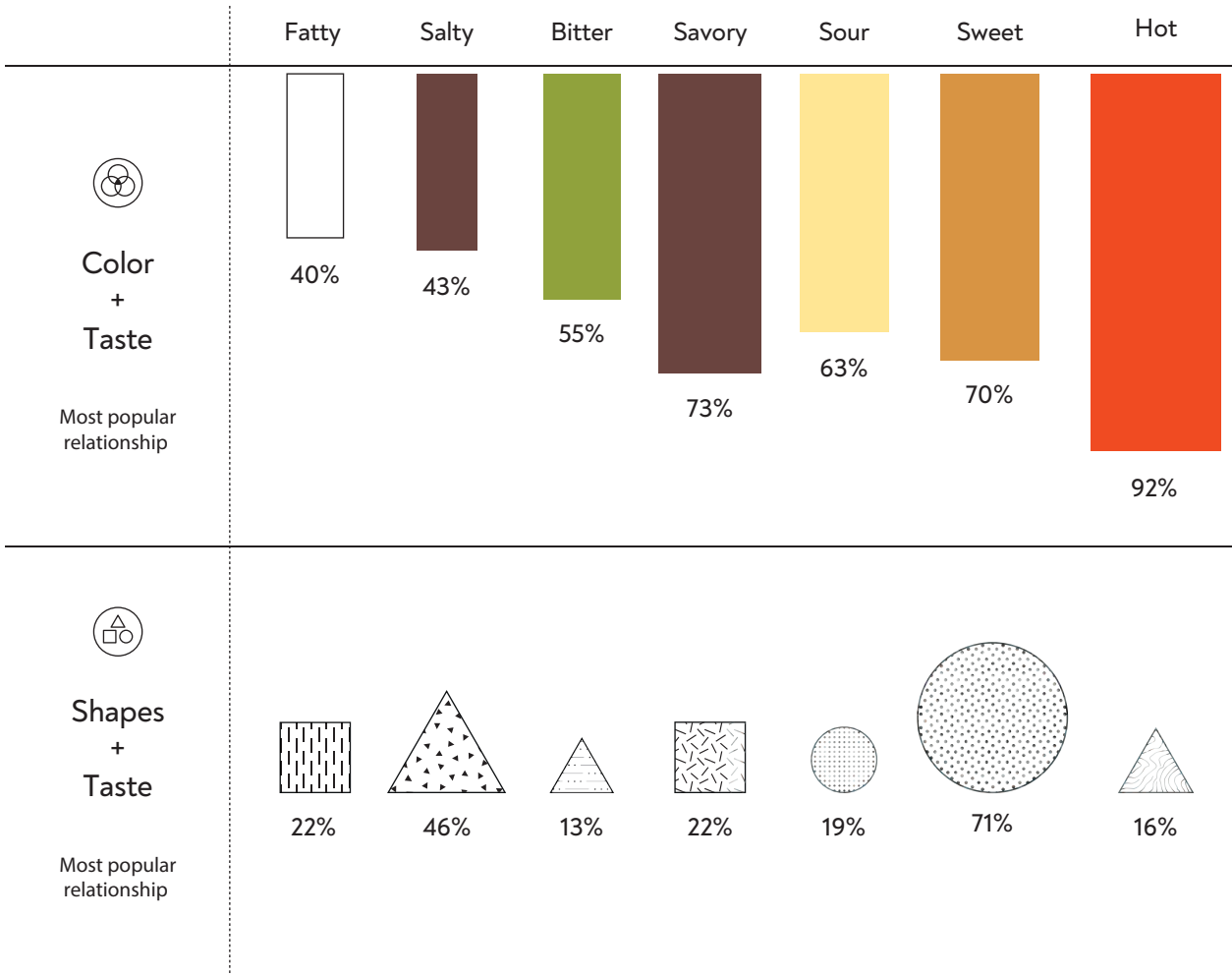
I often play with shapes when I compose my photos. In image 1, a set of circular shapes in the form of serveware focuses the eye's attention to the mayonnaise in the bowl, while the knife on the side adds subtle detail as it intersects them. In image 2, different types of quadrilateral shapes create a mazelike effect and the illusion that the cake is being lifted and presented. In both images, neutral backdrops let the colorful food take center stage.



Note how the yellow, green (image 1) & the golden-brown (image 2) colors pop out in these two photos and everything else draws your attention to the food.

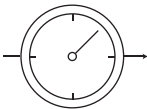
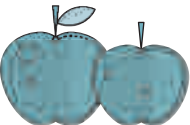
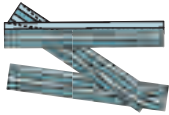
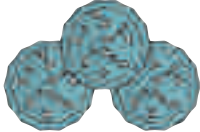
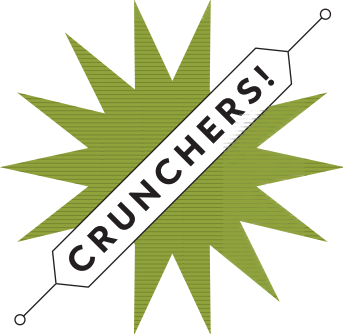
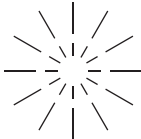
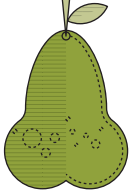
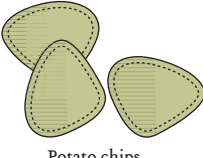
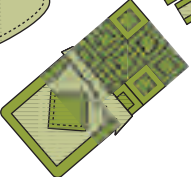
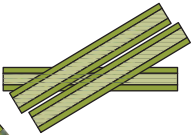
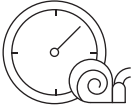
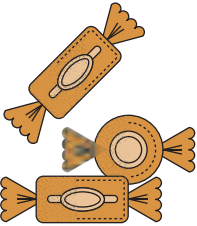
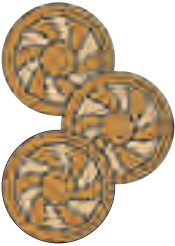
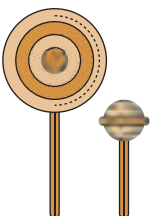
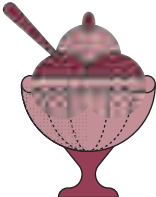
CASE STUDY: THE TASTE OF COLORS AND SHAPES

Over time, we start to associate not only colors but also shapes with the food we eat. Inspired by the work of experimental psychologist Charles Spence at Crossmodal Research Laboratory at the University of Oxford in the United Kingdom, who studies how people perceive flavor with respect to their environment, I ran a short experiment—an informal scientific poll. I asked a bunch of people a few questions on what tastes they most commonly associated with different colors and shapes. The results were interesting. In some cases, the answers were more obvious, as a lot of our perceptions are based on observations we notice in our environment. For example, among the responses, the color green implied bitter (bitter greens), while sharper-edged forms like triangles were associated with salty (salt crystals).



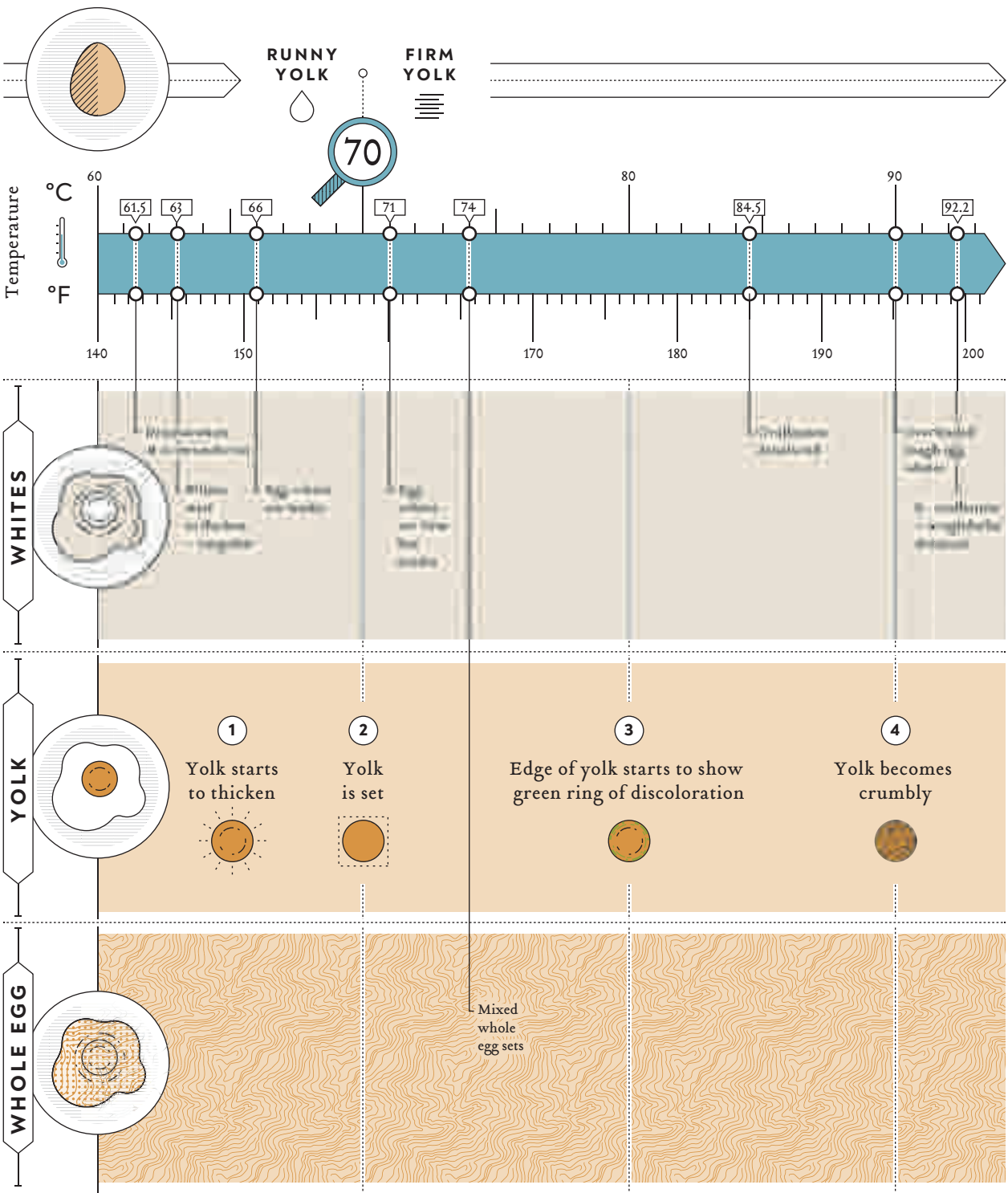
FOOD MOUTHFEEL CATEGORIES

Some scientists classify us by our preference for different food textures.

Category	Prefer	Examples of food
	 Food that can be chewed for a long time	 Gummy bears  Apples  String cheese  Oatmeal cookies  Brownies
	 Food that is crunchy	 Crisp apples and pears  Potato chips  Chocolate with nuts  Celery sticks
	 Food that dissolves slowly	 Hard candies  Peppermints  Lollipops
	 Food that is creamy	 Ice cream  Greek yogurt  Bananas  Custards and pudding

EGG PROTEIN CHART

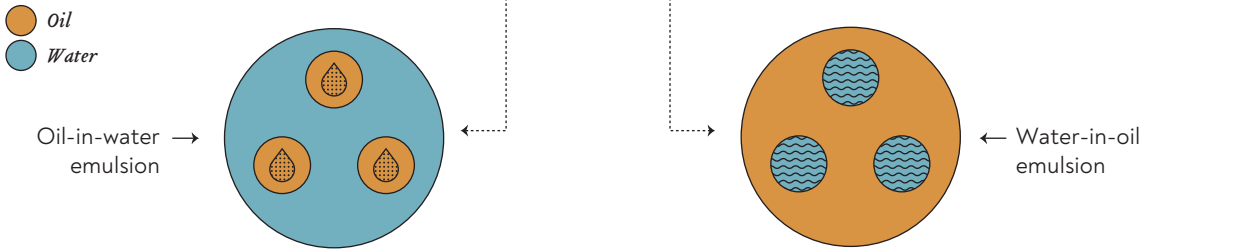
Physical and chemical changes that occur in eggs during heating.



OIL AND WATER EMULSIONS

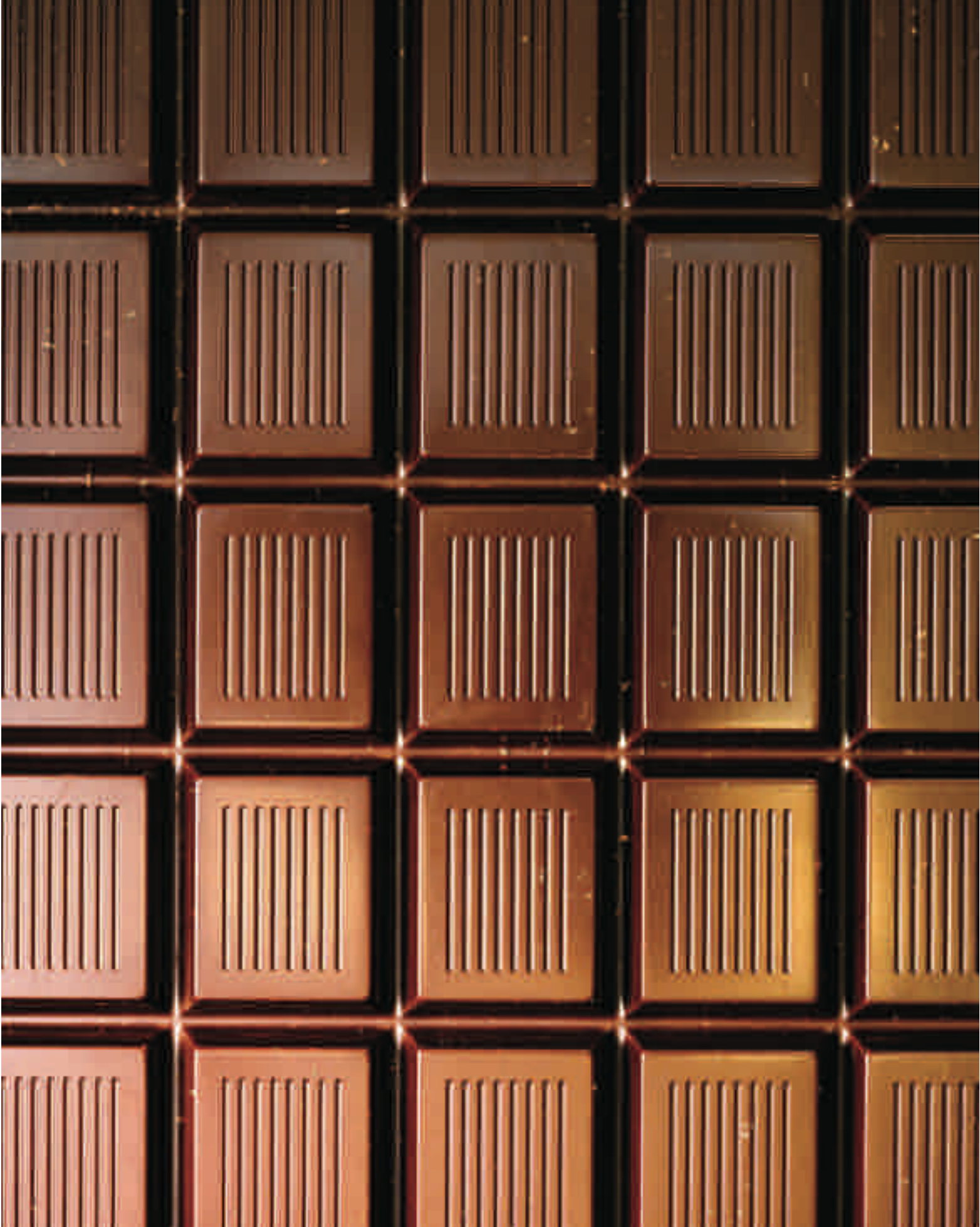
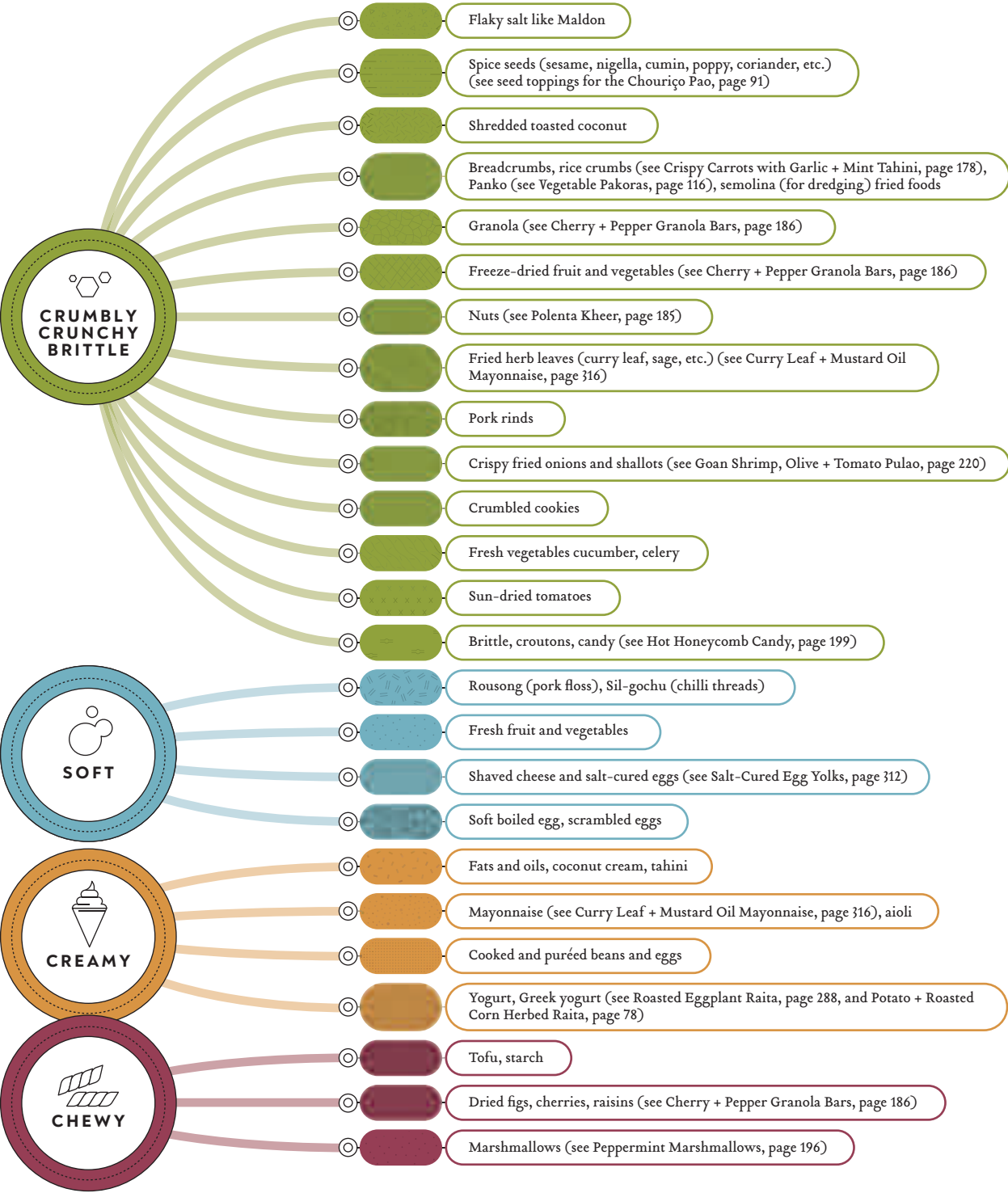
A closer look at some of the emulsions we prepare in the kitchen.

Food	Water	Food Emulsion	Emulsifying Agent
Mayonnaise	Oil + Vinegar	Oil-in-water	Egg yolk (proteins + lecithin); some recipes use mustard powder (mucilage)
Aioli	Oil + Vinegar	Oil-in-water	Egg yolk (proteins + lecithin), mustard powder (mucilage), garlic (pectin)
Toum	Oil + Lemon juice	Water-in-oil	Garlic (pectin)
Tomato vinaigrette	Oil + Vinegar	Water-in-oil	Tomato (pectin), garlic (pectin)



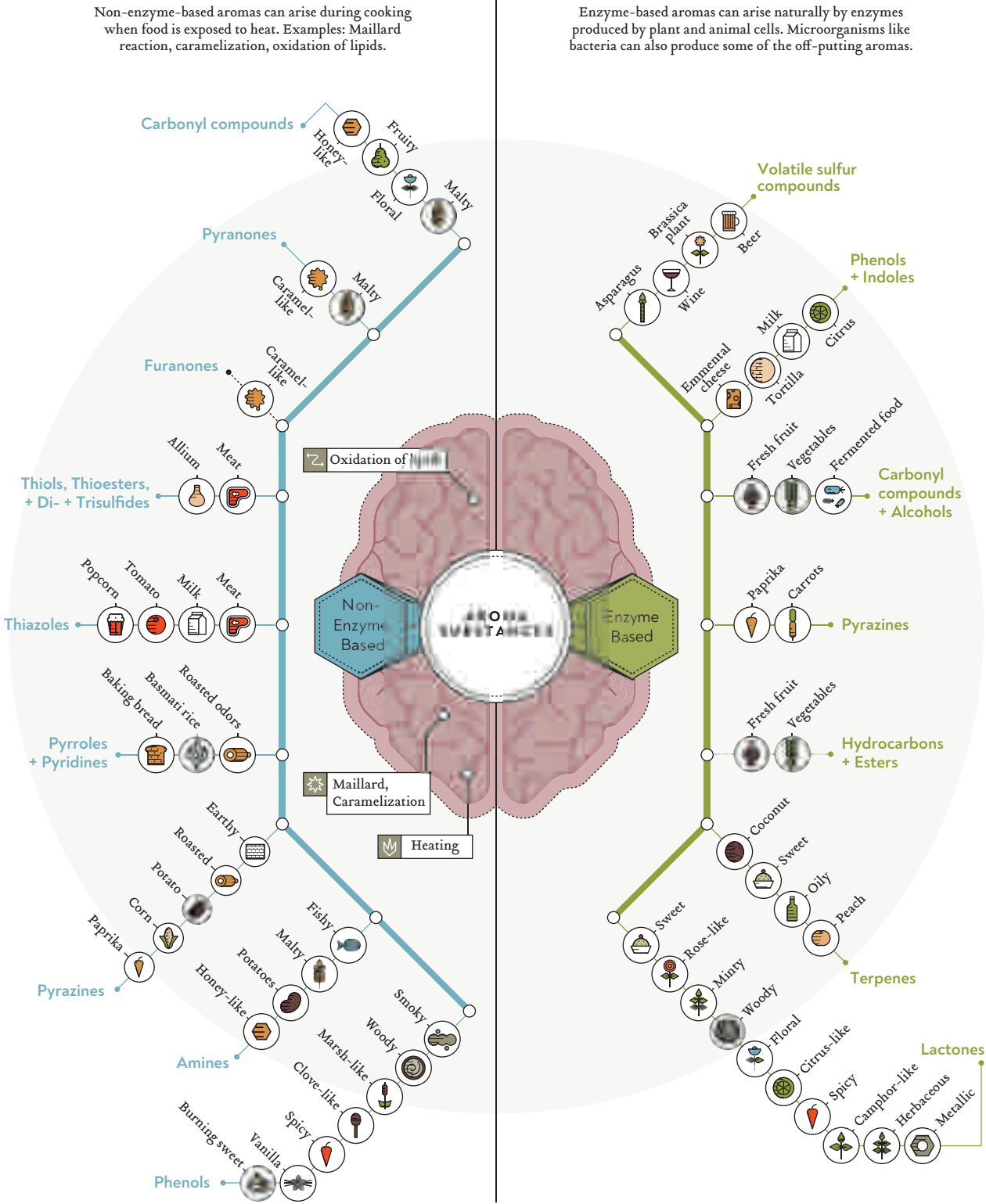
A FEW COMMON TEXTURE BOOSTERS USED IN COOKING

Cooking food involves appreciating and creating textures. Here are some of the different ingredients that add various textures to our food.



AROMAS BY CHEMICAL STRUCTURE

The aromas in our food are built by various cooking methods or naturally through biochemical reactions.



MAKE YOUR OWN FLAVORING EXTRACTS

Extracts are made by adding the flavoring ingredients to alcohol, which acts as a solvent to dissolve and draw out the aromatic molecules from these ingredients, and the end result is a concentrated liquid rich in aroma. A little bit of these flavoring agents goes a long way. Always store extracts in a cool, dark place away from sunlight, which can destroy some of the aromatic molecules over time. I prefer to store all my extracts in dark amber glass jars to avoid damage from all sources of light. Once infusing is complete, you can divide and store the liquid in smaller bottles or jars.

Vanilla Extract

MAKES 1 CUP [240 ML]

6 good-quality vanilla beans

1 cup [240 ml] clear unflavored vodka or rum

Cut the pod in half lengthwise, scrape out the seeds, and transfer the pods and the seeds to a small, dry glass container that can be sealed so it is airtight. Pour in the vodka and press the beans down to submerge them completely. Seal tightly and shake. Store in a cool, dark place for 6 to 8 weeks before using; shake occasionally. Discard the pods and use the liquid with the seeds as a flavoring extract in desserts.

Citrus Extract

MAKES ½ CUP [120 ML]

2 large lemons, limes, or navel oranges, or 3 oz fresh peels

½ cup [120 ml] clear unflavored vodka

If using oranges, rinse them under cold running water. Using a citrus zester, extract the zest and place it in a small, dry glass container that can be sealed so it is airtight. Pour the vodka over the peels and press down to submerge. Seal the lid tightly and shake. Store in a cool, dark place for 6 to 8 weeks; shake occasionally. Strain the liquid before using.

VARIATION: EXTRACTING BY HEAT

USING SOUS VIDE The preceding methods are cold extraction; you can also use heat extraction, which reduces the time required to extract the aromatic molecules and gives you better control of the process. Prepare your extracts as for cold extraction but in heat-proof jars, such as canning jars. Set up the sous vide device in a container filled with water, place the jars in the bath, and heat to 130°F [55°C]. (The boiling point of pure alcohol is 173.1°F [78.4°C], but since vodka is an 80 proof [40%] mixture of water and alcohol, the liquid behaves a bit differently. Vodka will boil at 212°F [100°C], which is actually nearer the boiling point of water.) Let the ingredients infuse in the water bath for 4 hours. A few minutes before the infusions are done warming, prepare a separate bath containing ice water. Transfer the infused jars to the ice water bath to chill completely. Strain the chilled liquid, transfer to dark amber jars, and store.

Green Cardamom Extract

MAKES ½ CUP [120 ML]

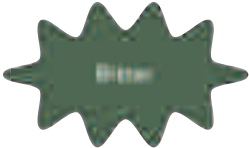
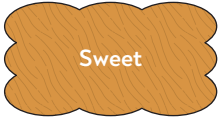
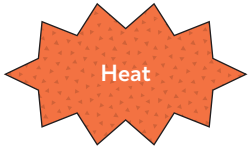
20 green cardamom pods, coarsely cracked

½ cup [120 ml] clear unflavored vodka

Place the cardamom husks and cracked seeds into a small, dry glass container that can be sealed so it is airtight. Pour the vodka over the cardamom, seal the lid tightly, and shake. Store in a cool, dark place for 6 to 8 weeks; shake occasionally. Strain the liquid before using.

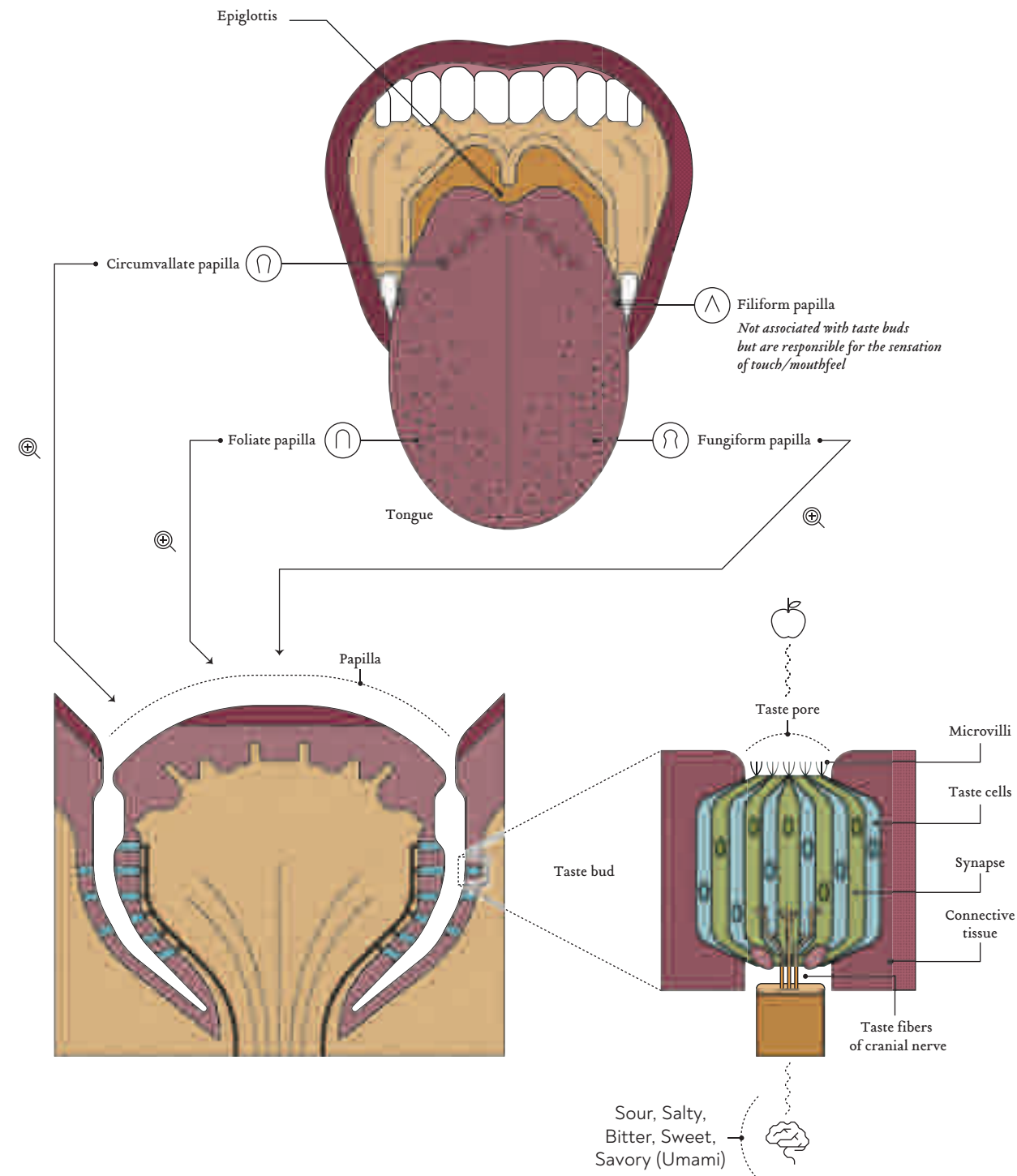
TYPES OF TASTE

Beyond providing pleasurable flavors in our food, our tastes (including Richness and Fieriness) evolved as tools to guide and protect us.

Taste	Flavor	Function
 BRIGHTNESS		 Protects us from toxins and harmful foods
 BITTERNESS		 Protects us from toxins and harmful foods
 SALTINESS		 Important for nervous system function
 SWEETNESS		 Provides energy and nutrition
 SAVORINESS		 Provides energy and nutrition by motivating protein intake
 RICHNESS <i>currently not classified as a taste</i>		 The role of fat receptors and taste is still unclear; potential roles include energy and nutrition, and protection from fats and oils that are degraded and potentially harmful
 FIERINESS <i>(chemestheris—not a taste)</i>		 The jury is still out on this one, but part of it might be our desire to seek thrills; chillies can taste hot, but we know we're not in any real danger when we eat them

HOW TASTE BUDS WORK

On the tongue are tiny, bumpy projections called papillae. Of the four types of papillae, only circumvallate, foliate, and fungiform are associated with taste buds. Filiform papillae are responsible for appreciating the textures in our food (mouthfeel). Each papilla contains a collection of taste buds which in turn contains the taste pore, through which the taste cells and nerves sense the different tastes in our food.

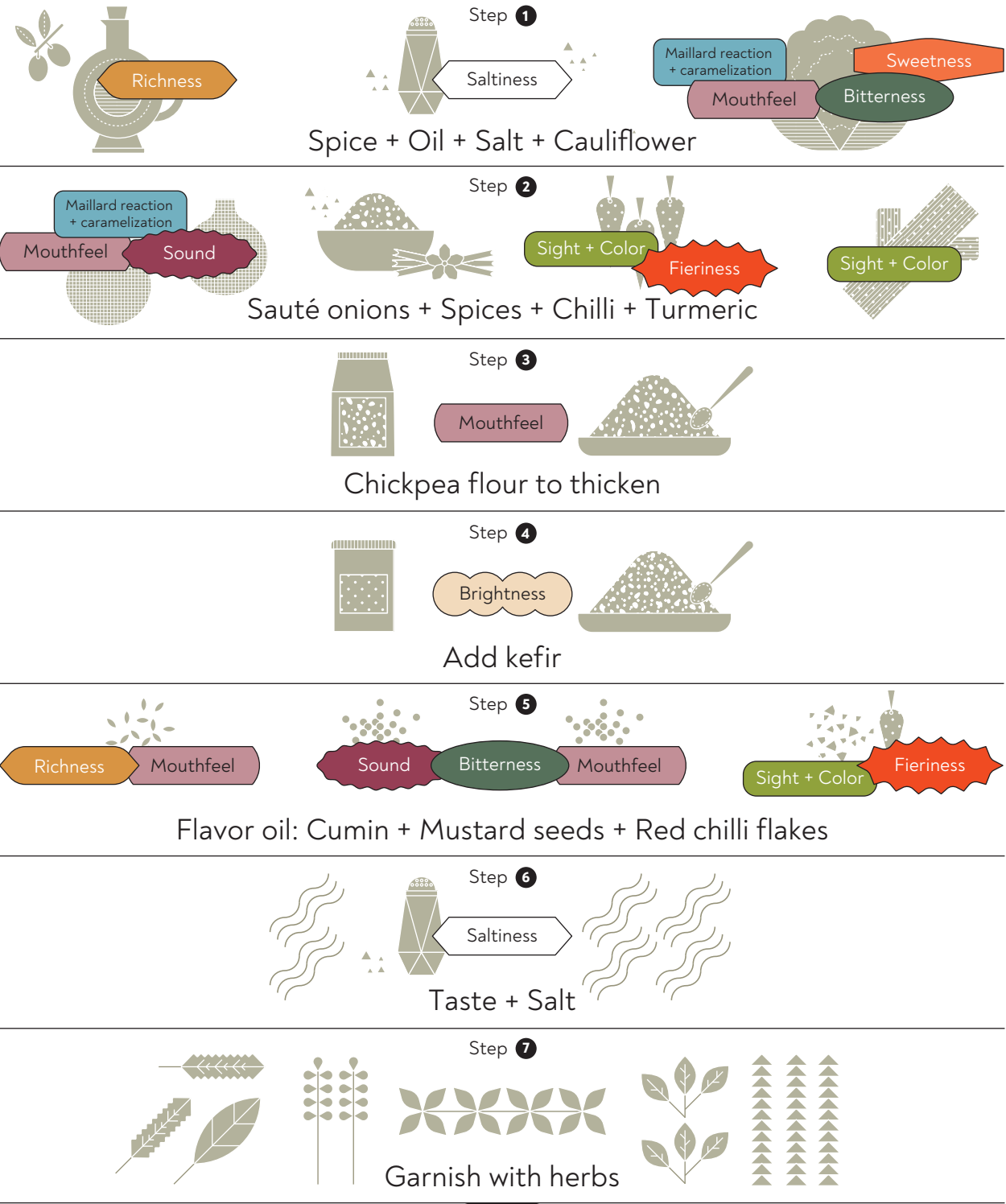


II. RECIPES + THE ANATOMY OF FLAVOR



ANATOMY OF A RECIPE

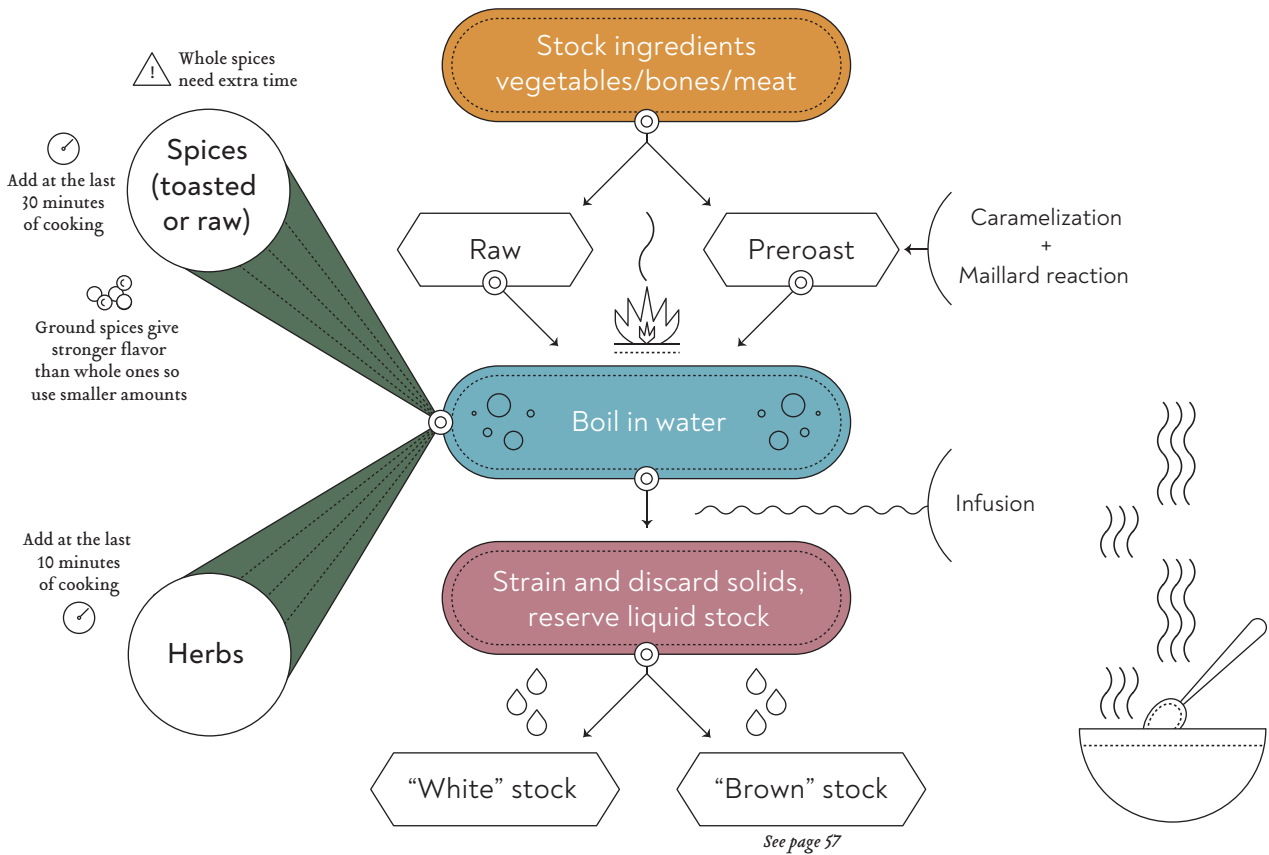
A recipe is made up of many parts: the ingredients, the cooking methods used, and our senses and emotions working in concert.



EMOTION! HAPPINESS!

FLAVOR MAP OF A STOCK

Use this as a general guide to help build flavor in your stocks.



1	2	3	4	5	6
Select bones (if using)	Select base vegetables	Select primary spices	Select umami boosters	Select an acid (pick one)	Add a color (optional)
Leftover chicken or turkey bones	Onion	Ginger	Whole tomatoes	Vinegar	Saffron
Beef bones	Leeks	Black peppercorns	Seaweed kombu/nori	Lemon	Turmeric
Fish bones, shrimp peels	Flat-leaf parsley	Cloves	Miso	Lime	
Roast in oven	Celery	Bay leaves	Bonito flakes		
450°F [232°C] for 25 to 30 minutes	Carrots		Parmesan rinds		
for fish bones, use 400°F [230°C] for 15 to 20 minutes		Select secondary spices	Tea (black tea/matcha)		
		Star anise	Dried shiitake		
		Green cardamom			
		Black cardamom			
		Curry leaves			
					7
					Salt

BASIC UMAMI/SAVORY RICH “BROWN” VEGETABLE STOCK

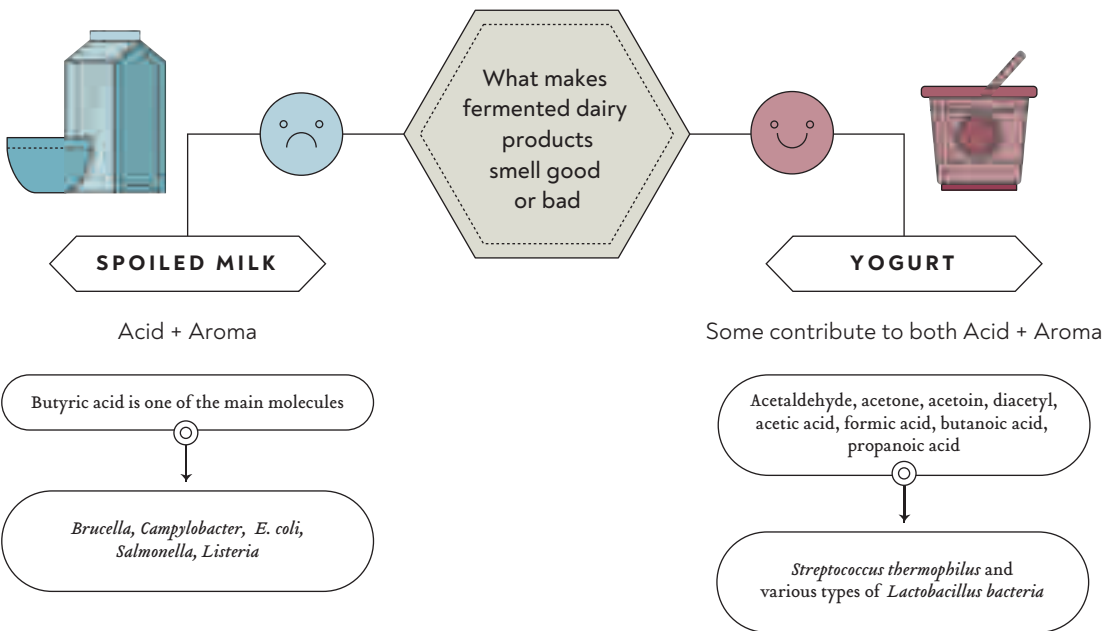
This is a very simple way to create a vegetable stock with a rich umami taste. There are two parts to building the flavors in this stock. The first involves steeping the dried shiitake in water maintained between 140°F and 158°F [60°C and 70°C] to allow the ribonuclease enzyme to produce the umami nucleotides. The second part is to apply the caramelization and Maillard reactions to the vegetables and sauté them in the absence of any added water or oil over low heat. This produces brown-colored pigments, and the bittersweet and aroma molecules along with the umami molecules give this vegetable stock its rich meaty profile.



1

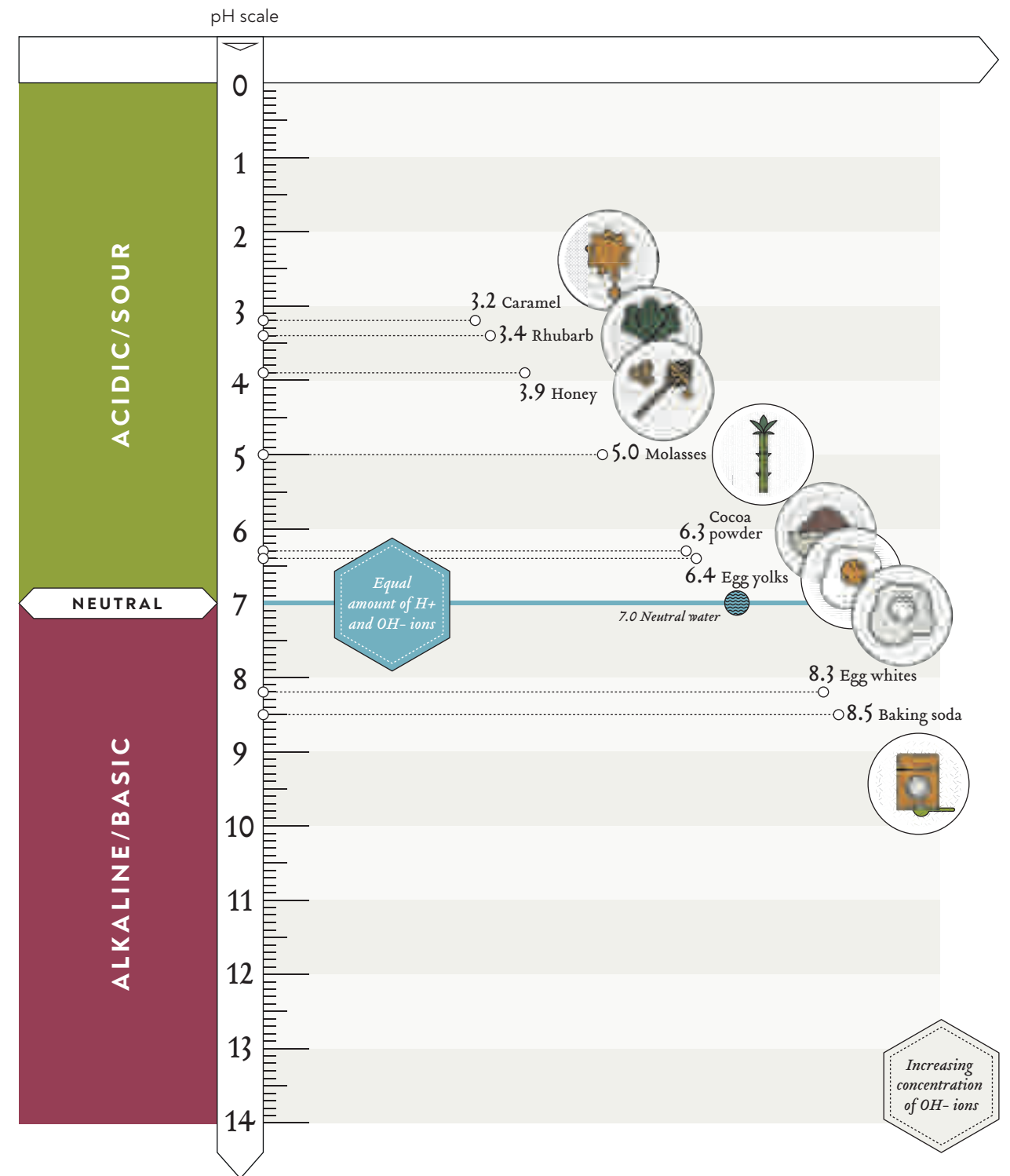
BRIGHTNESS





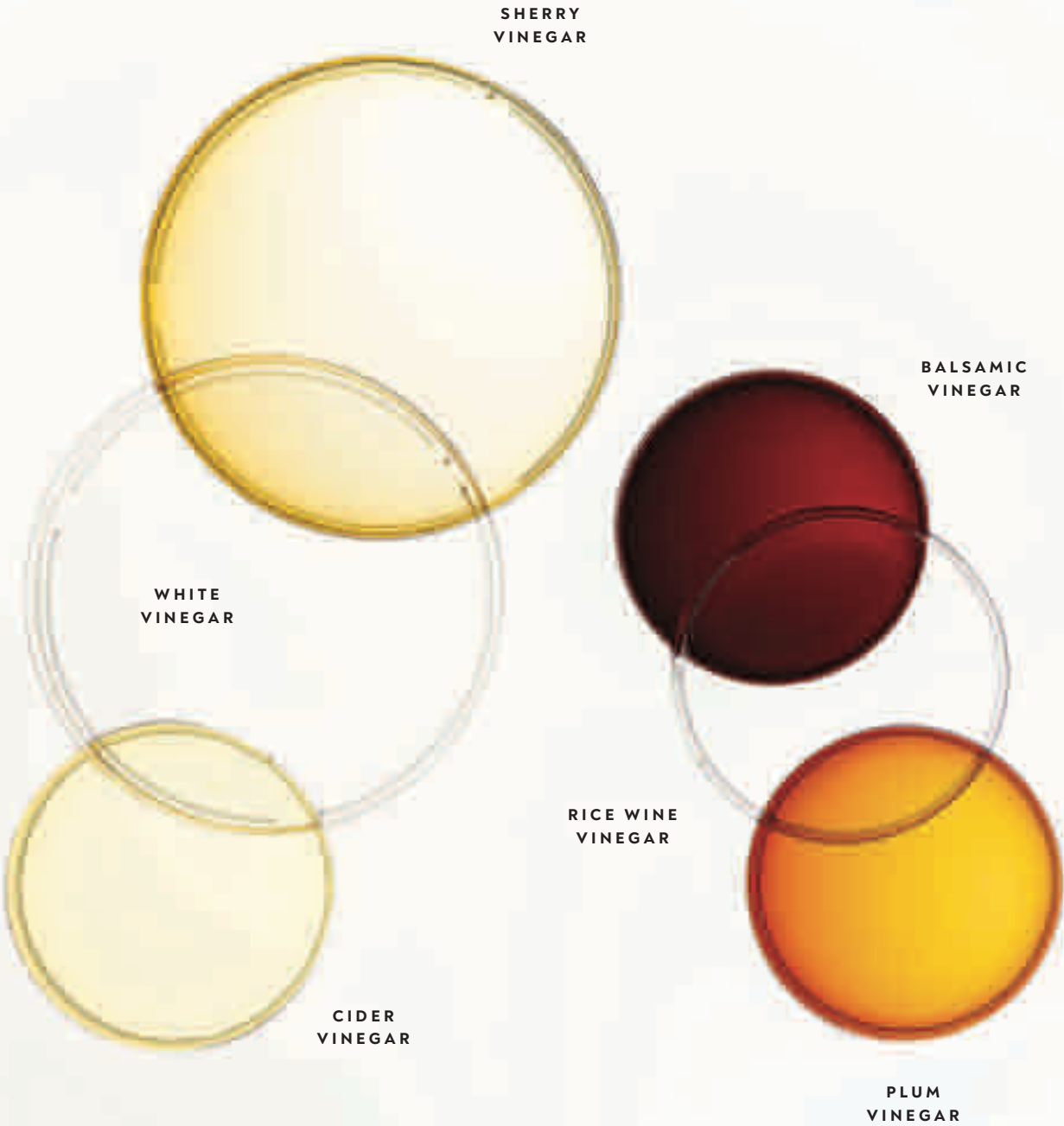
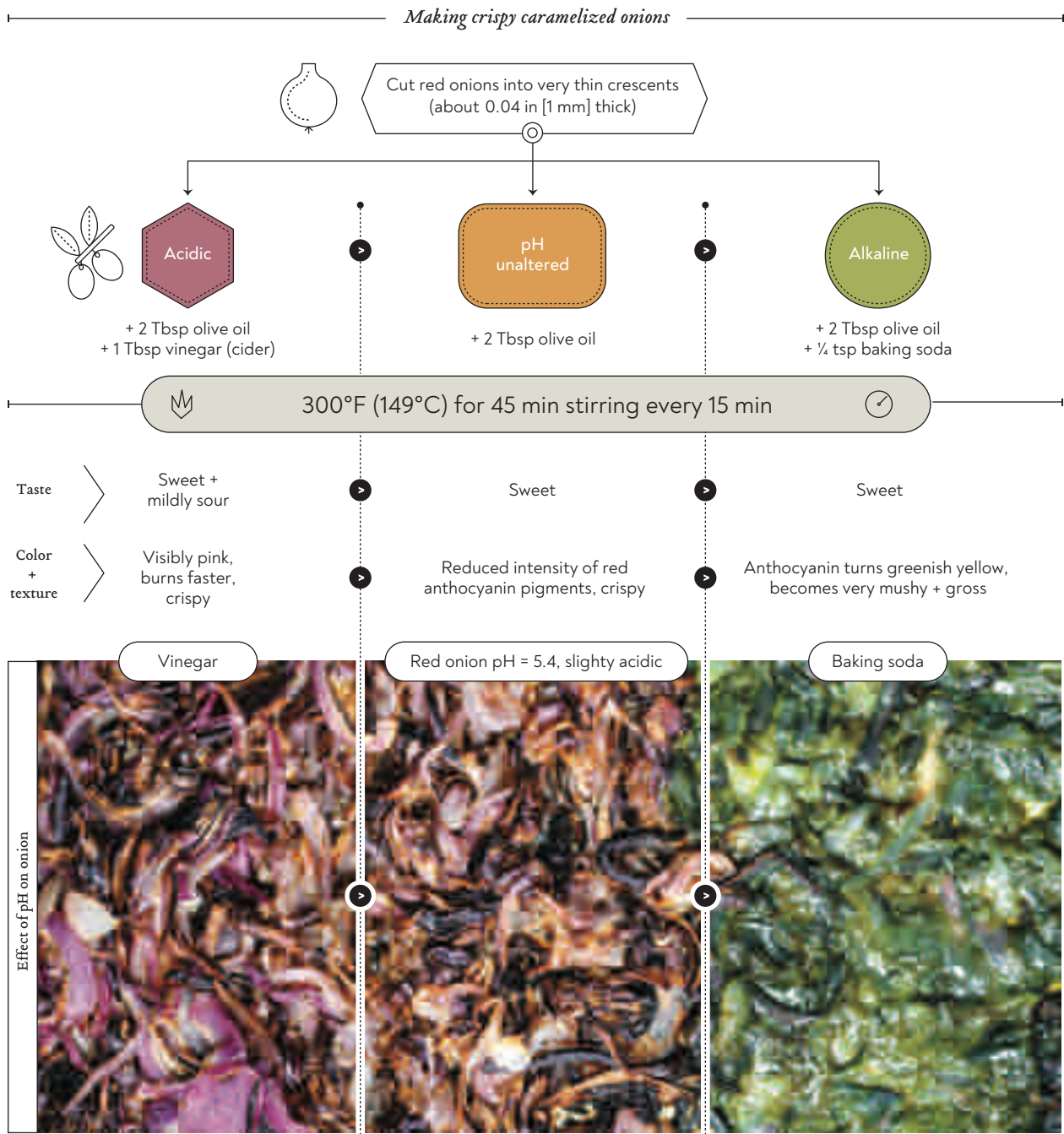
THE pH SCALE

The pH scale tells us how acidic (sour) or alkaline (basic) a substance is. Water is neutral.
Most foods we eat are acidic (with varying strengths).

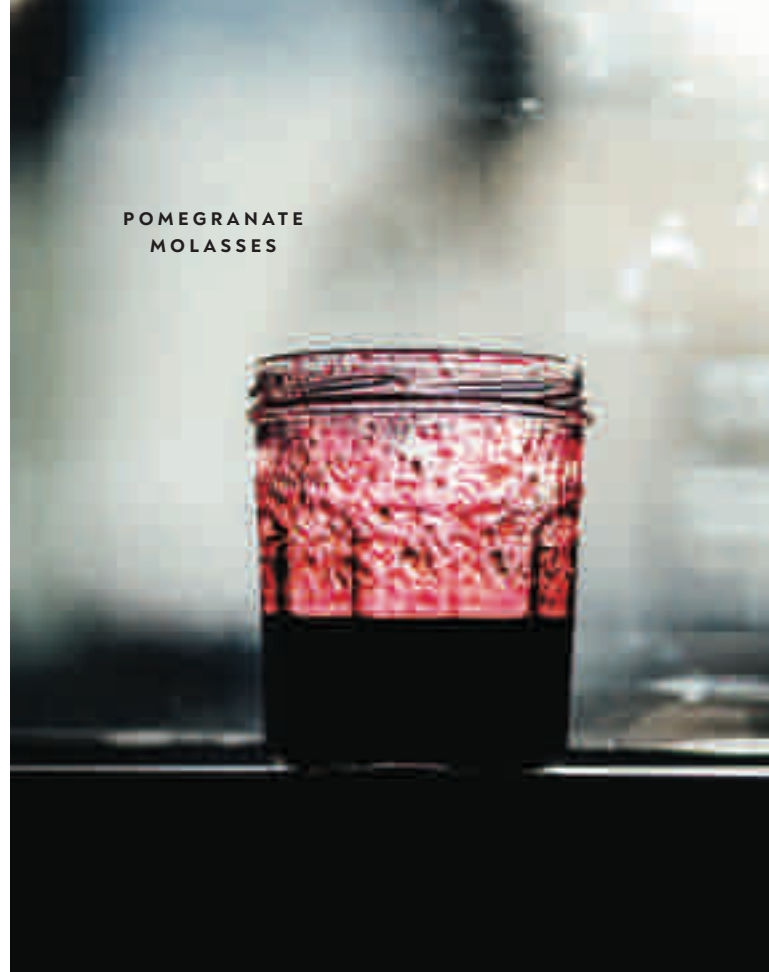


CASE STUDY: EFFECT OF PH ON
THE COLOR AND TEXTURE OF ONIONS

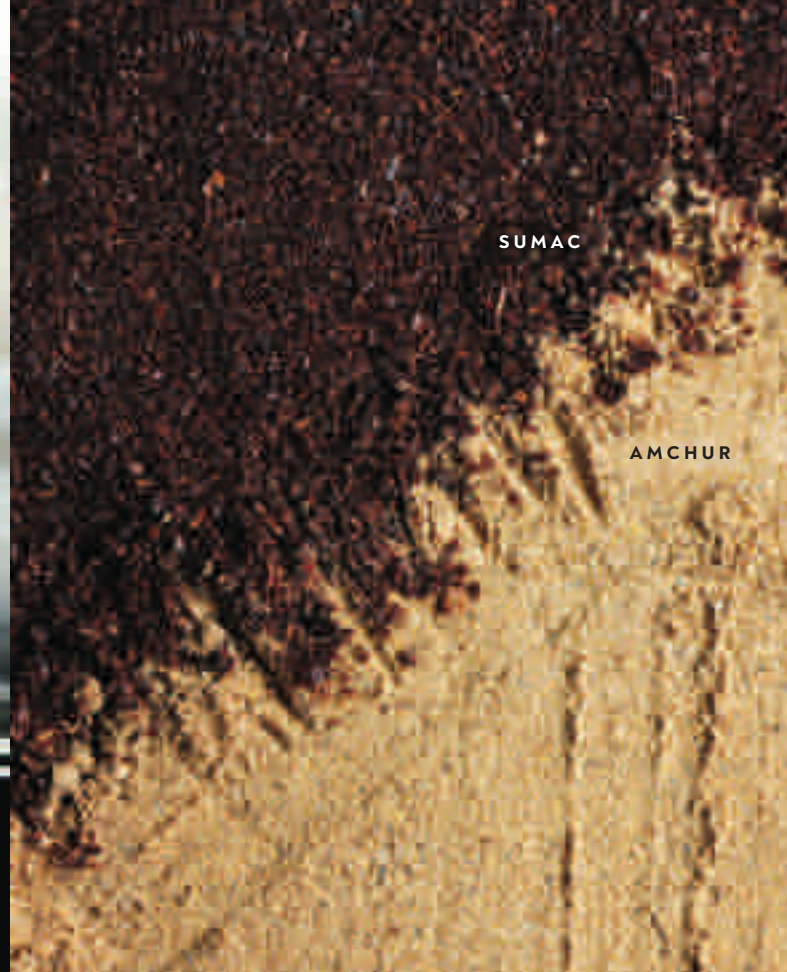
While writing this book, I did a fun experiment with caramelizing onions to demonstrate the effect of acidity in cooking. I caramelize onions with two different techniques, depending on the texture I need. For soft, jammy onions, I cook them slowly over medium heat for a long time. For crispy caramelized onions, I spread sliced onions in a thin layer on a baking sheet and bake them until crispy in a 300°F [149°C] oven. Onions are rich in sugars such as fructose, fructans (polymers of fructose), and glucose, which reveal their taste on heating. Spreading the onions in a thin layer facilitates evaporation for crispiness.



POMEGRANATE
MOLASSES



SUMAC



AMCHUR



TOMATO IN ITS
VARIOUS FORMS



OMANI LIMES



Grilled Hearts of Romaine with Chilli Pumpkin Seeds

I find grilling to be pure pleasure and one of the most enjoyable acts in cooking. There's the sizzling sound when cold food hits the blazing grate and the aroma of new substances created as it burns and reacts on contact. Romaine lettuce hearts take on a completely new flavor when grilled in this salad. I use a grilling pan, but you can most certainly make this on an outdoor grill.

SERVES 4

For the chilli pumpkin seeds:

¼ cup [35 g] raw pumpkin seeds

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

½ tsp ground paprika

Fine sea salt

1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa

For the garlic yogurt dressing (makes 1 cup [240 ml]):

¾ cup [180 g] plain, full-fat Greek yogurt

¼ cup [60 g] crème fraîche

2 Tbsp pomegranate molasses

2 Tbsp fresh lime juice

2 garlic cloves, peeled and grated

½ tsp ground turmeric

Fine sea salt

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil, plus extra to brush the grates of the grill

2 hearts of romaine lettuce

1 lime, halved

2 Tbsp shaved Parmesan, for garnish (optional)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Grilling the lettuce and lime adds depth via the caramelization and Maillard reactions.

The lime juice and lactic acid from the Greek yogurt offset the rich, creamy texture of fat and proteins.

Parmesan provides a hint of salty and savory, due to its high free glutamate content.

Heat changes the mouthfeel of the lettuce; the leaves will turn a little soft, while the midrib retains its crunchiness.

To prepare the seeds, heat a small skillet over medium heat. In a small bowl, mix the pumpkin seeds, olive oil, and paprika. Season with salt. Add the seeds to the hot pan and sauté until they start to turn golden brown, 1 to 1½ minutes. Remove from the heat, add the chilli flakes, toss to coat well, and spread the seeds out on a plate to cool.

To prepare the dressing, combine the yogurt, crème fraîche, pomegranate molasses, lime juice, garlic, and turmeric in a blender. Pulse for a few seconds until completely smooth. Taste and season with salt.

Heat a grilling pan over medium-high heat. Brush the pan with a little olive oil. Cut the lettuce in half

lengthwise and brush the surface of the lettuce and the lime halves with oil. Place the lettuce halves, cut-side down, on the hot pan until the lettuce develops nice char marks, then flip, 2 to 2½ minutes per side. Remove from the heat and season with salt. Place the limes on the hot surface of the grilling pan and sear until they start to develop a few char marks from the grill, about 1 minute.

To serve, place the lettuce on a large serving dish. Drizzle a few tablespoons of the garlic yogurt dressing over the lettuce. Sprinkle the pumpkin seeds and Parmesan, if desired, on top. Place the grilled limes on the side along with the remaining dressing. Serve immediately.

Chickpea Salad with Date + Tamarind Dressing

Street food occupies a celebrated position in India's cuisine, and it is as rich in flavor as it is diverse, from the hot and spicy succulent meat kebabs served on soft *roomali* rotis (a handkerchief-thin flat bread) to the sweet-and-sour tastes of *chaat*. Rather than spending my time eating in restaurants, I make it a point to indulge in street food on every trip. The dressing in this salad is loosely inspired by the ingredients and flavors used in India's street food.

SERVES 2 TO 4

For the dressing:

¼ cup [60 ml] date syrup,
homemade (page 324) or
store-bought

1 Tbsp tamarind paste,
homemade (see page 67)
or store-bought

1 Tbsp fresh lime juice

1 tsp ground ginger

Fine sea salt

For the chickpea salad:

One 15½ oz [445 g] can
chickpeas, drained and rinsed

1 cucumber (about 12 oz
[340 g]), diced

1 shallot (2 oz [60 g]), minced

2 Tbsp fresh dill leaves

2 Tbsp fresh mint leaves

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as
Aleppo

½ tsp amchur powder

½ tsp coarsely ground black
pepper

Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The acidity comes from sour fruits such as tamarind, lime, and amchur (dried mango powder). Lime juice and tamarind contain two powerful cooking acids—citric and tartaric acids—that add sourness to the dressing along with their fruity notes.

When you taste and season the dressing, make a mental note and observe how much salt you use, as sourness changes the perception of saltiness.

Fresh mint and dill provide a cooler note with their essential oils that act on our nerve endings via chemesthesis. Black pepper, ginger, and the red chillies also act via chemesthesis but provide warmer notes.

For an extra dose of heat, mince and fold in a fresh green chilli.

To prepare the dressing, whisk the date syrup, tamarind paste, lime juice, and ginger in a small bowl. If the dressing is too thick, stir in 1 to 2 Tbsp of water. Taste and season with salt. If making ahead, store in an airtight container for up to 1 week and warm the dressing to room temperature before using.

To prepare the chickpea salad, in a large bowl, toss the chickpeas, cucumber, shallot, dill, and mint with the olive oil, red chilli flakes, amchur, and black pepper. Taste and season with salt. Transfer to a serving plate and drizzle 2 Tbsp of the dressing over the salad; serve the rest on the side. Serve immediately.



Green Beans with Preserved Lemons + Crème Fraîche

I get more excited about preparing the sides and desserts for our Thanksgiving dinner than anything else. Although the base ingredients for our sides remain constant, I change the flavors every year. In this spin on green beans, preserved lemons give a bright pop against the splendid creaminess of crème fraîche. You can make your own preserved lemons (page 318) or pick them up from a Middle Eastern market, and they're now available at most grocery stores. For a bit of added savory salty goodness, garnish the green beans with a generous pinch of bonito flakes just before serving.

SERVES 4

- 3 shallots (total weight 6½ oz [180 g])
- 3 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- Fine sea salt
- 1½ lb [680 g] green beans, trimmed
- 1 tsp black poppy seeds
- 2 Tbsp preserved lemons, homemade (page 318) or store-bought, diced (see headnote)
- 8½ oz [240 g] crème fraîche
- 1 garlic clove, peeled and grated
- ½ tsp coarsely cracked black pepper

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The chlorophyll pigment of green beans becomes much more visible and brilliant in intensity after the beans are blanched in boiling water (see Sight, page 21).

Preserved lemons provide a concentrated spot of acid and salt that add contrast to the much more mellow flavors of the green beans and crème fraîche.

Crème fraîche provides fat as well as tang from its lactic acid.

Crunchy textures come from the green beans, crispy shallots, and poppy seeds.

Preheat the oven to 300°F [149°C]. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper.

Trim and discard the ends of the shallots and cut them into thin slices. In a small bowl, toss the shallots with 2 Tbsp of the olive oil and season with salt. Spread the shallots in a single layer on the prepared baking sheet and cook in the preheated oven until the shallots turn golden brown and crisp, 30 to 45 minutes. Stir and redistribute the shallots halfway through cooking to ensure even browning.

Fill a large bowl with ice and cold water and set aside.

Set a large pot of salted water over medium-high heat and bring to a rolling boil. When the water starts to boil, add the green beans and blanch them until the beans turn bright green and are tender but not overly soft, 2 or 3 minutes. Remove the green beans with a slotted spoon and immediately submerge them in the prepared ice water to stop them from cooking further.



Heat a small, dry saucepan or stainless-steel skillet over medium-high heat. Toast the poppy seeds until the seeds just start to get fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Remove from the heat and transfer the seeds to a small bowl. Scrape off and discard the pulp from the preserved lemons and rinse the peels under

running tap water to remove the excess salt. Pat them dry with a clean kitchen towel to absorb any excess water. Dice the lemon peels and add them to another small mixing bowl. Fold in the crème fraîche, garlic, and black pepper. Taste and season with salt as needed.

Remove the green beans from the ice bath and pat them dry with a clean kitchen towel. Toss the green beans with the remaining 1 Tbsp of olive oil and place them in a serving dish. Add the lemon–crème fraîche dressing and garnish with the crispy shallots and toasted poppy seeds.

Potato + Roasted Corn Herbed Raita

The cooling properties of rich, creamy yogurt mingled with its acidity makes raita an excellent side to accompany a hot and spicy meal. The brilliant green color from the fresh herbs scattered with the blistered kernels of bright yellow sweet corn and dusting of red chilli, along with the soft texture of potatoes, make this raita a colorful portrait of flavor and texture. Serve it chilled with any Indian meal—but truth be told, on days when it’s too hot to cook or I feel a bit lazy, I’ll eat an entire bowlful as a meal. The potato and corn can be prepared the night before to save time.

SERVES 4 AS A SIDE

- 1 (6¼ oz [190 g]) Yukon gold potato
- Fine sea salt
- 1 Tbsp grapeseed or other neutral oil
- 2 ears sweet corn (each approximately 8 oz [230 g]), husked
- 2 cups [480 g] chilled plain unsweetened Greek yogurt
- ½ cup [10 g] packed fresh mint leaves plus 1 Tbsp julienned for garnish
- ½ cup [10 g] packed cilantro
- 1 green chilli, such as serrano
- 2 Tbsp fresh lime juice
- ½ tsp black peppercorns
- ½ tsp red chilli powder

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Sweet corn is sweetest the day it is picked, but as it sits in storage, the sugars are converted to starch and its sweetness decreases. For most of us, it’s impossible to grab corn from the field; instead, buy it the day you plan to cook or freeze the corn kernels, as freezing stops the enzymes from converting sugar to starch.

A second method to determine the age of the sweet corn is to physically inspect the top pointy tip of the cob. If the top appears slightly dented, dry, and even grayish black, then the sugars are turning into starch and the corn won’t be as sweet.

Roasting corn builds new flavor molecules via caramelization and the Maillard reaction. Listen for the corn kernels to sizzle when they grill and char; that’s your cue to turn them.

Greek yogurt provides the creamy backdrop of the raita. I’ve always been a proponent of plain yogurt as the base for raitas; however, over the past few years I’ve noticed an increasing slimy texture in the whey that arises, due to the addition of stabilizers (which appears to be a trend with commercial brands). Greek yogurt, on the other hand, gives a richer and more luscious texture, since most of the whey has been removed and stabilizers are rarely added.

Scrub the potato and place it in a medium saucepan. Add enough cool water to cover it by 1 in [2.5 cm] and salt. Bring to a rolling boil over high heat, turn the heat to medium-low, and cover. Simmer the potato until completely tender, 25 to 30 minutes.

Carefully drain off the water and allow the potato to cool completely to room temperature. Once the potato is cooled, peel and discard the skin. Flake the potato with the prongs of a fork and season with salt.



While the potato is boiling, prepare the corn. Preheat a grill over medium-high heat and brush the grates with a little oil. Brush the remaining oil over the corn. Sear the corn cobs until they develop deep char marks all over, turning them over with a pair of tongs for 10 to 12 minutes. Remove the cobs from the grill and let rest for 5 minutes

to cool. Strip the corn kernels from the cob by slicing with a knife, and discard the cob. Cool completely. The vegetables must be cooled before they’re folded into the yogurt because heat can coagulate the dairy proteins.

In a blender, combine the yogurt, mint, cilantro, green chilli, lime juice,

and peppercorns on high speed until smooth. If the consistency is too thick, you can add a few tablespoons of chilled water. Taste for salt and adjust. Pour the herbed yogurt into a medium bowl. Fold in the cooled flaked potato and roasted corn. Garnish with the remaining mint and sprinkle with the chilli powder. Serve chilled.

Herb + Paneer Pulao

I find that a pulao, or pilaf, has a lot of advantages; you can serve it as the “fancy” rice to accompany a dinner for guests, or you can tweak it to make it a complete one-pot dish that doesn’t require sides—perhaps just a small bowl of plain salted yogurt or a bit of pickle.

SERVES 4 TO 6

- 2 cups [400 g] basmati rice
- 4 Tbsp [60 ml] grapeseed or other neutral oil
- 4 cloves, ground
- ½ tsp ground green cardamom
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground black pepper
- 1 medium yellow or white onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), cut in half and thinly sliced
- 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated
- 4 garlic cloves, peeled and minced
- 1 to 2 green chillies such as serrano, minced
- Fine sea salt
- 14 oz [400 g] paneer, homemade (use firm paneer, see case study page 334) or store-bought, cut into ½ in [12 mm] cubes
- ¼ cup [10 g] packed chopped cilantro leaves or flat-leaf parsley
- ¼ cup [2.5 g] packed chopped dill leaves
- ¼ cup [10 g] packed chopped mint leaves
- ¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lime juice
- Lime zest, for garnish (optional)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

There are a few tips that make this rice dish extremely aromatic. Start with aged basmati (rice that is labeled at least one year old). Grind your spices and chop your herbs just before you cook. Rinsing the rice gently removes the fine dust of starch created as rice grains rub against each other during transport and storage; this starchy powder can cause the grains to stick to each other while cooking. This step, plus frying the rice grains in oil and resisting the urge to disturb the rice too much as it cooks, will give you cooked grains that are separate and delicately tender.

The aromatic spices that give this pulao its perfume are first heated in hot oil to draw out the aromatic substances.

Fresh lime juice is added toward the end of this dish as a garnishing acid. If added early on, the acid will lose its aroma and the flavor will not be as fresh. For increased lime aroma, add a little lime zest before serving.

Halloumi is a good substitute for paneer because it is firm and will hold its shape on heating, but it can be a bit salty, so adjust your seasoning accordingly.

Pick through the rice for any stones or debris, then rinse it in a fine-mesh sieve under cool running tap water until the runoff is clear. Transfer to a large bowl, cover with 4 cups [960 ml] of water, and soak for 30 minutes.

Set up one large and one medium saucepan on the stove. Heat 2 Tbsp of the oil in the large saucepan over medium-high heat. Add the cloves, cardamom, cinnamon, and black

pepper and sauté until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Drain the soaked rice and add it to the large saucepan. Fry the rice, stirring until the grains are completely coated in the oil and don’t stick to each other, 1 to 1½ minutes. Add the onions and sauté until they just start to turn a light golden brown, 8 to 10 minutes. Add the ginger, garlic, and chilli and sauté until fragrant, about 1 minute. Add 4 cups [960 ml] water and season with salt. Bring the water to

a rolling boil. Lower the heat to a gentle simmer, cover the saucepan, and cook until most of the water has evaporated, 10 to 12 minutes. Remove from the heat.

While the rice is cooking, prepare the paneer. Heat the remaining 2 Tbsp of oil in the medium saucepan over medium-high heat. Once the oil is hot, fry the paneer cubes in batches until they turn golden brown on

each side, 8 to 10 minutes. Remove the paneer with a slotted spoon and place them on a plate or tray lined with absorbent paper to absorb any excess oil. Season the fried paneer with salt.

Fold the paneer, cilantro, dill, and mint into the cooked rice. Drizzle with the lime juice, sprinkle with zest, if desired, and serve warm.





Roasted Cauliflower in Turmeric Kefir

This recipe takes advantage of kefir (buttermilk can be substituted) for its bright acidity. I prefer to use a bottle of freshly opened kefir or buttermilk here, because as these liquids age, the lactic acid increases, which not only leaves a strong tart taste but also causes the milk proteins to curdle quickly on heating. If you have leftover kefir, use it to make the Blueberry + Omani Lime Ice Cream (page 98).

SERVES 4

2 lb [910 g] cauliflower, broken into bite-size florets

1 tsp garam masala, homemade (page 312) or store-bought

Fine sea salt

4 Tbsp [60 ml] grapeseed or other neutral oil

5¼ oz [150 g] minced red onion

½ tsp ground turmeric

½ tsp red chilli powder (optional)

¼ cup [30 g] chickpea flour

2 cups [480 ml] fresh kefir or buttermilk

½ tsp cumin seeds

½ tsp black or brown mustard seeds

1 tsp red chilli flakes

2 Tbsp chopped cilantro or flat-leaf parsley

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Using the acidity of fermented dairy such as kefir and the Maillard reaction creates a bittersweet taste and new aroma molecules in vegetables.

Chickpea flour, which contains starch, acts as a thickener for the base of the sauce.

The sound of the seeds sizzling is a good indicator of how hot your oil is; if the oil is hot enough, they will sizzle immediately and brown quickly.

Preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C].

Place the cauliflower in a roasting pan or baking dish. Sprinkle with the garam masala, season with salt, and toss to coat. Drizzle with 1 Tbsp of the oil and toss to coat evenly. Roast the cauliflower for 20 to 30 minutes, until golden brown and slightly charred. Stir the florets halfway through roasting.

While the cauliflower is roasting, place a deep, medium saucepan or Dutch oven over medium-high heat. Add 1 Tbsp of the oil to the pan. Add the onions and sauté until they just start to turn translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the turmeric and chilli powder and cook for 30 seconds. Lower the heat to low and add the chickpea flour. Cook, stirring constantly, for 2 to 3 minutes. Lower the heat to a gentle simmer and fold

in the kefir, stirring constantly. Watch the liquid carefully as it cooks until it thickens slightly, 2 to 3 minutes. Fold the roasted cauliflower into the liquid and remove from the heat. Taste and add salt if necessary.

Heat a small, dry saucepan over medium-high heat. Add the remaining 2 Tbsp of oil. Once the oil is hot, add the cumin and black mustard seeds and cook until they start to pop and the cumin starts to brown, 30 to 45 seconds. Remove from the heat and add the chilli flakes, swirling the oil in the pan until the oil turns red. Quickly pour the hot oil with the seeds over the cauliflower in the saucepan. Garnish with the chopped cilantro and serve warm with rice or parathas (see Parathas, page 297).

Roasted Butternut Squash + Pomegranate Molasses Soup

My favorite formula for a soup is to roast a vegetable, then blend it. This maximizes the way ingredients and flavors interact. This soup is based on my own personal soup philosophy and packs a mighty punch in flavor. Pumpkin can be substituted for squash in this recipe; I recommend using a variety that's not too sweet.

SERVES 4

1½ lb [680 g] butternut squash, peeled and cut into large chunks

1 medium white onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), peeled and diced

4 garlic cloves, peeled

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil, plus extra to drizzle

1 tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

1 tsp Aleppo pepper flakes

½ tsp ground turmeric

2 Tbsp Worcestershire sauce

1 Tbsp pomegranate molasses

¼ cup [30 g] slivered or [25 g] sliced almonds, for garnish

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Pomegranate molasses gives this soup acidity with a hint of sweetness; if you prefer it a bit more sour, add an additional 1 to 2 tsp of the molasses.

Worcestershire sauce adds to the savory character.

The heat and bright red pigment from the Aleppo pepper flakes and turmeric are extracted in the hot oil.

Heat is used to temper the flavor of turmeric.

Preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C].

Place the butternut squash, onion, and garlic cloves on a large baking sheet. Add 1 Tbsp of the olive oil and the black pepper. Season with salt and toss to coat evenly. Place the baking sheet in the oven and roast until the vegetables are completely cooked and start to turn golden brown, 35 to 45 minutes. (If the garlic starts to burn, remove and set aside.) Remove from the oven and transfer all the contents of the sheet to a blender or a food processor. Add 2 cups [480 ml] of water and pulse on high speed until completely smooth.

Lower the oven temperature to 350°F [177°C].

Heat the remaining 1 Tbsp of olive oil in a large saucepan over medium-low

heat. When the oil is hot, add the Aleppo pepper flakes and turmeric and cook for 30 seconds. Stir in the puréed butternut squash, the Worcestershire sauce, and pomegranate molasses. Increase the heat to medium-high and bring to a boil. Lower the heat to a simmer and cook for 5 minutes. Taste and season with salt.

While the soup is cooking, toast the almonds. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper. Spread the almonds in a single layer and toast in the oven until they turn golden brown, 8 to 10 minutes. Transfer to a small bowl.

To serve, ladle the warm soup into a serving bowl. Garnish with toasted almonds, drizzle with olive oil, and serve immediately.





Tomato Aachari Polenta Tart

Aachar is the Hindi word for Indian pickles; *aachari* in this recipe refers to the pickling spices used in their preparation (see Cauliflower Aachar, page 320, to get a sense of how they're different from European-style pickles). In this tart, those spices complement the flavor of ripe summer tomatoes.

MAKES ONE 10 IN [25 CM] TART

2 Tbsp melted ghee or unsalted butter, plus extra to grease the pan

2 or 3 fresh tomatoes (total weight 1.1 lb [500 g])

Fine sea salt

1 tsp black or brown mustard seeds

1 tsp cumin seeds

1 tsp fenugreek seeds

1 tsp nigella seeds

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 cup [140 g] polenta or cornmeal

1 oz [30 g] grated Gruyère

1 oz [30 g] grated Parmesan

1 tsp amchur

1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa (optional)

1 tsp oregano, fresh, or ½ tsp dried

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

A slice of polenta covered with slices of roasted tomatoes, cheese, and spices provides a soft, comforting texture.

Cheese lovers (like me) can add more cheese. The sound of bubbling cheese and its degree of browning is a good index of progress to watch while cooking. If you let it go too dark, it will taste bitter.

The number of tomatoes will vary a little, depending on their width. Take advantage of the colorful heirloom tomatoes that arrive in all sorts of shapes and sizes in summer.

Tomatoes can release a large amount of water, which could make for a soggy tart. Using the principle of osmosis, water is drawn out from the tomato by sprinkling them with a little salt and leaving them to drain on paper towels, which wick the liquid away.

The tomatoes and amchur are the main sources for sourness in the tart.

Grease and line a 10 in [25 cm] circular tart pan with a little melted ghee and a sheet of parchment paper. Place the pan on a baking sheet lined with parchment paper.

Line another baking sheet with two layers of paper towels. Cut the tomatoes into thin slices, sprinkle with a little salt on each side, and place the slices on the prepared baking sheet. Cover with an additional layer or two of paper towels and let rest for at least 30 minutes and up to 45 minutes.

Meanwhile, prepare the spice mix. Toast the mustard, cumin, and fenugreek seeds in a small, dry stainless-steel skillet over medium-high heat until the seeds start to turn fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Remove from the heat and transfer to a small plate to cool slightly. Add the cooled toasted spices to a spice mill or grinder and grind to a powder. Stir in the nigella seeds to the ground toasted spice mix.

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In a large pot, combine 3 cups [720 ml] of water with the olive oil, ghee, and 1 tsp of salt and bring to a rolling boil over medium-high heat. Slowly stir in the polenta, lower the heat to a simmer, and cook, stirring constantly to prevent the polenta from sticking, until completely tender and most of the water has evaporated, 15 to 20 minutes. Remove from the heat and transfer the polenta to the prepared baking tart while it is still warm and pliable. Level the surface with an offset spatula.

Prick the surface of the tart with the prongs of a fork a few times to allow even baking.

Preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C].

Mix together the Gruyère and Parmesan in a small mixing bowl. Sprinkle half over the surface of the polenta. Place the tomato slices on top of the cheese. Sprinkle the ground spice mixture over the tomatoes. Season with salt, if needed. Cover with the remaining cheese and bake until the cheese melts and turns

golden brown, 30 to 40 minutes. Remove from the oven and cool in the pan for 5 to 8 minutes. The tart should come out of the pan easily, but if it sticks, run a small paring knife around the edges of the pan to loosen. Place the tart pan over a can or glass and tap gently from the sides to release the ring.

Sprinkle with the amchur, chilli flakes, if using, and oregano. Serve immediately.

Spareribs in Malt Vinegar + Mashed Potatoes

Ribs are an indulgent, messy experience that’s oddly relaxing; they’re 100% unfussy. Sit back, pour a glass of wine, get your fingers dirty, and dig in. I like my ribs the way they do them in the South, a bit sweet and a bit sour and a lot of spice and heat. Make the mashed potatoes like I do or, if you own a ricer or food mill, by all means go ahead and put it to use. Note: Start this recipe 1 or 2 days before you plan to serve it. My preference is to cut the rack of ribs into individual pieces so it fits into the pan, but you can also ask your butcher to do this and even ask them to cut the ribs in half.

SERVES 4

- For the spareribs:**
 - 3 lb [1.4 kg] spareribs (pork) with bone left in (see headnote)
 - Fine sea salt
 - 1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
 - 2 cups [480 ml] dry white wine, such as Pinot Gris
 - 1 cup [240 ml] plus 2 Tbsp malt vinegar
 - ½ cup [100 g] packed jaggery or dark brown sugar
 - 12 black peppercorns
 - 2 tsp ground fennel
 - ½ tsp ground cinnamon
 - ½ tsp ground turmeric
 - ¼ tsp cayenne

- For the mashed potatoes:**
 - 1¼ lb [570 g] Yukon gold potatoes
 - ¼ cup [60 ml] plus 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
 - ½ cup [120 ml] warm water at 160°F [71°C]
 - Fine sea salt
 - 1 tsp nigella seeds
 - 2 garlic cloves, peeled and thinly sliced
 - 2 Tbsp minced chives, for garnish

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Malt vinegar and white wine tenderize the meat during cooking, and their acids provide contrast against the backdrop of warm spices and sweet jaggery.

Passing the potatoes through the grater and then the fine-mesh sieve gives them a smooth, creamy texture.

To prepare the spareribs, trim off any excess fat and cut them into individual ribs by slicing the meat right between the bones. Pat them dry with clean paper towels and season with salt. Heat the olive oil in a large cast-iron or stainless-steel skillet over medium-high heat. Working in batches, sear the ribs on each side until they turn brown, 5 or 6 minutes. Remove from the heat and place them in a medium heavy-bottomed Dutch oven or saucepan with a lid.

Preheat the oven to 300°F [149°C]. Cover the top of the Dutch oven with a double layer of aluminum foil and tuck the edges under to seal securely. Cover with the lid and cook for 2 hours. Remove the lid and the foil and cook the ribs for 1 more hour. The meat should be tender and falling off the bones. With a slotted spoon or a pair of kitchen tongs, remove the ribs from the Dutch oven and set them on a plate or tray.

cont'd

Skim and discard the excess fat from the liquid. Return the Dutch oven to the stove and heat the liquid over medium-high heat, stirring to prevent burning, until reduced to a thick syrup consistency, 15 to 20 minutes. Return the ribs with any liquids to the Dutch oven and fold to coat evenly with the sauce. Stir in the remaining 2 Tbsp of malt vinegar. Taste and season with salt if needed. Remove from the heat and serve with the mashed potatoes and garnish with the minced chives.

Note: If you have the time, you can also refrigerate the cooked ribs in the pan overnight and let the fat harden

on top, which will make it easier to remove; then proceed with the reduction step.

To prepare the mashed potatoes, place the potatoes in a large pot with enough salted water to cover them by 1 in [2.5 cm]. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat, then lower the heat to medium-low. Cook until the potatoes are completely tender but not mushy, 20 to 30 minutes. Drain the potatoes and set them aside until cool enough to handle.

Peel and discard the potato skins. Grate the potatoes with the fine holes of a grater. Then pass the

grated potatoes through a fine-mesh sieve placed over a large mixing bowl. Whisk in ¼ cup [60 ml] of the olive oil and the warm water until smooth and fluffy. Season with salt.

Heat the remaining 2 Tbsp of oil over medium-high heat. When the oil is hot, add the nigella seeds and garlic and cook for 30 to 45 seconds, until they are fragrant and the garlic turns a light golden brown. Pour the seasoned oil over the mashed potatoes and serve warm.

Chouriço Pao (Buns)

Every trip to Goa with my family involves ample consumption of chouriço, or *choriz* as it's more commonly known, a remnant of Portuguese colonial rule. Its fiery flavor combined with vinegar makes it one of the most popular condiments, and you'll see it tossed into pulaos and stuffed into breads such as naan in restaurants, as well as in these buns that my aunts often make. You can substitute a tofu-based chouriço alternative. But be warned: One bun is never enough.

MAKES 12 INDIVIDUAL BUNS

For the dough:

- ½ cup [120 ml] whole milk
- ¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter
- ¼ cup [50 g] sugar
- ½ tsp fine sea salt
- 1 large egg, lightly whisked
- 2 cups [280 g] all-purpose flour, plus more for dusting
- 1½ tsp active dry yeast

For the filling:

- 11 oz [312 g] chouriço
- 1 medium white onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), diced
- 1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 Yukon gold potato (6¾ oz [190 g]), peeled and diced
- 1 large egg, lightly whisked with 1 Tbsp of water
- 2 Tbsp nigella or black sesame seeds

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Yeast ferments the added sugar (sucrose), the lactose in the milk, and the sugar in the flour to produce carbon dioxide gas that gives the buns their airy texture.

The amylase enzyme comes from three different sources—the yeast, the egg yolk, and the flour. Amylase helps cut the long starch molecules into glucose, which the yeast uses for nutrition but also contributes to the development of the structure of the dough.

Chouriço is a cured sausage and contains acid as well as heat from the chillies used to flavor it.

Note: If you feel your chouriço is lacking a little in the flavor department, do what I do. Because Goan chouriço is nearly impossible to find outside Goa, save for a few people that make it from scratch, I use this formula: For every 1 lb [455 g] of store-bought chouriço, add ¼ cup [60 ml] of coconut or malt vinegar; 1 in [2.5 cm] piece of fresh ginger, peeled and grated; 1 Tbsp of ground Kashmiri chilli; 1 tsp of ground cayenne; 1 tsp of brown sugar or jaggery; 3 cloves, ground; and ½ tsp of ground cinnamon.

Warm the milk, butter, sugar, and salt over medium-low heat to 110°F [43°C], stirring until the butter melts and the sugar dissolves completely. Remove from the heat and stir in the whisked egg.

Place the flour and yeast in the bowl of a stand mixer. With the paddle attachment fixed and the speed set to low, dry whisk just to combine the ingredients. Slowly pour in the

milk mixture. Mix until the dough comes together, 5 to 6 minutes. The dough will be sticky. Use a scraper to transfer the dough onto a lightly floured surface. Knead for 1 minute to bring the dough together, shape into a ball, and place it in a lightly greased large bowl.

Cover with plastic wrap and allow to rise in a dark, warm place until the dough doubles in size, 1½ to 2 hours.





While the dough rests, prepare the filling. Heat a large skillet over medium-high heat. Remove the chouriço from the casing, break it into bits, and add it to the hot skillet. Cook until the meat just begins to brown. Add the onion and sauté until it is translucent, and the sausage is thoroughly cooked. With a slotted spoon, transfer the mixture to a bowl, leaving the fat in the skillet. Add the olive oil and potatoes and cook over medium-high heat until tender, 10 to 12 minutes. Remove from the heat, transfer to the chouriço in the bowl, and discard any excess fat. Fold to mix evenly and let cool completely.

Line a baking sheet with parchment paper and divide the meat mixture into 12 equal parts by weight. Shape each into a ball, place them on the lined baking sheet, and refrigerate.

Once the dough has doubled in size, line two baking sheets with parchment paper. Tip the dough out onto a lightly floured surface, knead it once, and weigh it. Divide the dough into 12 equal parts by weight and shape each into a ball. Pick up one ball of dough and fold by grabbing the underside and stretching it and folding it back on itself. Rotate a quarter turn and repeat three or four times. Flatten the dough to form a small disk, about 5 in [13 cm] across. Place a ball of the refrigerated chouriço filling in the center and wrap the edges of the dough to encase the filling. Gently shape the sides to form a ball and place it on the lined baking sheet. Prepare the remaining buns and divide them equally between the two sheets, leaving about 1½ in [4 cm] between them. Cover the buns loosely with a sheet of parchment paper and let rise for 1 hour until doubled in size.

Preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C]. Brush the buns with the egg and water mixture. Sprinkle a few pinches of nigella over the top of each bun and bake until they are golden brown and springy to the touch and a skewer comes out clean, 25 to 30 minutes. Rotate the pans halfway through baking. Cool on the baking sheets for 5 minutes. Transfer the buns from the baking sheets to a wire rack. Serve warm. Any extra buns can be wrapped in plastic wrap and stored in an airtight container or resealable bag for up to a week in the refrigerator or 2 weeks in the freezer. To reheat, thaw them in the refrigerator overnight, then unwrap and warm them in the oven at 200°F [93°C].



Pomegranate + Poppy Seed Wings

Unlike me, my husband, Michael, is an avid sports fan and watches the Super Bowl every year. My contribution to this annual ritual is preparing all the accoutrements—including these sweet-and-spicy wings that will have you licking your fingers in delight. The recipe for the sauce will give you enough to coat the wings plus a bit extra for dipping.



SERVES 4 AS AN APPETIZER

For the wings:

2 lb [910 g] chicken wings

2 tsp baking powder

Fine sea salt

For the sauce (makes about 1 cup [240 ml]):

¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter

2 tsp poppy seeds

2 tsp red chilli flakes or ½ tsp ground cayenne

1 tsp ground cumin

1 tsp ground black pepper

¼ cup [60 ml] pomegranate molasses

¼ cup [60 ml] prepared yellow mustard

2 Tbsp dark brown sugar

Fine sea salt

2 Tbsp minced chives, for garnish

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Moisture and dryness are natural enemies. To make a crispy chicken wing, the water must be drawn to the surface of the skin and wicked away. You can achieve this by using the combined action of salt and exposing the wings to air in the refrigerator. I use Kenji López-Alt’s method of applying baking soda to the chicken’s skin. Baking soda helps with browning because it increases the pH and, in the presence of heat, facilitates the Maillard reaction.

Pomegranate molasses and the vinegar in prepared mustard is the chief souring agent in this dish.

Adding a sweetener such as dark brown sugar adds sweetness and an earthy character to the sauce, balancing the acidity from the pomegranate molasses.

To prepare the wings, pat them dry with clean paper towels. Place in a medium bowl, sprinkle with the baking powder, and season with salt. Toss to coat evenly. Place a wire rack on a baking sheet; arrange the wings on the rack and leave them in the refrigerator to dry overnight. If you’re tight on space, arrange the wings on clean paper towels over smaller plates and refrigerate. You might need to discard and replace the paper towels after 12 hours if they get too wet.

Preheat the oven to 450°F [232°C]. Line a baking sheet with foil and place the wire rack with the wings on the sheet. Bake for 15 to 20 minutes. Flip the wings and bake until the skin starts to get crispy and golden brown, an additional 15 to 20 minutes. The

internal temperature of the chicken should read 165°F [74°C] on an instant-read thermometer. Transfer the wings to a large mixing bowl.

To make the sauce, melt the butter in a small saucepan over medium-high heat. When the butter melts, add the poppy seeds, red chilli, cumin, and black pepper. Swirl and cook for 30 seconds until the poppy seeds sizzle. Remove from the heat and stir in the molasses, mustard, and sugar. Taste and adjust with salt.

Pour ½ cup [120 ml] of the sauce over the hot wings and toss to coat evenly. Garnish with the minced chives. Serve the hot wings with the remaining sauce to dip.



Lemon + Lime Mintade

A few years ago, on a flight to India via the Middle East, I drank an exquisite glass of lemon and lime juice garnished with mint. It was refreshing and energizing with its bright citrus flavors and fresh mint aroma. As you might imagine, this was particularly welcome on a sixteen-hour flight. I've re-created that drink here; it's a powerful ode to citrus.

SERVES 6

- 1 cup [200 g] sugar
- Zest of 2 lemons (see The Flavor Approach)
- Zest of 2 limes (see The Flavor Approach)
- 1 bunch fresh mint, leaves and stems (2 oz [55 g]), plus a few extra leaves for garnish
- ½ cup [120 ml] fresh lemon juice
- ½ cup [120 ml] fresh lime juice
- 3 cups [720 ml] chilled club soda or water

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The aromatic essential oils in the zest of the lemon and lime are added to the hot syrup along with the mint to steep. These oils act on our nerves through chemesthesis (see page 235).

The lime and lemon juice are the main souring agents.

Do not use a Microplane zester to extract the zest of the citrus fruits; instead, use a citrus zester. The zester's larger holes create long strands that are easier to strain and can later double as a garnish. If you prefer the syrup less sweet, reduce the sugar to ½ cup [100 g].

In a medium saucepan, combine the sugar and 1 cup [240 ml] of water and bring to a simmer over medium-high heat, stirring until the sugar dissolves. Remove from the heat and pour the syrup into a large jar with a tight lid. Add the lemon and lime zest to the syrup. Bruise the mint by twisting and crushing the leaves and stems in your hands. Add to the mixture. Cover with a lid and let cool to room temperature. Stir in the lemon and lime juice, cover, and refrigerate for 1 hour.

Strain the liquid through a fine-mesh sieve over a medium bowl. Reserve a few strands of the zest and discard the rest of the zest and leaves left behind in the strainer.

To serve, fill six tall glasses with ice. Pour ½ cup [120 ml] of the syrup into each glass, top with ½ cup [120 ml] of the club soda, and stir. Garnish with the extra mint leaves and reserved zest. Store any leftover concentrate in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 1 week.

Blueberry + Omani Lime Ice Cream

This is a wonderfully easy recipe that takes advantage of the smoky flavor of dried Omani limes that are used in Persian and Middle Eastern cooking, and complements the tangy notes of the kefir and the blueberries. Dried Omani limes are sold whole and ground in Persian and Middle Eastern stores as well as spice markets. There is no need to add any salt, since cream cheese is always sold presalted.

MAKES 1 QT [1 L]

4 whole Omani limes

2 cups [480 ml] kefir or buttermilk

1 cup [200 g] sugar

4 oz [115 g] cream cheese, softened to room temperature and cubed

5 oz [140 g] fresh or frozen blueberries (no need to thaw if using frozen)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Because the liquid is cold and the limes are dried, they must be steeped overnight in the refrigerator to extract their acid and citrus aroma.

If ground, the bitter-tasting compounds will get more intense every day in the ice cream.

Sugar, cream cheese, and the pectin from the blueberries help prevent the formation of ice crystals, creating a smooth-textured ice cream.

Lightly crack the Omani limes just enough to open them. Place them in an airtight container and pour the kefir over the limes. Seal and refrigerate overnight to infuse.

Strain the liquid through a fine-mesh sieve over a large bowl. Discard the limes. Transfer the liquid to a blender. Add the sugar and cream cheese. Pulse for a few seconds on high speed until the sugar is completely dissolved and there are no visible flecks of cream cheese. Add the blueberries and pulse for a few seconds on high speed until the blueberries are blended.

Transfer the base to an ice cream maker and churn according to the manufacturer's instructions. Scrape the ice cream into a freezer-safe container, place a sheet of parchment

paper cut to size against the surface of the ice cream, and freeze until firm, at least 4 hours.

Alternatively, freeze the ice cream base in a freezer-safe container for 1 hour. Remove the container from the freezer and churn it by hand using a fork, electric hand mixer, immersion blender, or food processor to break the ice crystals, then return it to the freezer. Repeat three or four times at 30-minute intervals. The freezing time will vary a little depending on your freezer.

Leave the ice cream out for about 5 minutes to soften a little before serving. Store the leftover ice cream in the freezer for up to 5 days.



2

BITTERNESS







Warm Kale, White Bean + Mushroom Salad with Chilli Tahini

During the colder months of the year, I often make this quick, flavorful salad. This salad owes its heat to the Chinese condiment Chiu Chow style chilli oil, which comes from the region of Southern China within the Guangdong province. This condiment is prepared from a combination of fresh and brined chillies flavored with garlic, soy sauce, and toasted sesame oil. The most popular brand, and the one that I love, from Lee Kum Kee is available in most grocery stores in the international aisle as well as in Asian markets. Before you use these, give the contents a shake or stir so the flakes are distributed. This can also be served as a one-bowl meal over Plain Rice (page 310) with a generous spoonful or two of the Green Apple Chutney (page 321) or Cauliflower Achar (page 320).

There are other types of Chinese chilli oil condiments available; the Lao Gan Ma company makes one that is popularly referred to as chilli crisp oil and will also work in this dish. It will taste slightly different because in addition to chillies, garlic, and ginger, it contains Sichuan peppercorns, black cardamom, and cinnamon.

SERVES 4

For the salad:

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 shallot (2 oz [60 g]), thinly sliced

6 oz [170 g] fresh cremini or shiitake mushrooms, sliced

1 small bunch tender kale (about 10 oz [285 g]), such as Lacinato (also called Tuscan or dinosaur kale), midribs stripped, coarsely chopped

Fine sea salt

One 15½ oz [445 g] can white beans, such as cannellini, rinsed and drained

For the chilli tahini:

¼ cup [55 g] tahini

3 Tbsp Chiu Chow style chilli oil (see headnote)

¼ cup [60 ml] rice wine vinegar

Fine sea salt

1 or 2 Tbsp boiling water

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Tahini carries a mildly bitter taste that is masked by the warmth of the chillies and the acidity of the vinegar.

In addition, tahini provides a layer of creamy texture and fat that coats the kale and beans in this salad.

The bitterness of the kale is offset by the use of fat, acid, and heat.

Chiu Chow style chilli oil provides a complex combination of flavor from the chillies, garlic, soy sauce, and sesame oil.

To prepare the salad, heat the oil in a large saucepan over medium-high heat. When the oil is hot, add the shallot and sauté until it starts to turn golden brown, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the mushrooms and sauté until they start to sear a little, 3 to 4 minutes. Fold in the kale, season with salt, and cook until the leaves turn bright green, 3 to 4 minutes. Remove from the heat. Fold in the cannellini beans. Taste and season with salt. Transfer to a large mixing bowl.

To prepare the chilli tahini, whisk the tahini, chilli oil, and vinegar together in a small bowl. Taste and season with salt. If the mixture is too thick, stir in 1 or 2 Tbsp of the boiling water.

Pour the tahini dressing over the kale in the mixing bowl and toss to coat evenly. Serve warm.

Shaved Brussels Sprouts Salad

I was once asked if I could recall something I tasted for the first time after I moved to the United States. It's Brussels sprouts. I can't recollect the exact dish and how it was cooked, but I remember they reminded me of strange Lilliputian cabbages. Brussels sprouts are spectacular when shaved into shreds for a salad or roasted. Because some folks, especially my husband, love a bit more dressing or sauce with everything they eat, this recipe makes a little more to give you that option.

SERVES 4 TO 6

For the salad:

3 shallots (total weight 6½ oz [180 g])

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

Fine sea salt

1 lb [455 g] Brussels sprouts

1¼ oz [50 g] chopped walnuts

½ cup [24 g] thinly sliced scallions, both white and green parts

2 Tbsp chopped mint leaves, for garnish

1 tsp red chilli pepper flakes, such as Aleppo or Maras, for garnish

For the dressing:

2 garlic cloves, peeled

1 cup [240 g] crème fraîche

2 Tbsp fresh lemon juice

1 tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The dressing's combination of acid, fat, salt, and herbs provides textural contrast to the crunchy walnuts and Brussels sprouts, and offsets their mild bitterness.

Submerging the cut or shredded bits of the vegetable in a bowl of ice-cold water helps reduce their sulfurous smell.

Mint and crème fraîche create a cooling sensation via chemesthesis.

Crispy shallots and walnuts add a crunchy mouthfeel.

To make the dressing, smash the garlic cloves using the flat side of a knife until you get a smooth purée. Transfer to a small mixing bowl. Fold in the crème fraîche, lemon juice, and black pepper. Taste and add salt as needed.

To assemble the salad, drain the Brussels sprouts. Spread them out on a clean kitchen towel to absorb any excess liquid. Transfer them to a large mixing bowl. Add the scallions, walnuts, and half the crème fraîche dressing, and fold to coat evenly. Transfer to a serving bowl. Garnish with the mint, chilli flakes, and crispy shallots and serve with the remaining dressing on the side. The salad will be good for up to 2 days if refrigerated in an airtight container. Before serving, let it warm to room temperature.





Charred Asparagus with “Gunpowder” Nut Masala

This asparagus dish is an explosion of aroma and taste. If you have a bit of smoked salt at home, use it here to amplify and enhance the effect of grilling. This is an excellent side to serve at a barbecue or to accompany any grilled vegetable or meat dish. I sometimes serve this for lunch with a plain omelet and a bowl of Plain Rice (page 310).

SERVES 4

4 Tbsp [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil plus a little extra to brush the pan

1 lb [455 g] asparagus, tough ends trimmed and discarded

1 Tbsp fresh lime juice

1 tsp lime zest

Sea salt flakes

1 Tbsp My “Gunpowder” Nut Masala (page 312)

1 Tbsp chopped cilantro or flat-leaf parsley

1 lime, cut into quarters (optional)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

During charring, the mildly bitter taste of asparagus is reduced, and it takes on an entirely new set of flavors, including some caramelization and the Maillard reaction.

Salt is not added at the start during grilling because salt flakes are used as a finishing salt.

Observe how the green color of the asparagus gets brighter once cooked.

Heat a grill pan or cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. Brush the grates with a little oil.

Place the asparagus on a large plate or baking sheet. Drizzle with 1 Tbsp of the oil and rub to coat well.

Add the asparagus to the hot pan and cook for 5 to 6 minutes, turning with a pair of kitchen tongs, until

they turn bright green and develop charred spots or grill marks. Transfer the asparagus to a serving dish. Drizzle the remaining 3 Tbsp of oil and the lime juice over the asparagus. Sprinkle with the lime zest, salt flakes, “Gunpowder” Nut Masala, and cilantro and serve immediately with the quartered limes on the side, if desired.

Vegetable Pakoras

My mother’s favorite breakfast is pakoras. Often on weekends, she wakes up early to fry a large batch. Pakoras can get soft after they cool, so I changed things up a bit. I limit the water and instead allow the water inside the vegetables to dissolve the dry ingredients. Tempura batter flour bumps up the level of crispiness. There are several fantastic condiments to serve with hot pakoras: Maggi Hot and Sweet Tomato Chilli Sauce (available at Indian grocery stores), Mint Chutney (page 322), Pumpkin Seed Chutney (page 323), and Tamarind-Date Chutney (page 322). You can also pop a few pakoras into a toasted bun and sprinkle with either of the condiments to make it a sandwich.

SERVES 4

- For the vegetables:**
- 1 medium russet potato (7½ oz [215 g])
 - 1 small bunch Lacinato kale (about 10 oz [285 g]), midribs stripped, coarsely chopped
 - 1 medium red onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), halved and cut into thin slices
 - 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced
 - 1 green chilli, minced
 - 2 Tbsp cilantro leaves (optional)

- For the batter:**
- ¾ cup [90 g] chickpea flour
 - ¼ cup [40 g] tempura batter flour
 - 1 tsp garam masala, homemade (page 312) or store-bought
 - 1 tsp ground turmeric
 - ½ tsp ground black pepper
 - ½ tsp fine sea salt
 - 3 cups [720 ml] grapeseed or other neutral oil
 - 1 Tbsp amchur

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Mechanically breaking down some of the cells of the vegetables by massaging them gently releases the water trapped inside their cells, which helps bring the dry ingredients together to form a batter.

Achieve maximum crispiness by using minimal water plus a combination of chickpea flour and tempura batter flour.

Since the oil is maintained at a temperature of 350°F [177°C], use an oil with a smoke point way above this number, such as grapeseed.

To prepare the vegetables, peel the potato and grate it on the coarse blades of a grater into a large mixing bowl. Add the kale, onions, ginger, chilli, and cilantro to the mixing bowl.

To prepare the batter, whisk together the chickpea flour, tempura batter flour, garam masala, turmeric, black pepper, and salt in a medium bowl. Sift the flour mixture through a fine-mesh sieve over the vegetables in the mixing bowl and dump any bits of the black pepper left behind over the vegetables. Massage the ingredients together until the vegetables are completely coated with the batter, 3 to 4 minutes. If it needs a bit of water to help bind the ingredients, sprinkle on 1 or 2 Tbsp.

Heat the oil in a small, heavy cast-iron pot or saucepan over medium-high heat until the oil reaches 350°F [177°C]. Set a wire rack on a baking sheet lined with parchment paper. Once the oil is hot, test a small batch by dropping in 1 Tbsp of batter; the batter should float to the surface. To shape and fry the pakoras, use two dinner spoons—one to scoop the batter and the second to help shape and transfer the batter to the hot oil. Fry the pakoras in batches. The pakoras are cooked when they turn golden brown all over, 3 to 4 minutes. Remove the pakoras with a slotted spoon and transfer them to the prepared baking sheet to drain any excess oil. Sprinkle the hot pakoras with the amchur and serve them immediately with chutney on the side, if desired.



Collard Greens, Chickpea + Lentil Soup

I like tangy flavors in all my soups; it's a constant in most of the soups I cook or write about. The bitterness of collard greens is tamed by the acids in the tamarind and tomatoes. Red lentils cook quickly, so you don't have to soak them like green or brown lentils, but I still do; it's a habit I learned from my family in India. Soaking seeds and legumes in water changes their chemical composition and makes them more digestible. If you're running low on time, skip the soak and just cook them. Depending on where you buy your red lentils, you might notice some differences in their thickness and diameter. Indian red lentils are wider and thicker than the ones sold in American grocery stores; consequently, you will need to increase your cooking time accordingly and add a little more water if you notice the liquid all being absorbed.

SERVES 4

½ cup [100 g] red lentils
2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
1 medium white or yellow onion (9½ oz [260 g]), diced
4 garlic cloves, peeled and sliced
1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated
2 in [5 cm] piece cinnamon stick
1 tsp ground black pepper
½ to 1 tsp red chilli powder
½ tsp ground turmeric
2 Tbsp tomato paste
1 medium tomato (5 oz [140 g]), diced
1 bunch collard greens (about 7 oz [200 g]), midribs removed, coarsely chopped
One 15½ oz [445 g] can chickpeas, drained and rinsed
1 qt [960 ml] vegetable stock, “brown” vegetable stock (page 57), or water
1 Tbsp tamarind paste, homemade (page 67) or store-bought
Fine sea salt
2 Tbsp chopped flat-leaf parsley
2 Tbsp chopped cilantro
Buttered bread or naan, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Tamarind and tomato provide a sour backdrop for bitter greens and vegetables in this soup.

Pick over the lentils for any stones or debris, rinse in a fine-mesh sieve under running tap water, and transfer to a small bowl. Cover with 1 cup [120 ml] of water and soak for 30 minutes.

Heat the olive oil in a large saucepan over medium-high heat. Once the oil is hot, add the onion and sauté until translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the garlic and ginger and cook until fragrant, about 1 minute. Add the cinnamon, black pepper, red chilli, and turmeric and sauté until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Stir in the tomato paste and cook until it just starts to brown, 2 to 3 minutes.

Stir in the diced tomato and collard greens and sauté until the leaves turn bright green, 1 to 2 minutes. Drain the soaked lentils and add along with the chickpeas and vegetable stock. Bring to a boil, lower the heat to a simmer, and cook until the lentils are tender and completely cooked, 25 to 30 minutes. Stir in the tamarind paste. Taste and season with salt.

Before serving, stir in the chopped parsley and cilantro. Serve hot with toasted slices of warm buttered bread or naan.



Grapefruit Soda with Chai Masala

My husband loves grapefruit, so one year I surprised him with a dwarf Ruby Red Grapefruit plant. The little plant is housed in a big pot only a few feet high but bears impressively large, orb-like yellow citrus that are extremely fragrant when sliced. Sometimes I collect the juice and stir it into a simple syrup made with chai masala (tea spices). I infuse whole spices rather than ground into the simple syrup to get a lighter flavor that delicately complements the citrus.

SERVES 8

- ½ cup [100 g] sugar
- 2 in [5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and cut into thin slices
- 1 in [2.5 cm] piece cinnamon stick
- 10 whole black peppercorns
- 2 whole green cardamom pods, lightly cracked
- 1 star anise
- 2½ cups [600 ml] fresh grapefruit juice (from 2 to 3 large pink grapefruit)
- One 4½ cup [1 L] bottle club soda, chilled

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The bitterness of grapefruit is complemented by a combination of spices.

Aroma and taste molecules in the whole spices are extracted using a combination of heat and water.

Club soda and grapefruit juice both provide acidity, while the soda’s carbonation adds the textural effect of fizz by playing with our receptors (see Carbonated Beverages, page 67).

The added sugar and the sugars present in grapefruit soda help temper the bitter tastants in the grapefruit juice.

Combine 1½ cups [360 ml] of water and the sugar in a medium saucepan. Add the ginger, cinnamon, peppercorns, cardamom, and star anise. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat and immediately remove from the heat. Cover with a lid and steep for 10 minutes. Strain the simple syrup through a fine-mesh sieve placed over a bottle or jug. Discard the spices. You should have 1½ cups [360 ml] of simple syrup. Refrigerate the syrup until chilled.

In a large pitcher, combine the chilled simple syrup and grapefruit juice. Fill eight tall glasses with ice. Pour ½ cup [120 ml] of the syrup mixture into each glass, top with ½ cup [120 ml] of the club soda, and stir. Store any leftover syrup in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 1 week.





Spiced Coffee Kulfi

When I was in high school in India, a street-food vendor would drop by the school every afternoon during our lunch break. Attached to the back of his bicycle was a large metal box filled with chunks of ice and metal containers of frozen kulfi. I'm hesitant to call kulfi an Indian ice cream, because it really isn't that; it's a type of frozen dessert. Unlike ice cream, in which ice crystals are a negative trait, a kulfi will contain a certain amount of ice crystals and is a little firmer than a soft ice cream. Kulfi is one of the easiest treats to make at home. Make ahead of time to allow ample time to freeze.

SERVES 6

1 cup [240 ml] heavy cream

One 14 oz [400 g] can
evaporated milk

One 14 oz [400 g] can
sweetened condensed milk

1 Tbsp instant espresso
or coffee

¼ tsp fine sea salt

2 green cardamom pods,
cracked

2 in [5 cm] piece cinnamon stick

1 or 2 star anise

1¼ oz [35 g] ground toasted
hazelnuts, (optional; see
Hazelnut Flan, page 126,
for instructions on toasting
hazelnuts)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The flavor molecules in the whole spices are extracted into the milk fat for a more delicate flavor to complement the coffee. For a stronger dose of spice, add ½ tsp of ground spices directly to the milk. If you want to reduce the flavor of coffee, use ½ Tbsp.

The use of instant coffee helps in two ways: It dissolves very easily, and it provides a very concentrated dose of coffee flavor without increasing the liquid volume, which would otherwise pose a problem in achieving the correct frozen texture. Excess water will cause a higher proportion of ice crystal formation by changing the ratios of the ingredients involved such as fat, proteins, and sugars.

Evaporated milk acts as a shortcut here; it provides the taste of caramelized lactose, a characteristic feature of kulfis made in India. See the Polenta Kheer (page 185) for a more detailed explanation of the use of evaporated milk and its concentrated flavor in Indian desserts.

Stir together the heavy cream, evaporated milk, condensed milk, instant espresso, salt, cardamom, cinnamon, and star anise in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat, until the espresso dissolves and the liquids are combined. Bring to a boil and remove from the heat. Press a piece of plastic wrap against the surface of the mixture to prevent a skin from forming on the surface and let the mixture steep for 1 hour at room temperature. Remove the whole

spices and discard. Pour the liquid into 6 freezer-safe ramekins or kulfi molds. Wrap the tops with plastic wrap or top with kulfi lids. Transfer to the freezer and let firm for at least 6 hours, preferably overnight.

The kulfi can be served directly in the ramekins. If using kulfi molds, run the metal mold under water for a few seconds, flip, and tap gently to release the kulfi. Garnish with the toasted hazelnuts.



Roasted Fruit with Coffee Miso Tahini

This combination of coffee and miso with tahini might seem a bit unusual, but stick with me; it works, creating a somewhat butterscotch-like taste. I prefer fruit-based desserts. No matter when you make them and how many times you repeat them, fruit always tastes different depending on variety, ripeness, and provenance. This dessert is a good choice for a light and sweet finish to a heavy meal. Use it as a topping over vanilla or cardamom ice cream, or over a bowl of lightly sweetened Greek yogurt. To add a bit of a kick, fold in a few tablespoons of crystallized ginger. A little bit of this dressing goes a long way. Serve it on the side.

SERVES 4

For the roasted fruit:

2 Tbsp unsalted butter, plus extra for greasing

12 oz [340 g] blueberries, fresh or frozen (no need to thaw if using frozen)

12 oz [340 g] fresh figs, sliced in half lengthwise

2 Tbsp fresh lime juice

2 Tbsp maple syrup

½ tsp ground black pepper

¼ tsp fine sea salt

For the coffee miso tahini (makes ¾ cup [180 ml]):

2 Tbsp shiro or sweet white miso

¼ cup [85 g] maple syrup or honey

¼ cup [55 g] tahini

¼ tsp instant espresso or coffee powder

Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

White or shiro miso provides a welcome salty and savory character to the bitter taste of coffee and tahini. This combination works well with fruit and dishes that are sweet with a bold sour character.

Roasting the fruit in their juices helps introduce a bunch of new flavor molecules via the caramelization and Maillard reactions.

Unlike red cabbage, which loses its bright anthocyanin colors on heating, blueberries retain their color. One reason is the presence of blueberry pectin, which is used in the food industry as a stabilizer for anthocyanins. Blueberry pectin can bind some types of anthocyanins and form a complex that is stable in the presence of heat and even acidic pH.

To prepare the fruit, preheat the oven to 375°F [190°C].

Grease a rectangular 8 by 10 in [20 by 25 cm] baking dish with a little butter and place it on a baking sheet lined with parchment paper to catch any of the juices that might bubble over. Place the blueberries and figs in a medium mixing bowl. Drizzle the lime juice and maple syrup over the fruit. Add the black pepper and salt and toss to coat well. Transfer the fruit with the liquids to the baking dish and spread in an even layer. Dot the fruit with the butter and roast

until the figs start to caramelize and the fruits release their juices, 25 to 30 minutes. Remove from the oven.

While the fruit is roasting, prepare the coffee miso tahini. Whisk the miso, maple syrup, tahini, ¼ cup [60 ml] of water, and the espresso powder in a small bowl until smooth. Taste and season with salt.

To serve, drizzle a few tablespoons of the sauce over the warm fruit and serve the rest on the side. You can also serve this over scoops of ice cream or Greek yogurt.

Hazelnut Flan

When summer turned searing hot and humid in Bombay, we would eat chilled bowls of flan (we call it caramel pudding in India). Sometimes we made it from an instant mix, and sometimes we made it from scratch. Here I celebrate one of my favorite childhood desserts through flavors I've learned to love as I grew older. The bittersweet taste of caramelized sweet jaggery is offset by the creaminess of the flan and the aroma of hazelnuts. You have two options for this recipe, depending on the time you have available. You can infuse milk with hazelnuts by yourself (which I highly recommend) or skip that and use a good-quality hazelnut extract or creamer. Note: Making your own infused milk must be done a day or two in advance.

MAKES ONE 8 IN [20 CM]
ROUND FLAN

- 1/8 tsp cream of tartar
- 3/4 cup [150 g] sugar
- 2 cups [480 ml] whole milk or hazelnut-infused milk (recipe follows)
- One 14 oz [400 g] can sweetened condensed milk
- 1 tsp hazelnut extract or 2 Tbsp hazelnut creamer (if using whole milk)
- 1/4 tsp fine sea salt
- 4 large eggs

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Cream of tartar is acidic, which prevents the caramel from crystallizing by helping the sucrose “invert” and produce glucose and fructose from the sucrose. The glucose and fructose interfere with sucrose crystallization, and the caramel remains in liquid form.

A bain-marie, or water bath, is used to gently coagulate the egg proteins to form the structure of the pudding. The aromatic molecules of hazelnuts are intensified by toasting the nuts and then infusing them into the milk.

While bubbles do not affect the taste of the flan (I'll happily devour the pudding), some consider them a textural flaw. To minimize introducing air bubbles in the batter, don't whisk the eggs; instead, gently stir and fold them using a spatula.

A second source for bubbles is the infused hazelnut milk. I took a tip from Stella Parks, author of *BraveTart* and pastry whiz at Serious Eats, who recommends heating the custard base for the flan to get rid of most of the air bubbles.

Preheat the oven to 325°F [163°C].

Combine 1/4 cup [60 ml] of water and the cream of tartar in a small saucepan. Pour the sugar into the center of the saucepan so it does not stick to the sides. Cook, without stirring,

over medium-high heat until the sugar starts to caramelize and turn dark brown, 6 to 8 minutes. Pour the liquid into an 8 in [20 cm] round cake pan and rotate to coat evenly.

cont'd



In a medium saucepan over medium-high heat, combine the milk, condensed milk, hazelnut extract (if using plain milk), and salt, using a spatula to gently stir. Heat until hot but not boiling. Remove from the heat.

Crack the eggs into a large mixing bowl. Using a silicone spatula, slowly break the yolks and stir the eggs gently until combined. Avoid whipping, whisking, or aggressively folding the eggs, or you will incorporate air. While mixing the eggs, slowly add ½ cup [120 ml] of the hot milk mixture to the eggs. Continue to stir the eggs and add another ½ cup [120 ml] of the hot milk. Repeat until all the milk is incorporated into the eggs. Pass this custard base through a fine-mesh sieve over a medium jug or bowl with a spout to remove any lumps.

Hold the flat end of the spatula right over the layer of caramel in the prepared baking pan. Slowly pour the custard base over the flat surface of the spatula, to prevent disturbing the layer of caramel. Cover the top of the pan with a double layer of foil.

Fill a kettle with water and bring it a boil. Place a deep, wide baking dish or pan large enough to accommodate the round baking pan in the oven. Place a circular wire rack inside the dish or make a thick, 8 in [20 cm] ring with aluminum foil to prevent the baking pan from touching the base of the baking dish.

Carefully place the prepared baking pan over the rack or ring in the center of the larger dish. Pour boiling water from the kettle into the space between the baking pan and the

large dish and fill it to about a ½ in [12 mm] from the top of the baking pan. Cook the custard in the oven until it is almost set and the center jiggles slightly, 45 to 50 minutes. Carefully remove the baking pan from the oven, place it on a wire rack, and let it cool completely to room temperature. Refrigerate the flan overnight to set.

The next day, remove the foil cover. Run a small, sharp knife around the inside edge of the flan. Place a large serving plate over the baking pan. Holding them tightly, flip the pan and the plate and tap gently to release the flan onto the plate. Scrape any extra caramel liquid over the flan. Serve chilled or cold. Refrigerate any leftovers in an airtight container for up to 3 to 4 days.

Hazelnut-Infused Milk

This step adds an extra day, but it is well worth the gorgeous, rich flavor of hazelnut and is my preferred method. On the first day, prepare the hazelnut milk; on the second day, use this infused milk in place of the milk and hazelnut extract or creamer and proceed as indicated in the recipe. Be careful to avoid introducing air bubbles when stirring in the hazelnuts.

Preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C].

Line a baking sheet with parchment paper. Place the hazelnuts on the sheet and toast in the oven until they start to turn golden brown and fragrant, 12 to 15 minutes. Remove the nuts from the oven, transfer them to the bowl of a blender or food processor, and pulse for a few seconds, just long enough to break the whole nuts

apart. Do not overgrind to a powder or it will incorporate air bubbles.

Pour the milk into a large jar with a lid. Gently stir in the toasted hazelnuts. Seal the jar and leave to infuse overnight in the refrigerator. You can steep the milk for 24 or 48 hours for a richer flavor.

On the day you plan to prepare the flan, line a fine-mesh sieve with a

piece of wet cheesecloth and place it over a medium bowl. Strain the hazelnut-infused milk through the cloth and discard any solids left behind in the cheesecloth. If your milk volume is slightly under 2 cups [480 ml], add enough milk to bring it back to the original volume. Use this infused milk in the recipe and skip adding the hazelnut extract or creamer.

Sweet Potato Honey Beer Pie

Sweet potatoes are on a monthly rotation in my household; even my dog, Snoopy, loved them. The different components of the pie can be prepared on different days. Here's a suggested order of steps you might find useful, especially if you make this for Thanksgiving. Day 1: Roast sweet potatoes, reduce the beer, and prepare the pie crust, but don't blind bake (partially bake). Day 2: Blind bake the pie crust, prepare the sweet potato custard, and bake the pie. Of course, you can also do this all in one day.

MAKES ONE 9 IN [23 CM] PIE

For the crust:

¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter, cubed and softened to room temperature, plus extra for greasing the pan

¼ cup [50 g] packed dark brown sugar

1 large egg, lightly whisked

7 oz [200 g] almond flour (blanched or unblanched)

½ tsp fine sea salt

For the filling:

1 lb [455 g] sweet potatoes, preferably an orange-fleshed variety such as Garnet or Jewel

One 12 fl oz [360 ml] bottle dark beer

½ cup [100 g] packed dark brown sugar or jaggery

¼ cup [85 g] honey

3 large eggs plus 3 yolks

2 tsp ground ginger

1 tsp ground green cardamom

½ tsp ground turmeric

¼ tsp fine sea salt

½ cup [120 ml] whole milk

½ cup [120 ml] heavy cream

1 Tbsp cornstarch

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Heat plays a very important part in this recipe: The bitterness of beer is concentrated through reduction by evaporating the water. When the nuts in the crust are heated, a whole new set of flavor molecules is produced, which will vary depending on the type of nut used. Heat also helps the egg, nuts, and sugar bind together to form the structure of the pie.

When sweet potatoes are heated, the enzyme amylase breaks down the starch stored in the vegetable's cells to release sweet-tasting sugar molecules, making a roasted sweet potato taste much sweeter than a raw one. This is why roasting sweet potatoes is a superior method for producing not just sweetness but also a beautiful fragrance. Research shows that roasting produces at least seventeen more aromatic molecules than are achieved through boiling or microwaving, and most of them in higher concentrations. Roasting also helps with caramelization of sugars and the Maillard reaction.

To prepare the crust, line the base of a 9 in [23 cm] round tart pan with parchment paper and grease lightly with a little butter.

Place the butter and sugar in the bowl of a stand mixer and beat with the paddle attachment on medium-low speed until the mixture is a uniform pale brown and fluffy, 4 to 5 minutes. Stop the mixer and scrape down the sides of the bowl with a silicone spatula. Add the egg and whisk on medium-low speed

until combined, 1 minute. Add the almond flour and salt and mix on medium-low speed until it comes together to form a ball of dough, 3 to 4 minutes. Scrape the dough from the bowl directly into the prepared pan.

Using a small, flat-bottomed bowl or the base of a flat measuring cup (with parchment paper covering the dough if you wish), spread and level the dough until it covers the base and



the sides in an even layer. Wrap with plastic wrap and freeze for at least 1 hour until firm. The crust can be prepared in advance and frozen, wrapped and sealed in a resealable bag, for up to 2 weeks.

To partially bake the crust, at least 1 hour before it will be filled with the custard, preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C] and set a rack in the lower one-third position. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper. Place the crust on the baking sheet. Dock the surface by pricking it all over with a fork. Cover with a large sheet of parchment paper and weigh it down with pie weights. Bake until the sides just start to brown, 15 to 20 minutes. Transfer to a wire rack and cool for 5 minutes.

Remove the weights and the parchment paper.

To prepare the filling, preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C]. Rinse the sweet potatoes to remove any dirt and pat them dry with paper towels. Place the sweet potatoes in a baking dish or on a baking sheet lined with aluminum foil. Roast until completely tender, 35 to 45 minutes. Cool completely before handling. Peel the sweet potatoes, discard the skins, and purée the flesh in a food processor. You should have about 12 oz [340 g] of sweet potato purée. Once the purée is completely cooled, proceed with the filling or refrigerate overnight in an airtight

container. This can be done a day or two in advance.

When ready to complete the filling, pour the beer into a medium, deep, heavy-bottomed saucepan and bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Watch carefully to avoid overflowing as the liquid foams on heating. Lower the heat to low and cook until the liquid reduces to about ¼ cup [60 ml], 20 to 30 minutes. Cool to room temperature before using.

Preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C]. In a large mixing bowl, whisk together the reduced beer, sweet potato purée, sugar, honey, eggs, yolks, ginger, cardamom, turmeric, and salt. Slowly whisk in the milk and heavy

cream until the sugar completely dissolves. In a small bowl, whisk the cornstarch and 1½ Tbsp of water to form a slurry. Pour the slurry into the custard and whisk until combined. Alternatively, add the ingredients to a high-speed blender and pulse on high speed briefly until you get a smooth slurry (this is my preferred method to obtain a silky-smooth filling).

Transfer the custard to a large saucepan and heat over medium-low heat, stirring constantly, scraping down the sides, until the mixture reaches 165°F [74°C] on an instant-read thermometer and begins to noticeably thicken, 10 to 12 minutes. Quickly remove from the heat. Set a fine-mesh sieve over a large measuring

pitcher and strain the custard to remove any lumps.

Pour the custard into the prebaked crust and bake until the custard is set and an instant-read thermometer reads 185°F [85°C] when inserted into the center of the custard, 25 to 30 minutes. The custard should be firm on the sides but slightly jiggly in the center. Transfer to a wire rack and let the pie cool to room temperature before serving.

NOTES:

You can use the same recipe to make a pumpkin pie, using 15 oz [430 g]

unsweetened pumpkin purée in place of the sweet potatoes. Feel free to use a different crust, homemade or store-bought.

Most pie crusts tend to absorb a bit of water from the filling; nut-based crusts are notorious for this, because nuts release their fat on cooling and also absorb moisture from air (most nuts, including almonds, are hygroscopic). I've tried "waterproofing" pie crusts with egg whites, but that's never worked for me. Here's a method that does work: Melt 3 Tbsp of white or dark bittersweet chocolate and paint the surface of the pie with a pastry brush. Let the chocolate set and harden before you pour in the custard and bake.



Chocolate Miso Bread Pudding

This pudding has all my favorite things in one dish. Since this pudding is rich, I prefer to serve it by itself, warm and gooey, but I wouldn't refuse a big scoop of vanilla or green cardamom ice cream on top. If your local bakery makes a challah or brioche topped with poppy or sesame seeds, go for it. I love the extra crunchy texture the seeds add to the pudding. Note that it's best to start a day ahead so the bread can really soak up the liquid.

SERVES 8 TO 10

1 lb [455 g] challah or brioche

2 Tbsp unsalted butter, cut into small cubes, plus extra for greasing the pan

9 oz [255 g] bittersweet chocolate (70% cacao), chopped

1 tsp instant coffee or espresso

3 oz [85 g] dried tart cherries

1½ cups [360 ml] heavy cream

¼ cup [40 g] shiro or sweet white miso

1½ cups [360 ml] whole milk

¾ cup [150 g] sugar

3 large eggs plus one yolk, lightly whisked

¼ tsp fine sea salt (optional)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Chocolate's flavor is enhanced by the addition of coffee. You can introduce deeper smokier notes depending on the type of chocolate and coffee used and the quality of the roast (both the coffee and chocolate beans are roasted).

Miso gives this dish a boost of salty and sweet notes. You don't need to add salt, because miso contains salt.

Tart cherries give a welcome spot of sourness to this sweet dessert.

If your bread is not stale, preheat the oven to 200°F [93°C]. Set a wire rack on a baking sheet. Cut the bread into 1 in [2.5 cm] cubes and arrange them on the rack. Dry the bread cubes in the oven until completely dry, 45 minutes to 1 hour. You can also dry the bread cubes overnight, on your kitchen counter at room temperature.

Butter a 9 by 12 by 2 in [23 by 30.5 by 5 cm] rectangular baking pan. Add the bread cubes.

Chop the chocolate and transfer half to a large mixing bowl with the instant coffee. Sprinkle the remaining chocolate and the cherries over the bread in the baking pan and fold in. Avoid leaving the bits of chocolate and cherries on top; they might burn during baking.

Warm the cream in a small saucepan over medium-high heat. When the cream just starts to bubble, pour

it over the chocolate in the large mixing bowl. Whisk until the chocolate mixture is completely melted and smooth. Transfer ½ cup [120 ml] of the chocolate mixture to a small mixing bowl. Add the miso and whisk until completely smooth, with no lumps. Pour the miso mixture into the large bowl with the chocolate mixture. Whisk in the milk, sugar, eggs, yolk, and salt until smooth. Pour the liquid over the bread cubes in the baking pan. Cover with plastic wrap and let it sit for 1 hour, or preferably overnight, in the refrigerator.

When ready to bake, preheat the oven to 325°F [163°C]. Unwrap the baking pan and discard the plastic wrap. Dot the surface of the pudding with the butter, then bake until the top is crisp and the pudding is firm, about 1 hour. Serve warm or at room temperature.

3

SALTINESS





“Pizza” Toast

By no means is this a classic pizza in any way, shape, or form, but rather a throwback to a breakfast dish I grew up with. Once I started to get comfortable in the kitchen, I would make breakfast on Sundays, and this “pizza” toast was in constant rotation. It’s the sauce that makes it perfect.

MAKES 4 TOASTS

¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter or
¼ cup [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil

4 slices sandwich bread

¼ cup [60 ml] My Quick Marinara
(page 316) or store-bought pizza
sauce

½ cup [40 g] shredded sharp
cheddar

1 medium (7 oz [200 g]) bell
pepper

1 medium tomato (5 oz [140 g])

Fine sea salt

Fresh coarsely ground black
pepper

2 Tbsp chopped cilantro or flat-
leaf parsley

1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as
Aleppo

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The major contributor to saltiness in this dish is the tomato sauce, followed by the cheese.

The vegetables provide different textural counterpoints to the toast and the sauce.

Preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C].
Line a baking sheet with parchment
paper and set a wire rack on top.

Butter each slice of bread with 1 Tbsp of butter and place them on the wire rack. Spread 1 Tbsp of the marinara sauce on each slice. Sprinkle 1 Tbsp of the cheese over each slice. Cut the bell pepper and tomato into thin rings; reserve 4 and save the rest for another purpose. Place a slice of bell pepper and a slice of tomato on each bread slice. Season with salt and pepper. Sprinkle the remaining cheese over the vegetables on the bread slices. Bake until the cheese is melted and the bread is toasted, 10 to 12 minutes. Remove from the heat. Garnish each toast with ½ Tbsp of the cilantro and some red chilli flakes. Serve immediately.

Gunpowder Oven “Fries” with Goat Cheese Dip

These aren’t technically fried, but the slender matchstick cuts deliver the same finger-food experience, and the ghee gives them a comforting nutty perfume. Be generous with the gunpowder masala; you can use more than I recommend in the instructions or serve extra on the side. The idea behind the technique came from a principle used in blood collection, using citric acid and sodium citrate as *chelators*—agents that can bind and hold ions like calcium and magnesium—which in this case improves texture.

MAKES 2 TO 4 SERVINGS

- For the fries:**

 - ¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lemon juice
 - 1 tsp fine sea salt, plus more as needed
 - ¼ tsp baking soda
 - ⅛ tsp ground turmeric (optional)
 - Three large russet potatoes (total weight 2 lb [910 g])
 - 2 Tbsp melted ghee
 - 2 Tbsp My “Gunpowder” Nut Masala (page 312)
- For the dip:**

 - 5 oz [140 g] soft goat cheese or fromage blanc, at room temperature
 - 2 Tbsp full-fat plain Greek yogurt
 - 1 Tbsp chopped flat-leaf parsley
 - 1 Tbsp fresh lemon juice
 - 1 tsp lemon zest
 - 1 garlic clove, peeled and grated
 - ½ tsp ground black pepper
 - Fine sea salt



To make the fries, in a medium saucepan, mix 4 cups [960 ml] of water with the lemon juice, salt, baking soda, and turmeric, if using. The liquid will foam a little.

While the potatoes boil, preheat the oven to 425°F [218°C]. Move the racks in the oven to the center. Line two baking sheets with foil and place a wire rack over each sheet.

Peel the potatoes and cut them into approximately ¾ by 3½ in [1 by 9 cm] matchsticks. Place the potatoes in the saucepan with the lemon-water

mixture. Place the pan over high heat and bring to a rolling boil. Lower the heat and simmer for 1 minute, until the potatoes are just tender but not falling apart. Carefully drain off the water and place the potatoes in a large bowl. Toss them gently with the melted ghee and season with salt.

Divide the potatoes between the prepared baking sheets, spreading them out in a single layer and leaving enough space between them to cook evenly. Bake until lightly golden brown, 20 to 25 minutes, rotating the sheets and flipping the potatoes with

a spatula or kitchen tongs halfway during cooking. The fries should be soft on the inside and crispy on the outside. Remove them from the oven and sprinkle with the masala, 1 Tbsp per baking sheet.

To prepare the dip, in a small bowl, whisk the cheese, yogurt, parsley, lemon juice, lemon zest, garlic, and pepper. Taste and season with salt, if needed.

Serve the hot fries with the dip.



Paneer + Beet Salad with Mango-Lime Dressing

There is an incomparable joy that I find difficult to express in words when I eat ripe Indian mangoes. During ripening, the starch transforms and gives way to a soft pulp that's sweet and sour, carrying an aroma that reminds me of warm summer holidays in Goa. While mangoes are delicious as a sweet treat, they also make an excellent addition to savory applications. The fruity, sweet flavor of mangoes with lime gives this beet salad a refreshing taste. Try to use a good ripe mango without a chalky aftertaste. It's no surprise that I recommend Indian mangoes, but champagne mangoes are a good option. You'll find paneer in the cheese section at Indian grocery stores as well as most regular food markets.

**SERVES 4 PLUS 1½ CUPS
[360 ML] DRESSING**

For the marinade:

- 1 cup [240 ml] plain unsweetened kefir, buttermilk, or yogurt
- 2 tsp fine sea salt
- ½ tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp ground turmeric
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- ½ tsp freshly ground black pepper
- 14 oz [400 g] firm paneer, homemade (see case study, page 334) or store-bought

For the beets:

- 4 medium beets (total weight 1 lb [455 g]), ideally a mixture of red and yellow
- 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil, plus extra for greasing the pan
- Fine sea salt

For the mango-lime dressing:

- 5 oz [140 g] diced ripe mango
- ½ cup [120 ml] kefir or buttermilk
- ¼ cup [60 ml] grapeseed or debittered extra-virgin olive oil (see case study, page 104)
- 1½ Tbsp fresh lime juice
- 1 Tbsp prepared yellow mustard
- ¼ tsp freshly ground black pepper
- ¼ tsp red chilli powder
- Fine sea salt

For serving:

- 7 oz [200 g] arugula leaves
- 1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp freshly ground black pepper
- Fine sea salt
- 2 tsp amchur

Green Olives + Chouriço Stuffing

I love the concept of stuffing; it’s a blank slate waiting to be painted in flavors that depict who you are. Green olives are my ode to California, while the chouriço, saffron, and vine-gar speak for the India I grew up in.

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Paneer is not a salty cheese, so the marinade must contain a bit more salt for the cheese to absorb.

The salad dressing provides a second layer of flavor as well as salt.

While paneer is one of the easiest cheeses you can make at home, I prefer the store-bought variety in this application, where shape and structural integrity are important. It takes the pressure of an extremely heavy weight to bring together the protein molecules in the paneer and force them to coalesce, producing a firm, compact paneer that can hold its shape when cut and cooked. Commercial producers have equipment that generates sufficient pressure; it’s a little tricky to do this at home but I’ve developed a method that you can use (see case study, page 334); otherwise store-bought is perfectly fine.

Whisk the kefir, salt, cumin, turmeric, chilli powder, and black pepper in a small bowl. Taste and season with more salt if needed. Pour the marinade into a large resealable bag.

Cut the paneer into approximately 1 by 2 by ½ in [2.5 cm by 5 cm by 12 mm] cubes and place them in the bag with the marinade, seal, and gently shake to coat evenly. Let the paneer marinate for 1 hour at room temperature. If you need to marinate it longer, leave it in the refrigerator.

Preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C].

While the paneer marinates, prepare the beets. Peel, trim the ends, and cut into quarters. Place the beets in a baking dish or roasting tray, drizzle with the olive oil, and season with salt. Roast for 30 to 45 minutes, until they are tender on the inside and a knife slides through the center with ease. Remove from the oven and let them rest for 10 minutes.

While the beets roast, prepare the dressing. Place the mango, kefir, oil, lime juice, mustard, pepper, and chilli powder into a blender and pulse on slow speed until combined and smooth. Taste and season with salt.

Grill the paneer just before you’re ready to assemble the salad. Heat a cast-iron grill pan or a medium nonstick saucepan over medium-high heat and brush the surface with a little olive oil. With a pair of kitchen tongs, carefully lift the paneer out of the bag and cook it in batches in the hot pan until it turns golden brown and is slightly seared, 2 to 3 minutes per side.

To serve, toss the arugula in a large mixing bowl with the olive oil. Add the pepper and season with salt. Add the warm grilled paneer pieces. Drizzle with a few tablespoons of the salad dressing. Sprinkle with the amchur just before serving. Serve the remaining salad dressing on the side.

SERVES 8 TO 10

- 1 lb [455 g] ciabatta or sourdough bread
- ½ cup [110 g] unsalted butter, plus extra for greasing
- 20 strands saffron
- Fine sea salt
- 11 oz [310 g] chouriço
- 1 leek (10½ oz [300 g]), ends trimmed and thinly sliced
- 1 medium yellow onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), thinly sliced
- 4 garlic cloves, peeled and thinly sliced
- 2 Granny Smith or other firm, tart baking apples (each about 7 oz [200 g]), cored and diced
- 3 oz [85 g] dried tart cherries
- ½ cup [60 g] walnut halves
- ¼ cup [60 ml] apple cider or malt vinegar
- One 6 oz [170 g] can medium green olives, drained and halved
- 3 cups [720 ml] low-sodium chicken stock
- 2 large eggs, lightly whisked
- 2 Tbsp chopped cilantro, for garnish
- 2 Tbsp chopped flat-leaf parsley, for garnish

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Salty brined green olives provide a strong taste counterpoint to the bold flavors of the chouriço. To boost the flavor of your chouriço, see Chouriço Pao (page 91) for tips.

Apples and cherries add a pop of sweetness and mild sourness.

Saffron is ground to a fine powder using a little salt as an abrasive. Grinding saffron extracts more color and flavor than would be achieved by using the strands directly.

Drying the bread helps dehydrate it, aids the caramelization and Maillard reactions, and makes the bread behave like a sponge to absorb the liquid on soaking.

The stuffing is first cooked covered, to let the egg proteins change their shape, forming a protein meshwork that binds together the different ingredients and flavor molecules. It is then uncovered to finish cooking at a lower temperature, which helps create a crunchier top surface and reduces the risk of burning.

Preheat the oven to 200°F [93°C] and line a baking sheet with parchment paper. Cut or tear the bread into ½ in [12 mm] cubes, spread them out in a single layer on the baking sheet, and dry in the oven, about 1 hour. Remove and let cool completely. Transfer to a large mixing bowl.

Increase the oven heat to 350°F [177°C]. Grease a 9 by 13 by 2 in [23 by 33 by 5 cm] ceramic or glass baking dish with a little butter.

Grind half of the saffron to a fine powder with a little salt and set aside. Remove and discard the casing from the chouriço and break the sausage into small bits. Heat a medium saucepan over low heat and sauté until the sausage starts to brown, 8 to 10 minutes. Add the butter and stir until it melts. Increase the heat, add the leek and onion, and sauté until they start to turn translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the garlic and sauté for 1 minute. Add the whole and ground saffron strands.



Add the apples, cherries, and walnuts and sauté until the cherries get plump, 1 minute. Add the vinegar and remove from the heat. Gently fold in the olives, followed by the dried bread. Season with salt. Transfer the mixture to the prepared baking dish.

In a medium bowl, whisk 1 cup [240 ml] of the stock with the eggs, then whisk in the remaining stock. Pour the liquid over the bread mixture in the baking dish and fold in gently to distribute. At this stage, you can let the baking dish sit for 30 minutes before baking, or cover it with plastic wrap and refrigerate overnight.

When ready to bake the stuffing, discard the plastic wrap. If chilled,

leave the baking dish out on the kitchen counter to warm to room temperature, about 15 minutes. Cover the baking dish snugly with a sheet of aluminum foil to form a tight seal and bake for 40 minutes. Lower the heat to 300°F [149°C], remove the foil, and continue to bake, uncovered, until the top is golden brown and crispy and the liquid has completely evaporated, 20 to 30 minutes. A skewer or knife inserted into the center should come out clean. Remove from the oven and let cool for at least 10 minutes. Garnish with the cilantro and parsley and serve warm.



Roasted Tomatoes with Curry Leaves

My first formal introduction to gardening came when we got our backyard in Oakland. I grow all sorts of things—ingredients that are harder to find at grocery stores and the foods I love to eat. Tomatoes fall right into this last category. Sometimes my tomatoes ripen well and sometimes they do fairly okay; this recipe arose out of a need to use the semi-ripe ones or the ones with weaker flavor. I serve this as an appetizer with slices of warm, toasted sour-dough and extra salt and pepper on the side. The oil develops a delicious flavor as it gets infused with the curry leaves and garlic, which makes it the ideal candidate to sop up with bread. For an added layer of flavor, use a smoked flaky salt. As for the tomatoes, you can use any kind and color: cherry and grape varieties, or even some of the small and medium ones; larger tomatoes must be halved before they are roasted. If you can get your hands on them, tomatoes ripened on the vine look very attractive in this dish.

MAKES JUST UNDER 2 LB [910 G]

- ½ cup [120 ml] extra-virgin olive oil
- 2 lb [910 g] small tomatoes
- 4 garlic cloves, unpeeled
- 3 or 4 sprigs fresh curry leaves
- 1 Tbsp coriander seeds, coarsely cracked
- 1 tsp coarsely cracked black pepper
- Coarse sea salt or flaky salt
- Toasted bread, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

This recipe is an experiment in using heat to concentrate and infuse flavor molecules. As the tomatoes roast in the olive oil, the juices evaporate, which concentrates the salt, sugars, glutamate, and other flavors.

The aromatic flavor molecules in the curry leaves and spices are released on heating, and, thanks to their higher solubility in fats and oil, are absorbed by the oil.

Preheat the oven to 320°F [160°C]. Pour the olive oil into a rectangular 9 by 12 in [23 by 30.5 cm] roasting pan.

Rinse the tomatoes carefully under tap water to remove any dirt. Pat them dry and place them in the roasting pan. Smash the garlic cloves with their paper on and toss them into the pan. Add the curry leaves, coriander seeds, pepper, and salt. Fold to coat well.

Roast for about 1 hour, until the tomatoes have burst and lightly caramelized. Remove the pan from the oven and allow to cool before serving. The tomatoes can be stored, covered, for up to 2 weeks in the refrigerator. Serve warm or at room temperature with the toasted bread.

Couscous with Sesame-Roasted Carrots + Feta

While filming a documentary for PBS in Oakland, my friend Jessica Jones (who produced the video) brought in a delicious couscous salad studded with roasted carrots and a bunch of fresh green herbs. At the time, we had just moved into our home and the furniture hadn't arrived yet, so we squatted on the bare wood floors and ravished that dish rather quickly. It ranks as one of the most flavorful meals I've eaten. I might be a little biased because I think Jessica is absolutely wonderful. This couscous dish, inspired by Jess's couscous, is also simple yet elegant.

SERVES 4 AS A SIDE

- For the couscous:
- 1 lb [455 g] carrots, peeled and cut in half lengthwise

8 garlic cloves, peeled

3 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 tsp black sesame seeds

1 tsp white sesame seeds

1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa

Fine sea salt

½ tsp ground black pepper

1 cup [240 ml] low-sodium chicken stock, “brown” vegetable stock (page 57), or water

2 bay leaves

¼ cup [135 g] couscous

2 Tbsp chopped cilantro or flat-leaf parsley

¼ cup [30 g] crumbled feta

2 Tbsp chopped mint

- For the dressing:
- ¼ cup [60 ml] rice wine vinegar

2 Tbsp toasted sesame oil

1 Tbsp maple syrup or 2 tsp honey

½ tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa

Fine sea salt

1 shallot (2 oz [60 g]), thinly sliced

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Observe how vinegar affects the perception of salt in the shallot and sesame oil dressing. Acids increase the perception of saltiness, and you will end up using less salt than you would otherwise.

The shallot is cut thinly enough to pickle quickly when submerged in the acid in the vinegar. Notice how the pinkish-red anthocyanin pigments in the shallots turn a little more intense once they're in the vinegar. The low pH helps intensify the color.



To prepare the couscous, preheat the oven to 425°F [218°C].

Place the carrots in a roasting pan or baking sheet with 4 of the garlic cloves. Add 1 Tbsp of the olive oil, the black and white sesame seeds, and the red chilli flakes and rub with your fingers to coat the carrots and garlic. Season with salt and the black pepper. Roast for 25 to 30 minutes, until the carrots are crispy on the outside and thoroughly cooked and tender on the inside. Watch carefully to prevent the garlic from burning;

it should be just slightly roasted and charred. Remove the cloves with a pair of kitchen tongs if they're cooking too quickly.

Meanwhile, place the stock and the remaining 2 Tbsp of olive oil in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat. Smash the remaining 4 garlic cloves and toss them into the stock along with the bay leaves. Season with salt and bring the stock to a boil. Stir in the couscous, remove from the heat, cover with a lid, and let stand until the couscous absorbs

the stock and swells up, about 5 minutes. Fluff the couscous with a fork.

To make the dressing, combine the vinegar, sesame oil, maple syrup, and chilli flakes in a small bowl. Season with salt. Fold in the shallots and let sit for 15 minutes.

To serve, fold the cilantro into the couscous. Place the roasted carrots and garlic on top. Garnish with the feta and mint. Pour the dressing on top and serve warm or at room temperature.



Roasted Tomato + Tamarind Soup

On a cold day or when you’re feeling a bit under the weather, this is a peppery tomato soup you’ll want to have in your repertoire. This is a soup of contrasting flavors that goes well with a sharp cheddar or salty feta on buttered toast. Kashmiri chilli powder is a mild, bright-red chilli that can be purchased at Indian grocery stores as well as international markets and specialty spice stores.

SERVES 4

- 1½ lb [680 g] large ripe tomatoes, quartered
- 4 garlic cloves, peeled
- 1 tsp black or brown mustard seeds
- 1 tsp coriander seeds
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 1 tsp ground turmeric
- 1 tsp whole black peppercorns
- ¼ tsp asafetida
- 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- Fine sea salt
- 1 tsp red chilli powder
- 1 tsp dark brown sugar or jaggery, plus extra as needed
- 1 Tbsp tamarind paste, homemade (see page 67) or store-bought
- Extra-virgin olive oil or mustard oil, for garnish
- Coarsely ground black pepper, for garnish
- Warm buttered toast, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Tomatoes are a rich source of different taste molecules including salt; preroasting tomatoes concentrates the salts and also creates new flavor molecules in addition to the salt, sugars, and glutamate already present in the tomatoes.

Tamarind provides sourness to complement the sweet, sour, and savory taste of the tomatoes.

Adding a bit of sugar helps reduce the impression of acidity from the tomatoes and tamarind.

Taste this soup when warm and compare with chilled leftovers to observe how the perception of salt and acid changes with temperature. For a hotter feel to the soup, replace the Kashmiri chilli powder with ¼ tsp to ½ tsp of cayenne and a generous pinch of quality red chilli flakes.

Preheat the oven to 425°F [218°C].

Quarter the tomatoes and place them on a baking sheet or roasting pan. Add the garlic, the mustard, coriander, and cumin seeds, turmeric, black peppercorns, and asafetida. Drizzle with olive oil, toss, and season with salt. Roast the tomatoes cut-side up until they start to brown, about 30 minutes. If the garlic starts to burn, remove and set aside. Remove from the heat and transfer the contents of the pan to the bowl of a blender or a food processor.

Add the red chilli powder, sugar, 3 cups [720 ml] of water, and the tamarind. Pulse until completely smooth and combined. Taste and season with salt and/or sugar if needed.

To serve, portion the hot soup into four bowls. Drizzle each with a few drops of olive or mustard oil and a generous sprinkling of black pepper. Serve with warm buttered toast.



Grilled Spiced Chicken Salad with Amchur

This is my weekday afternoon salad. The salad itself is very simple—a splash of lime juice and a bit of amchur for a dose of acidity—but it’s the chicken that carries the strongest punch of flavor. You can also use this chicken in sandwiches for a brunch or picnic menu, served with a little mayonnaise. Depending on what I have at home, I sometimes add 2 Tbsp of fresh herbs such as mint, cilantro, or tarragon. Both breast and thigh meat from the chicken work here.

You will need to plan a few hours in advance to marinate the chicken. Here’s a kitchen trick that I use at home to plan ahead for the week: I marinate the chicken for 1 hour in the refrigerator, then freeze it with the marinade in small batches in resealable bags. Whenever you’re ready to cook the chicken, thaw it in the refrigerator overnight or leave it out on the kitchen counter and then cook it.

SERVES 4

4 boneless, skinless chicken thighs (total weight about 1 lb [455 g])

¼ cup [60 ml] plus 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil (you can use debittered; see case study, page 104), plus extra for greasing

¼ cup [60 ml] red wine vinegar

1 tsp ground coriander

1 tsp ground cumin

1 tsp red chilli powder

1 tsp fine sea salt, plus more as needed

½ tsp freshly ground black pepper, plus more as needed

2 heads butter lettuce (total weight 14 oz [400 g]), leaves separated and torn

3 shallots (total weight 6½ oz [180 g]), thinly sliced

12 oz [340 g] cherry tomatoes, sliced in half

2 Tbsp fresh lime juice

Fine sea salt

Freshly ground black pepper

1½ to 2 tsp amchur

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The marinade for the chicken acts as a flavor booster and also as a brining solution.

The salt and acid present in the vinegar in the brine create favorable conditions for the salt to diffuse and other ingredients to flavor the meat. Together salt and acid affect protein structure and increase the water retention capacity of the chicken breast. The result is a chicken breast that’s juicier and more tender.

Pat the chicken thighs dry with clean paper towels and place them in a resealable bag. In a medium bowl, combine the ¼ cup [60 ml] of olive oil, the vinegar, coriander, cumin, red chilli powder, salt, and black pepper. Pour over the chicken in the bag, shake to coat evenly, and seal. Refrigerate the bag to marinate for at least 4 hours and up to 8 hours. When ready to cook, bring the bag out and leave on the kitchen counter for at least 15 minutes to warm to room temperature.

Heat a grill pan over medium-high heat. Brush the grates with a little oil. Take the chicken thighs out of the bag with a pair of kitchen tongs, tapping them on the side of the

bag to get rid of any excess liquid. Place the chicken on the hot grates and grill until they are completely cooked (165°F [74°C] on an instant-read thermometer) and develop grill marks on each side, 4 to 5 minutes per side. Transfer the chicken to a plate and let rest for 5 minutes. Cut the chicken into strips.

Place the lettuce leaves, shallots, and cherry tomatoes in a large bowl. Whisk the lime juice and remaining 2 Tbsp of olive oil in a small bowl and pour it over the vegetables in the bowl. Season with salt and black pepper and toss to coat evenly. To serve, place the chicken on top of the salad and sprinkle the amchur on top.

Beef Chilli Fry with Pancetta

This is my take on a classic Goan dish that I grew up eating, served over a bowl of warm, Plain Rice (page 310). The classic method does not use pancetta; however, I find it adds a nuanced note of flavor. If you're a meat-and-potatoes type person, this one is for you. The Braised Cabbage with Coconut (page 291) is a good accompaniment to this dish.

SERVES 4

- 4 oz [115 g] diced pancetta
- 2 Yukon gold potatoes (total weight 15½ oz [445 g]), peeled and diced into ½ in [12 mm] cubes
- Fine sea salt
- 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 2 yellow onions (total weight 18 oz [500 g]), cut in half and thinly sliced
- 6 garlic cloves, peeled and minced
- 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated
- 6 cloves, ground
- 1 tsp ground black pepper
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1 tsp ground turmeric
- 1 lb [455 g] flank steak
- 2 Tbsp malt or apple cider vinegar
- ¼ cup [10 g] fresh cilantro, chopped
- 2 or 3 fresh chillies, minced

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Pancetta is a type of cured pork that develops flavor substances during the curing process. When the pancetta is cooked, it acts as a flavor booster by adding a layer of fat and salt that's released by heat.

The flavor boosters are heated in hot oil to extract their fat-soluble fiery molecules. The onion's pungency is tamed by cooking it for a few minutes, which helps make the taste of their sugars more obvious and softens the impact of heat in every bite.

Heat a large stainless-steel or cast-iron saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the pancetta and sauté until the fat renders and the meat starts to brown, 5 to 8 minutes. Add the potatoes and season with salt. Cook until the potatoes turn golden brown and are completely cooked but crispy on the outside, about 30 minutes. Remove the potatoes and pancetta and transfer to a medium bowl.

In the same saucepan, heat the oil over medium-high heat. Add the onions and sauté until they turn translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the garlic and ginger and sauté until fragrant, about 1 minute. Add the ground cloves, black pepper, cinnamon, and turmeric and cook until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Transfer the onions with the spices to a small bowl and leave the saucepan on the stove over medium-high heat.

Pat the steak dry with paper towels. Cut the steak against the grain into ½ by 1 in [12 mm by 2.5 cm] cubes. Season with salt and add the steak to the hot saucepan. Cook until the beef is tender and medium-rare (130°F [54°C] on an instant-read thermometer), 4 to 5 minutes. Turn the heat to low and scrape the bottom of the pan to mix the drippings with the beef. Fold in the cooked potatoes, onions, and pancetta. Sprinkle with the vinegar. Taste and season with salt if needed. Transfer from the heat to a serving dish, garnish with the cilantro and chillies, and serve immediately.





Lamb Chops with Scallion Mint Salsa

The seasoning on these lamb chops envelops them in a jacket of flavor, while the scallion and mint salsa is the bright green scarf that makes it all dressed up for a fancy dinner party. Halve the amount of garlic for a milder flavor. Tourn (page 315) is a great alternative or accompaniment to the salsa.

SERVES 4

For the lamb:

8 lamb rib chops (total weight 2 lb [910 g])

¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lemon juice

4 Tbsp [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil

1 tsp amchur

1 tsp ground black pepper

1 tsp red chilli powder

1 tsp fennel seeds, coarsely cracked

2 tsp kala namak, or more as desired

For the salsa (makes 1½ cups [360 ml]):

½ cup [120 ml] extra-virgin olive oil

¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lemon juice

1 bunch fresh mint (2 oz [55 g]), chopped

4 scallions, both white and green parts, thinly sliced

4 garlic cloves, peeled and minced

1 tsp ground black pepper

1 fresh green chilli, minced

Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Kala namak, or Indian black salt, acts as the brining salt and also as a flavoring agent for the meat.

The combination of salt and acid in the marinade changes the lamb's protein structure. In the case of red meat, the tough collagen starts to solubilize, and the tissue swells as it retains water and is tenderized. The cooked meat will be tender and juicy.

To prepare the lamb, pat the chops dry with clean paper towels and place them in a large resealable bag. In a small bowl, mix the lemon juice, 2 Tbsp of the olive oil, amchur, black pepper, chilli powder, fennel, and kala namak and pour it over the lamb chops in the bag. Seal the bag and shake to coat the chops well. Leave the chops to marinate in the refrigerator for at least 2 hours, preferably 6 hours.

An hour before you're ready to cook, prepare the salsa. In a lidded bowl, mix the olive oil, lemon juice, mint, scallions, garlic, black pepper, and chilli. Taste and season with salt. Cover and let stand until ready to serve.

When you're ready to cook the chops, leave them in the plastic bag out on the kitchen counter for at least 15 minutes to warm to room temperature.

Cook the marinated chops in batches. Heat 1 Tbsp of olive oil in a large stainless-steel or cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. When the pan is hot, lift 4 chops out of the bag with a pair of kitchen tongs and place them on the hot pan for 3 to 4 minutes per side for rare and 5 to 6 minutes per side for medium-rare (on an instant-read thermometer, 145°F [62.8°C] for rare and 160°F [71°C] for medium-rare). Repeat with the remaining 1 Tbsp of olive oil and the remaining chops. Transfer the chops to a plate, tent loosely with foil, and let rest for 5 minutes before serving.

Before serving, garnish the lamb with the scallion mint salsa. Serve warm.

Spiced Fruit Salad

Most recipes capture a point of view in time and are versions of other versions; they reveal how ideas evolve. I originally created a version of this recipe for my column at the *San Francisco Chronicle*, which was inspired by the fruit chaats of India.

SERVES 4

- 1 yellow nectarine or peach (9¼ oz [260 g]), ripe but still firm
- 1 plum (3 oz [85 g]), ripe but still firm
- 14 oz [400 g] mixed grapes
- 12 fresh mint leaves
- 2 Tbsp lime juice
- ¼ cup [60 ml] maple syrup
- 2 Tbsp pomegranate molasses
- 1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa
- ½ tsp fennel seeds, lightly cracked
- ½ tsp freshly ground black pepper
- ½ tsp kala namak, or more as desired

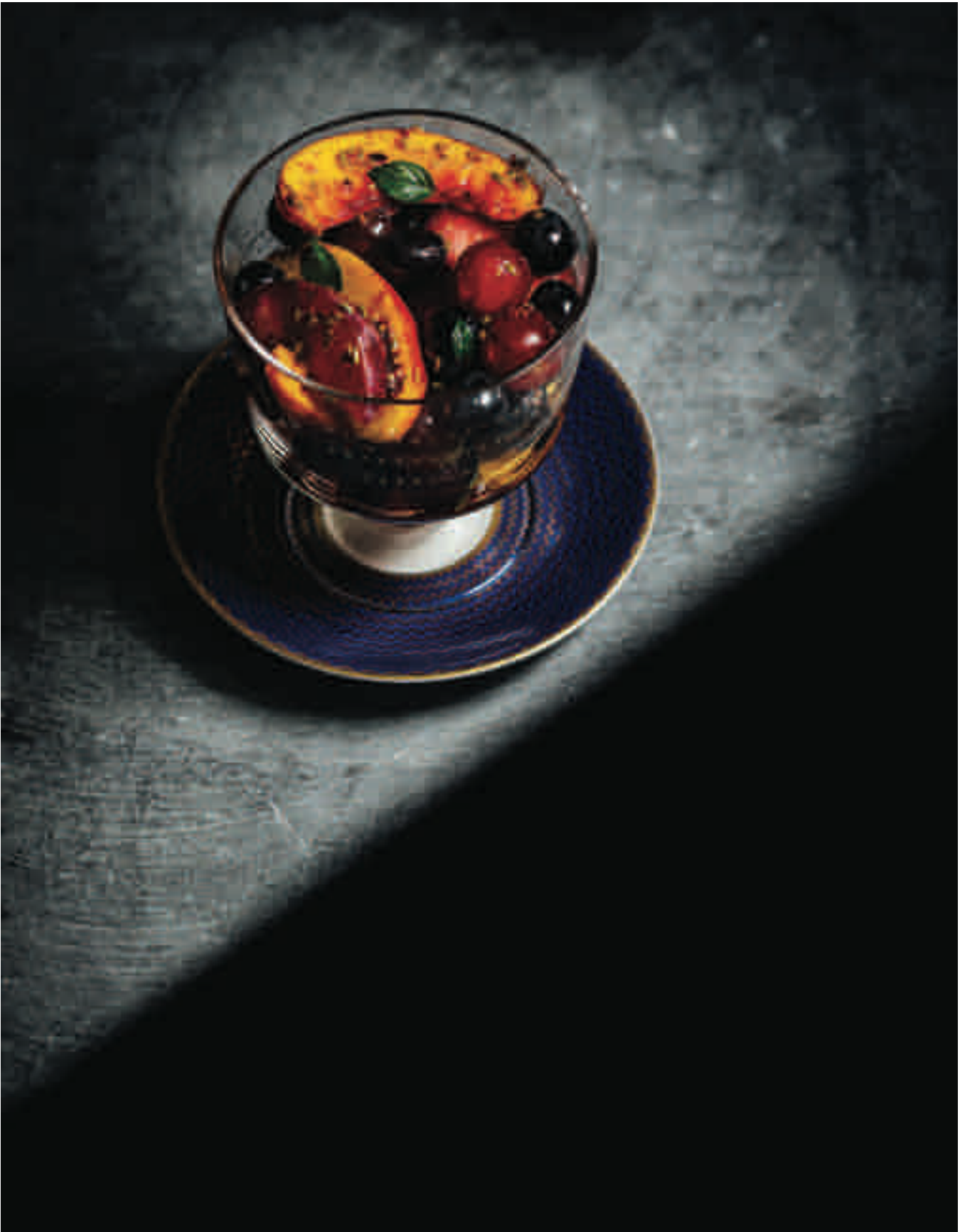
THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Kala namak, or Indian black salt, complements the spices by releasing its unique sulfurous aroma as soon it meets water. The salt and sweeteners help draw out the juices from the fruit through the combined mechanisms of osmosis and maceration.

Cut the nectarine in half and discard the stone. Cut each half into thin slices and place them in a large mixing bowl. Repeat with the plum. Add the grapes to the fruit in the bowl. Add the mint.

Whisk together the lime juice, maple syrup, pomegranate molasses, and red chilli flakes in a small mixing bowl.

Toast the fennel seeds in a small dry skillet over medium-high heat until they just start to turn brown and get fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Quickly transfer to a mortar and pestle, crush to crack the seeds, and add them to the fruit. Add the pepper and kala namak and fold gently to coat. Taste and add more kala namak if needed. Cover the bowl with a lid and allow to sit in the refrigerator for at least 30 minutes before serving.



4

SWEETNESS



THE SWEETNESS SCALE

To create the sweetness scale that can be used to gauge the relative intensity of sweetness of various ingredients, the taste of various sweeteners is compared to table sugar (sucrose). The less sweet a substance, the lower its value. Most sugar substitutes, whether natural like stevia or artificial like sucralose, are extremely sweet when compared to table sugar.

Keep in mind that many of the sweeteners listed in the table here are sold in a solid or liquid form and can behave differently in recipes for cakes and ice creams, and several sweeteners like lactose, honey, maple syrup, molasses, and agave have their own intrinsic aromas and tastes, which will affect the final flavor of the food.

Pure, refined sugar is sweet to taste, but it has no characteristic aroma.

Sugar	% Sweetness*
Starch	0
Cellulose	0
Lactose	20
Maltose	30
Galactose	35
Maple syrup	60
Glucose	70
Molasses	70
Honey	97
Sucrose (table sugar)	100
High-fructose corn syrup	120
Agave	140
Fructose	170
Aspartame	180
Stevia	250
Saccharin	300
Sucralose (Splenda)	600

**Compared to sucrose*

Sweetener	Color and Texture	Aroma and Taste	Description	Uses	Kitchen Notes
Jaggery/Gur	Jaggery comes in various color grades from light brown to dark. The palm variety has a dark, molasses-like color. Sold as a solid block or as a powder. Always store it in a dry, airtight container away from light, as it can absorb moisture quickly from the air.	Less sweet than sugar with a mineral and slightly salty taste. Jaggery obtained from palm sugar has a very different taste, with hints of caramel.	An unrefined sugar obtained from raw sugar cane juice or unfermented palm tree (coconut) sap by boiling the liquid in large pans.	A sweetener often used in Indian cuisine. Use it as you would sugar for a finishing touch on desserts or bread, or incorporate into baking and ice cream recipes. It can be substituted for brown sugar in most recipes.	I prefer the ground, pre-powdered stuff sold in jars in Indian stores because it is much easier to work with. Fresh blocks of jaggery can be chopped with a knife and stored in a sealed container or bag. If too hard, the block can be grated or broken into small pieces with a heavy tool.
Panela	A hard solid that is available in a lighter color, called <i>blanco</i> , and a darker variety, called <i>oscuro</i> .	The taste is similar to molasses; the oscuro variety has a much stronger flavor.	An unrefined sugar obtained by concentrating sugarcane juice.	A sweetener used in Central and South American cuisines. The names vary by the country and the language (<i>piloncillo</i> / <i>chancaca</i> / <i>rapadura</i>). It's a bit firmer than jaggery and is usually sold in cone-shaped blocks.	Use as a substitute for brown sugar. Grate or chop with a serrated knife before using. If it is too hard, warm it for a few seconds in a microwave to soften.
Brown sugar	Brown-colored sugar crystals that come in two grades: light and dark.	It has a distinct molasses-like flavor. The dark grade brown sugar has a richer molasses flavor.	A refined sugar prepared by adding molasses to sugar.		Store in a dry container because it absorbs moisture easily. Can be used in sweet and savory preparations.
Raw sugar	A purified form of sugar available in different varieties: Demerara is white sugar with added molasses; Barbados/Muscovado is moist, dark, with fine-textured grains; Turbinado has light-brown crystals; Sucanat is a branded product, with small brown grainy crystals.	Demerara: toffee-like flavor Barbados/Muscovado: deep, rich, molasses flavor Turbinado: mild caramel flavor Sucanat: intense, smoky molasses taste	The various grades of raw sugar are obtained from purified sugarcane residues during processing of the juice.		Muscovado is a close substitute for jaggery in flavor. Sucanat does not dissolve in liquids quickly and might need to be ground to a powder before use.
White sugar	Pure white, available in crystals of various sizes—coarse to superfine.	Pure sweetness, without aroma.	A refined sugar obtained from sugarcane or sugar beets.		Superfine sugar dissolves quickly and works great in baking and dessert recipes; it is my go-to baking sugar for almost all my dessert recipes. Used in sweet and savory recipes.
Confectioner's sugar, powdered sugar, 10x sugar, icing sugar	A white powder, fine as dust.	No unique aroma or taste, other than sweetness.	Obtained by powdering refined white sugar and mixing it with a small amount of cornstarch to prevent clumping in the presence of moisture.		Used to garnish by sifting over desserts, but do this right before serving, as sugar can absorb moisture quickly and get sticky. It can thicken sauces quickly because the sugar dissolves quickly and also contains a small amount of cornstarch. The presence of cornstarch and the small size of the sugar particles can affect the final shape and texture of cookies and cakes when baking.
Golden syrup, light treacle	A thick, pale golden-yellow liquid.	A noticeable buttery flavor.	Obtained from sugar (sugarcane) but is an invert sugar.	Used in British cuisine, especially in baking.	Used as a sweetener for desserts but also to brush onto the surface of baked breads.

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Molasses	70
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Sucrose (table sugar)	100
High-fructose corn syrup	120
Agave	140
Fructose	170
Aspartame	180
Stevia	250
Saccharin	300
Sucralose (Splenda)	600

*Compared to sucrose

Sweetener	Color and Texture	Aroma and Taste	Description	Uses	Kitchen Notes
Molasses, black treacle (UK)	A thick, viscous, dark-brown liquid.	Sugar cane molasses: First Molasses/Grade A/cane syrup/light molasses/Barbados is the sweetest. Second Molasses/Grade B/dark molasses has a mild bitter taste. Third Molasses/Grade C/blackstrap molasses is less sweet, due to a very low sugar amount, but with a noticeable bitter flavor. Sulfured molasses is obtained by treating the sugarcane with sulfur dioxide fumes, which leaves behind a distinct chemical flavor. Always use unsulfured molasses. Sugar beet molasses is obtained at the final stage. Because of its flavor, unpalatable to humans, it's typically used in cattle feed.	An unrefined sweetener obtained during the production of sugar from sugarcane or sugar beets.	Used in North American and European cuisines in both sweet and savory preparations.	For both savory and sweet cooking, use either light molasses, dark molasses, or black treacle. Never use blackstrap molasses unless specified in a recipe; it has an intense bitter taste and a much lower sugar content, which often leads to undesirable outcomes in both texture and flavor.
Honey	Usually sold in a thick liquid form. Honey powder is a solid form of honey obtained by dehydrating and then grinding honey to produce a fine powder. Raw honey is unpasteurized honey.	Aromas and taste can vary depending on the source of the honey. Some sources include orange blossom, clover, and manuka.	Honey is produced by bees from the nectar they harvest from flowers.	Used in sweet and savory preparations.	
Maple Syrup	Usually sold in liquid form. Maple syrup powder is obtained by removing the water through dehydration. Grade A Maple Syrup classified by color: Light Amber (golden) Medium Amber Dark Amber Very Dark	Grade A Maple Syrup Light Amber: Delicate taste Medium Amber: Rich taste Dark Amber: Robust taste Very Dark: Very strong taste	An unrefined liquid obtained from the sap of maple trees in North America.	Used in sweet and savory preparations.	
Corn syrup	Sold in liquid form. Comes in three grades: light, dark (caramel food coloring is added), and high-fructose corn syrups.	Light corn syrup is flavored with vanilla; dark syrup is flavored with caramel.	Obtained during the processing of cornstarch.	Baking and savory preparation. They are valuable in the preparation of ice creams because they prevent the crystallization of sugars.	
Date syrup (silan; page 324), date molasses	Usually sold in a viscous liquid form; has a dark caramellike color.	Toasty, fruity, molasses-like, mildly acidic taste.	An unrefined sweetener prepared by extracting the sugar from dates in boiling water, followed by concentration.	Used in Persian, Middle Eastern, and North African cuisine.	Used in sweet and savory preparations.
Pekmez	Usually sold in a thick liquid form.	Fruity, molasses-like taste varies depending on the fruits used.	Obtained by concentrating a variety of sugar-rich fruits such as grapes, figs, mulberries, and/or dates.	Used in Turkish, Azerbaijani, and Greek cooking.	Used in sweet and savory preparations.
Malt syrup and extract	A thick, viscous brown liquid.	Has a malt-like aroma.	An unrefined sweetener obtained from germinated whole grains such as barley.	One of the earliest sweeteners known to man.	Used in baking and in sweet and savory preparations.





Baked Sweet Potatoes with Maple Crème Fraîche

We all adore certain pantry staples. Kefir and crème fraîche are two of my favorites. I've been testing new ways to improve on roasting sweet potatoes in the oven, and I found that a combination of steaming and roasting works great for a dish like this for both the texture and the extra set of aroma molecules that comes through. The first step, partial steaming, keeps the moisture inside the sweet potato while cooking, and the second step, uncovered roasting, helps create a robust flavor profile. I recommend using fragrant nuts. Toasted hazelnuts are a good substitute for the peanuts.

SERVES 4

For the sweet potatoes:

4 sweet potatoes (each 7 oz [200 g]), preferably a yellow-fleshed variety such as Garnet or Jewel

2 Tbsp unsalted butter, at room temperature

Fine sea salt

For the dressing:

½ cup [120 g] crème fraîche or sour cream

1 Tbsp maple syrup or honey

1 Tbsp fresh lime juice

2 tsp fish sauce (optional)

½ tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

For garnish:

2 Tbsp thinly sliced scallions, both green and white parts

2 Tbsp roasted peanuts

1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa

½ tsp lime zest

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Butter works as the fat of choice here due to its higher smoke point. As the butter melts, it separates into its constituents—fat, water, sugars, and milk solids—which undergo caramelization and the Maillard reaction.

The sugars concentrate as the water evaporates during cooking.

Fish sauce adds a spot of umami to the sauce, but you can use vegan fish sauce as an alternative.

The peanuts and scallions provide crunch against the softer textures of the potato and the dressing.

To prepare the sweet potatoes, pre-heat the oven to 400°F [204°C].

Rinse and scrub the sweet potatoes under running tap water. Slice them lengthwise and place them in a roasting pan, cut side facing up. Brush with the butter and season with salt. Cover the pan with a sheet of aluminum foil and press around the edges to seal snugly. Bake for 20 minutes. After 20 minutes, remove the foil, flip the sweet potatoes, and cook, uncovered, for 20 minutes more, until the sweet potatoes are cooked thoroughly and are tender; a knife inserted into the center of the sweet

potato should slide through easily. Remove from the heat and let rest for 5 minutes.

To prepare the dressing, in a small bowl, combine the crème fraîche, maple syrup, lime juice, fish sauce, if using, and pepper. Taste and season with salt.

To serve, top the warm roasted potatoes with a few tablespoons of the maple crème fraîche dressing. Sprinkle with the scallions, peanuts, red chilli flakes, and lime zest. Serve with the extra dressing on the side.

Crispy Carrots with Garlic + Mint Tahini

Go for the rainbow variety of carrots if available. Their colors shimmer through the sequined crust of crumbs, making a visual treat full of crunchy goodness. If you love garlic and want a bigger punch of flavor, add a few more cloves. Use either Rice Crumbs (page 310) or breadcrumbs to coat the carrots. Both amchur (ground dried unripe mango) and kala namak (Indian black salt) can be obtained in both crystal and ground form from Indian grocery stores and specialty spice stores. These carrots are also wonderful served with Herbed Yogurt Dressing (page 253).

SERVES 4

For the garlic + mint tahini:

¼ cup [55 g] tahini
¼ cup [60 ml] boiling water
2 Tbsp fresh lemon juice
1 garlic clove
1 tsp dried peppermint, ground
¼ tsp ground cayenne
Fine sea salt

For the carrots:

2 large eggs
2 tsp ground black pepper
½ tsp ground cayenne
Fine sea salt
7 oz [200 g] rice crumbs,
homemade (page 310) or
store-bought
½ cup [120 ml] extra-virgin olive oil
1 lb [455 g] young carrots, cut in
half lengthwise
1 Tbsp amchur
1 tsp kala namak

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Beyond the natural sweetness of carrots, this recipe is about sound and texture. The sizzling sound of crumb-coated carrots frying in hot oil, the fragrant steam that escapes, and the “crunch” of crisped rice crumbs lend unique audio and mouthfeel.

There are two main types of mint sold: peppermint and spearmint. I prefer to use peppermint over spearmint because it contains a few different aromatic substances (menthol, menthone, menthyl acetate, and 1, 8-Cineole) that give it a stronger flavor. If you prefer a milder flavor, use spearmint.

Kala namak is added at the end for unique flavor and saltiness.

Heat the oil in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat to 350°F [177°C].

Meanwhile, dip the carrots in the whisked egg, coating them evenly. Tap to remove any excess liquid and carefully press them into the rice crumb mixture, coating evenly. Shake gently to remove excess crumbs.

Shallow fry the carrots in batches until golden brown on each side, 3 to 4 minutes. The carrots should be completely cooked in the center. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the fried carrots to the wire rack to drain off any excess oil. While still hot, place them on a serving plate. Sprinkle with the amchur and kala namak. Serve hot with the Garlic + Mint Tahini on the side.



Honey + Turmeric Chicken Kebabs with Pineapple

I've always been fascinated with kebabs. I love to watch them being cooked with panache, rotating over a hot charcoal grill or tandoor. Experience, intuition, aroma, and texture all come into play to determine when they're ready. The role of the fruit and vegetables on the skewer is twofold: They add flavor and color, but also secure the meat in place as it cooks. Serve the kebabs with Mint Chutney (page 322) and Masala Parathas (page 297).

SERVES 4 TO 6

For the marinade:

- ¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lime juice
- ¼ cup [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil
- 8 garlic cloves, peeled and grated
- 2 Tbsp honey
- 2 tsp ground black pepper
- 2 tsp ground coriander
- 2 tsp red chilli powder
- 2 tsp ground turmeric
- 2 tsp fine sea salt

For the kebabs:

- 1½ lb [680 g] boneless, skinless chicken breast, cut into 1 in [2.5 cm] cubes
- 1 lb [455 g] ripe pineapple
- 1 large red onion (10½ oz [300 g])
- 1 medium green bell pepper (7 oz [200 g])
- 1 medium red bell pepper (7 oz [200 g])
- 1 medium yellow bell pepper (7 oz [200 g])
- 4 Tbsp [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil
- ½ tsp ground black pepper
- Fine sea salt

For garnish:

- 2 Tbsp cilantro leaves
- 1 lime, cut into quarters or sixths

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Both honey and pineapple provide a sweet counterpart to the warmer flavors in this dish.

The pineapple and chicken are kept separate until they are threaded onto the skewers. Raw pineapple contains bromelain, an enzyme that breaks down protein molecules into smaller peptides by a process called *proteolysis*. If the chicken and pineapple were kept together in the marinade, the proteins in the chicken breast would be broken down by the enzyme, eventually affecting the texture of the chicken; once cooked, it will appear crumbly on the surface. However, once heated on the skewers, the bromelain loses its ability to break down proteins.

To prepare the marinade, combine the lime juice, olive oil, garlic, honey, black pepper, coriander, chilli powder, turmeric, and salt in a small bowl.

To prepare the kebabs, pat the chicken dry with clean paper towels and place in a resealable bag. Pour the marinade into the bag, seal, and shake to coat the chicken well. Let the chicken marinate in the refrigerator for at least 4 hours, preferably overnight.

When ready to grill, remove the bag from the refrigerator and let the chicken come to room temperature for at least 15 minutes.

Cut the pineapple, onion, and bell peppers into quarters and place them in a large bowl. Add 2 Tbsp of the olive oil and the black pepper. Season with salt and toss to coat evenly.

Thread a skewer with the onion, bell peppers, and pineapple, alternating with the marinated pieces of chicken. Pour the leftover marinade over the kebabs.



Heat a grill over medium heat and oil the grates with a little bit of the remaining oil. Cook the kebabs in batches, turning and basting with the reserved marinade and remaining oil. The kebabs will be ready when the vegetables and chicken are thoroughly cooked and tender, appearing browned and charred in spots, and the internal temperature of the chicken reaches 165°F [74°C], 10 to 12 minutes. If some kebabs

start to cook before the others, move them to the cooler part of the grill to continue cooking. Transfer the kebabs to a plate, cover with a tent of foil, and let cool slightly, 2 to 3 minutes, before serving.

Garnish with the cilantro and serve with the lime wedges on the side.



Masala Cheddar Cornbread

I'm the type of person who adds extra cheese to pizza, so this cornbread is a tribute to my love for cheese. It's a riot of flavor, with sharp cheddar; sweet, tiny nuggets of corn that burst in your mouth; and a little fire from the red chilli flakes.

SERVES 4 TO 6

½ cup [120 ml] melted ghee or unsalted butter, plus a little extra to grease the baking dish

2 cups [280 g] all-purpose flour

2 cups [280 g] medium-grind cornmeal

1 Tbsp baking powder

1 tsp ground coriander

1 tsp ground fennel

1 to 2 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo or Maras

½ tsp ground turmeric

¼ tsp ground cayenne

1½ cups [120 g] grated sharp cheddar

1 cup [144 g] sweet corn kernels, fresh or frozen (if frozen, thaw before use)

¼ cup [50 g] packed dark brown sugar or jaggery

¼ cup [85 g] honey

4 large eggs, at room temperature

2 cups [480 ml] whole milk, at room temperature

2 tsp fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Adding sweet corn kernels to the mixture of flour and cornmeal adds a depth of sweetness.

Dark brown sugar and honey contribute sweetness as well as help with the structure of the bread as it bakes. They also participate in the caramelization and Maillard reaction and introduce new flavor molecules.

Dairy fats, including ghee and cheddar, as well as the lipids in the yolks provide fat in the cornbread, which boosts texture, taste, and aroma.

Turmeric's chief role in this cornbread is as a pigment to increase the rich yellow.

Fennel seeds amplify the perception of sweetness.

Preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C]. Grease a 9 by 12 in [23 by 30.5 cm] baking dish with a little ghee.

In a large bowl, whisk together the flour, cornmeal, baking powder, coriander, fennel, red chilli flakes, turmeric, and cayenne. Reserve 3 Tbsp of the dry mixture.

Toss 1 cup [80 g] of the cheddar and the corn kernels with the reserved 3 Tbsp of the dry mixture in a medium mixing bowl.

In a large bowl, whisk together the melted ghee, brown sugar, honey, eggs, milk, and salt until combined and the sugar is completely dissolved.

Make a well in the center of the dry ingredients in the large mixing bowl. Pour the liquid mixture into the well and whisk until the ingredients are completely combined and there are no visible flecks of the dry ingredients. Using a spatula, fold in the cheddar-corn mixture. Pour the mixture into the greased baking dish and level the surface with the spatula. Sprinkle the remaining ½ cup [40 g] of cheddar over the surface. Bake until the sides are golden brown, and a skewer or knife comes out clean when inserted into the center, 25 to 30 minutes. Serve warm.



Polenta Kheer

On the streets of Mathura in northern India, sweet (*mithai*) makers stir large pans of boiling milk over hot gas stoves. Most of the water evaporates out of the milk and concentrates the flavor, and the milk sugar (lactose) slowly caramelizes to give the milk a delicious flavor. This forms the basis of many milk-based desserts in India, including the rice pudding *kheer*. Here, a can of evaporated milk provides that same caramel flavor and also reduces the cooking time significantly. Rice is the classic grain of choice, but polenta gives a similarly wonderful, comforting texture.

SERVES 4 TO 6

For the kheer:

½ cup [100 g] packed dark brown sugar

20 strands saffron

¼ tsp fine sea salt

1 cup [140 g] coarse-ground polenta

1 cup [240 ml] whole milk

One 12 oz [355 ml] can unsweetened evaporated milk

½ tsp ground green cardamom

½ tsp rose water

For the topping:

2 Tbsp ghee or unsalted butter

½ cup [85 g] diced dried apricots

¼ cup [35 g] raw whole cashews

2 Tbsp raisins

½ tsp ground black pepper

¼ tsp ground green cardamom

¼ tsp fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Sweetness tends to dominate this dish, accentuated by rose water and cardamom. To balance this, I find it helpful to add a bit of black pepper and salt to the topping.

Lightly frying the dried fruit and nuts with the spices draws out the flavorful essential oils, and the heat helps the sugars participate in the caramelization and Maillard reaction, giving you a much more flavorful topping than you would achieve if they were just folded into the milk and boiled.

To prepare the kheer, place 3 cups [720 ml] of water in a large heavy-bottomed saucepan. Grind 2 Tbsp of the brown sugar with 12 of the saffron strands to a fine powder using a mortar and pestle or in a spice grinder. Add the ground powder along with the remaining sugar, whole saffron strands, and salt to the water in the saucepan. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Add the polenta and lower the heat to a gentle simmer. Stir occasionally to prevent burning and sticking to the bottom of the saucepan and cook until the mixture is thick and the polenta completely tender, 30 to 40 minutes. Increase the heat to medium-high, stir in the milk, evaporated milk,

and cardamom, and bring to a boil. Remove from the heat and stir in the rose water. Transfer to a serving bowl.

To prepare the dried fruit and nut topping, melt the ghee in a medium saucepan over medium-low heat. When the ghee is hot, add and fry the apricots, cashews, and raisins until the fruits are plump and the nuts are a light golden brown, 2 to 2½ minutes. Add the pepper and cardamom and season with salt. Sauté for an additional 30 seconds and immediately transfer to a medium bowl. Just before serving, garnish the kheer with the dried fruit and nut topping. Serve the pudding warm or at room temperature.

Cherry + Pepper Granola Bars

A good dose of black pepper gives these granola bars a little warmth. I sometimes crush these granola bars and sprinkle them over scoops of ice cream or roasted fruit (such as Roasted Fruit with Coffee Miso Tahini, page 125).

MAKES THIRTY-TWO ¹ **BY 2 IN**
[2.5 BY 5 CM] **BARs**

2 Tbsp olive oil, plus extra to grease the pan and your hands

2 cups [200 g] old-fashioned rolled oats

½ cup [70 g] raw cashews

½ cup [70 g] raw pistachios

7 oz [200 g] dried cherries, preferably the sour variety

1 tsp fresh coarsely ground black pepper

½ tsp ground green cardamom

½ tsp fine sea salt

½ cup [120 ml] maple syrup

¼ cup [60 ml] date syrup, homemade (page 324) or store-bought

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

For these bars, I played with different types of sweeteners. Maple syrup is mostly sucrose with very little fructose and glucose; date syrup contains glucose and fructose (in ascending order of concentration).

This recipe uses twice as much maple syrup as date syrup by volume. When the resulting syrup reaches 252°F [122°C] (hard ball stage), the sucrose starts to crystallize as most of the water is removed by evaporation and the sugars are concentrated. This ensures that the sugar will harden as the bars cool off, which prevents the bars from falling apart.

Preheat the oven to 325°F [163°C]. Grease an 8 by 8 by 2 in [20 by 20 by 5 cm] baking pan with a little olive oil and line with parchment paper.

Heat a medium saucepan over medium heat and add the olive oil. When the oil is hot, add the oats and cook until they start to turn light brown, 5 to 6 minutes, stirring occasionally. Add the cashews and pistachios and cook for an additional 2 minutes. Transfer the oat mixture to a large mixing bowl. Fold in the cherries, pepper, cardamom, and salt.

In a medium saucepan, whisk together the maple and date syrups. Heat the saucepan over medium heat, stirring occasionally, until the mixture reaches 252°F [122°C] on an instant-read thermometer (hard ball stage), 8 to 12 minutes. Quickly pour

the hot liquid over the oat mixture in the bowl and fold with a silicone spatula to coat the ingredients well. Transfer the mixture to the prepared pan and, using the spatula, spread and firmly press the oat mixture down in an even layer. Bake until it turns a darker shade of golden brown, 15 to 20 minutes. Remove the pan from the oven, set it on a wire rack, and let cool completely to room temperature in the pan. Once it has cooled, run a knife around the edges of the pan and flip the granola onto a cutting board. Peel and discard the parchment paper. Cut into 1 by 2 in [2.5 by 5 cm] bars. Store the granola bars in an airtight container, with parchment paper between the layers to prevent sticking, for up to 2 weeks.



Raspberry + Stone Fruit Crisp

My mother-in-law introduced me to the bright, sweet world of cobblers, crisps, and other delicious fruit-based desserts. I love their unfussy nature compared to pies, whose crusts usually require a bit of extra planning ahead—and kitchen work.

SERVES 4 TO 6

For the fruit:

3 ripe peaches (total weight
1½ lb [680 g])

3 ripe nectarines (total weight
1 lb [455 g])

3 ripe plums (total weight 9 oz
[255 g])

12 oz [340 g] raspberries

¾ cup [150 g] jaggery or dark
brown sugar

¼ cup [40 g] crystallized ginger

¼ tsp fine sea salt

1 vanilla bean

2 Tbsp fresh lime juice

2 Tbsp cornstarch

For the topping:

1 cup [100 g] old-fashioned
rolled oats

1 cup [100 g] sliced almonds,
with the skin on

¾ cup [150 g] jaggery or dark
brown sugar

¼ tsp fine sea salt

¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter

1 tsp fresh lime zest

1 tsp ground cinnamon

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Butter is heated to produce brown butter, in which the milk proteins and sugars undergo the Maillard reaction and caramelization.

Cinnamon and lime zest are added to the hot fat to dissolve and extract their essential oils.

Stone fruits release a lot of water when heated, which can eventually end up making the crisp topping soggy. To avoid this, cook the fruit and crisp separately, and assemble just before you are ready to serve and eat.

To prepare the fruit, preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C]. Line two baking sheets with parchment paper.

Cut the peaches, nectarines, and plums in half. Remove and discard the center stones and cut the halves into slices. Place in a 9 by 12 by 2 in [23 by 30.5 by 5 cm] baking pan and gently fold in the raspberries, jaggery, ginger, and salt. Cut the vanilla bean in half lengthwise and scrape the tiny seeds out with the tip of a knife. Add the seeds and bean to the fruit. Add the lime juice and gently fold to distribute. Sift the cornstarch over the fruit and fold once again to coat evenly. Set the dish on one of the baking sheets. Bake for 45 to 60 minutes, until the fruit juices are bubbling in the center. Remove from the oven and keep warm.

To prepare the topping, combine the oats, almonds, jaggery, and salt in a medium mixing bowl. Melt the butter in a small saucepan over

medium-low heat until the milk solids separate and start to turn reddish brown, 5 to 8 minutes. Remove from the heat and stir in the lime zest and cinnamon. Scrape the bottom of the saucepan to dislodge any milk solids, pour the hot fat over the oat mixture, and mix with a spatula to coat evenly. Spread the oat mixture out over the parchment paper on the second baking sheet. Bake for 10 to 12 minutes, until the oats and nuts are golden brown. Remove from the oven and let cool for 15 to 20 minutes. Crumble by hand. The crisp topping can be prepared ahead of time and, once cooled completely, stored in an airtight container for up to 1 week.

When ready to serve, top the warm fruit in the baking dish with the warm crisp and serve immediately. You can also serve it warm with scoops of vanilla ice cream. To reheat and serve, preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C] and warm the fruit and crisp.





Semolina Coconut Cookies (Bolinhas)

Coconut fans, this cookie is for you. I like these with a cup of hot, sweetened, milky black tea. *Bolinhas*, as they are called in Goa, are crunchy and crisp, full of coconut aroma and sweetness. You may notice that this cookie uses pound cake ratios to come together. I strongly recommend using a brand of desiccated coconut with a strong coconut aroma, or use a good-quality coconut extract. I use the fine-grade (No. 1) semolina flour; the smaller particle size eliminates the need to soak the cookie batter before baking as is classically done with the coarser variety used in India.

MAKES APPROXIMATELY 24 COOKIES

3 cups + 2 Tbsp [250 g] unsweetened shredded desiccated coconut (see The Flavor Approach)

1½ cups + 1 Tbsp [250 g] fine-grade semolina flour

1¼ cups [250 g] sugar

2 Tbsp ghee or unsalted butter

¼ tsp fine sea salt

1½ to 2 tsp ground green cardamom

1 tsp coconut extract (optional)

3 large egg yolks plus the white of one large egg, lightly whisked together

All-purpose flour, for shaping the cookies

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The aromatic molecules in the ground green cardamom and coconut help amplify the perception of the cookie’s sweetness. You can apply this trick to other sweets too when you want to accentuate the sweetness without increasing the amount of sweetener; use aromatic ingredients and spices, such as cinnamon, nutmeg, orange blossom water, or rose water, that we commonly associate with sweets.

The classic bolinha uses fresh coconut ground to a paste, which yields a smooth texture. I prefer the texture of shredded coconut, so I use a combination of ground and shredded.

You can toast the desiccated coconut before it meets the semolina (see instructions, Coconut Milk Cake, page 306), but remember to cool it before you add it.

Place half of the coconut in the bowl of a food processor and grind it into a fine powder. Mix the ground coconut and remaining shredded coconut with the semolina in a large mixing bowl.

Prepare a simple syrup by combining 1 cup plus 2 tsp [250 ml] of water and the sugar in a medium saucepan and bringing to a boil over medium heat. Stir until the sugar dissolves. Add the ghee and salt and stir until the fat melts. Remove from the heat, pour the hot liquid over the semolina and coconut, and fold with a spatula

until evenly combined. Cover with plastic wrap and let cool to room temperature.

Once the semolina mixture is cooled, sprinkle on the cardamom and coconut extract, if using, and fold to combine. Add the whisked egg yolks and fold into the mixture until combined. Cover the mixture and refrigerate for at least 4 hours and up to 8 hours to let the dough firm up and absorb the flavors.

cont'd

Saffron Swirl Buns with Dried Fruit

When I wanted to pursue my dream of baking, I envisioned owning a tiny little bakery selling only buns. Buns of all sorts, sizes, shapes, and flavors, sweet and savory. Life had different plans for me, but I still bake a lot of buns, sharing them with my friends and neighbors.

Cookbook author and baker extraordinaire Edd Kimber, who writes the blog *The Boy Who Bakes*, first introduced me to the delicious nature of golden syrup; I now use it to brush all my sweet breads. In the United States, you can find Lyle’s Golden Syrup online or anywhere British foods are sold. If you can’t find it, use the substitution I’ve provided. Note: The paddle attachment at low speed does a much better job of mixing this sticky dough than the dough blade.

When ready to bake, preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C] and line two baking sheets with parchment paper.

You can store the wrapped cookie dough for up to 2 weeks in the freezer. When ready to use, leave it out on the kitchen counter for about 15 minutes, until soft enough to be pliable.

To assemble the cookies, work in batches. Lightly dust your hands with a little flour to help prevent

the dough from sticking to the surface of your palms. Take about 2 Tbsp of the dough and shape it into a 1 in [2.5 cm] round patty. Evenly space about 12 patties on each baking sheet. Take the blunt end of a knife and press gently to make three equally spaced parallel cuts in the center of the cookie patty. The cuts do not need to be very deep or go all the way across the diameter of the cookie. Rotate the tray and repeat to create three perpendicular cuts, creating a crosshatch pattern.

Bake two sheets at a time for 25 to 30 minutes, until the cookies turn brown on the edges and light golden brown on top and are firm, rotating the sheets halfway through baking. Remove the sheets from the oven and transfer the cookies to a wire rack to cool completely. Repeat with the remaining cookie dough. The cooled cookies can be stored in an airtight container for up to 1 month in the refrigerator; just remember to bring them to room temperature before serving.

MAKES 12 INDIVIDUAL BUNS

For the dough:

20 strands saffron

¼ cup [50 g] sugar

½ cup [120 ml] whole milk

¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter, cubed, plus extra for greasing

½ tsp fine sea salt

1 large egg, lightly whisked

1½ tsp active dried yeast

2 cups [280 g] all-purpose flour, plus extra for dusting

For the filling:

3½ oz [100 g] sliced almonds, with skins left on

3 oz [85 g] dried apricots, chopped

3 oz [85 g] dried blueberries

3 oz [85 g] dried figs, chopped

¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter, plus extra for greasing

1 tsp ground cinnamon

1 tsp ground green cardamom

1 tsp fresh lemon zest

¼ cup [50 g] packed dark brown sugar

½ tsp fine sea salt

1 large egg

¼ cup [80 g] golden syrup or
¼ cup [85 g] honey mixed with
1 tsp lemon juice

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Unlike cakes and cookies, this basic bun dough calls for a smaller amount of sugar—just enough to provide energy to the yeast for fermentation and leave behind a trace of mild sweetness.

The sweetness in this dessert comes chiefly from the dried fruit filling and the coating of golden syrup.

Yeast gives the bread its light and airy structure through fermentation of the sugars in the dough.

The enzyme amylase from the yeast and flour helps break down the starch into smaller molecules that the yeast utilizes for energy.

To make the dough, grind the saffron with 2 Tbsp of the sugar to a fine powder using a mortar and pestle, then transfer to a small saucepan. Add the remaining sugar and the milk, butter, and salt and warm over medium-low heat to 110°F [43°C], stirring until the butter melts and the sugar dissolves completely. Remove from the heat and stir in the whisked egg and yeast.

Lightly flour a work surface and grease a large bowl. Place the flour in the bowl of a stand mixer and make a well in the center. With the paddle attachment fixed and the speed set to low, slowly pour in the milk mixture. Mix until the dough comes together, 5 to 6 minutes. The dough will be sticky. Using a bowl scraper, turn out the dough onto the floured surface. Knead for 1 minute to bring the dough together, then transfer it to the greased bowl. Cover with plastic wrap and let rise in a warm spot until the dough doubles in size, 1½ to 2 hours.

cont’d



While the dough rises, prepare the filling. Place the almonds and dried fruit in a medium bowl. Melt the butter in a small saucepan over medium-high heat, swirling until the butter melts and the milk solids separate and turn reddish brown, 4 to 5 minutes. Remove from the heat and add the cinnamon, cardamom, and lemon zest. Scrape loose the solids at the bottom of the saucepan with a spatula, then pour the liquid over the almonds and dried fruit. Add the brown sugar and salt and fold to coat evenly. Cover with a lid and let sit for at least 30 minutes.

To assemble the buns, once the dough has doubled in size, line a half sheet pan with parchment paper and lightly dust it with flour. Turn the dough out onto the sheet and roll it

out with a small rolling pin to cover the entire surface.

Sprinkle the dough with the fruit-and-nut mixture and press it in gently. Using the parchment paper as a support, starting from the longer side of the dough, roll up the dough and filling to form a log. Refrigerate the log on the baking sheet for 30 minutes to firm up.

Grease a rectangular 9 by 12 in [23 by 30.5 cm] baking dish with a little butter and line it with parchment paper. Take the baking sheet with the log from the refrigerator and cut the dough with a sharp knife perpendicular to its length into 1 in [2.5 cm] thick sections. Place the sections on the prepared baking dish, spacing them about 1 in

[2.5 cm] apart. Cover loosely with parchment paper and let rise for 1 hour, until they double in size.

Preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C].

Whisk the egg in a small bowl and brush it over the surface of the buns. Bake the buns until they're golden brown, 25 to 30 minutes, turning the sheet halfway through baking. Remove from the oven and dab the buns with the golden syrup all over. Let cool in the baking dish for 15 minutes, then transfer the buns to a wire rack to cool. Serve warm or at room temperature. These buns are best eaten the day they're prepared but can also be wrapped with plastic wrap and stored in an airtight bag for 3 days and rewarmed in the oven at 200°F [93°C].

Peppermint Marshmallows

Come December, we'd dust my grandparent's large wooden dining table with a mixture of cornstarch and confectioner's sugar, and on this we'd roll out logs of marshmallows. I'd joyfully play with the soft pillow-like logs, my arms and face becoming covered in white powder. I've reworked my grandmother's original recipe by adding cream of tartar. Back then in India, corn syrup (glucose) wasn't readily available, so she relied on lime juice to achieve the same result.

MAKES EIGHTEEN ¹ IN
[2.5 CM] SQUARES

- ¼ cup [35 g] cornstarch
- ¼ cup [30 g] confectioner's sugar
- ¾ oz [21 g] granulated gelatin
- 10½ oz [300 g] superfine sugar
- ⅛ tsp cream of tartar
- 2 large egg whites, at room temperature
- ½ to 1 tsp peppermint extract
- Red food coloring or 1 tsp beet powder mixed in 2 Tbsp water
- Neutral oil, for greasing

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

For the Cherry + Pepper Granola Bars (page 186), a higher temperature ensures sugar crystallization, desirable for firm bars that hold together. For marshmallows, sugar (sucrose) must be heated to a lower temperature to prevent crystals from forming.

The acidic cream of tartar also helps prevent sugar crystallization by “inverting” some of the sucrose, which splits into glucose and fructose. Glucose and fructose interfere with sugar crystal formation.

Gelatin is a protein derived from collagen. When mixed with hot water, the granules of gelatin begin to absorb water and swell and form a gel. When combined and whisked with the egg white proteins and sugar, the proteins start to unfold and bond and produce a meshwork that gives the marshmallows their soft texture and airy shape.

The mixture of cornstarch and confectioner's sugar acts like talcum powder; it creates a thin layer over the marshmallows that prevents them from sticking and absorbing moisture from air.

Sift the cornstarch and confectioner's sugar with a fine-mesh sieve over a small mixing bowl. Sift 2 Tbsp of this mixture over a 9 by 9 by 2 in [23 by 23 by 5 cm] baking pan. Reserve the rest.

Pour ½ cup [120 ml] of water into a large, wide, medium heatproof mixing bowl; this will increase the surface area of water available and reduce the chances of the gelatin clumping. Sprinkle the gelatin over the surface

of the water and let sit undisturbed until the gelatin swells and absorbs the liquid, 5 to 6 minutes.

Pour another ½ cup [120 ml] of water into a medium saucepan and add the sugar and cream of tartar. Cover with a lid and heat over medium-low heat until the sugar is completely dissolved and the temperature reaches between 238°F and 240°F [114°C and 115°C] on an instant-read or candy thermometer (soft ball stage).



While the sugar cooks, place the egg whites in the bowl of a stand mixer fitted with the whisk attachment and whisk on medium-high speed until the egg whites turn foamy and eventually produce stiff peaks, about 5 minutes. Set aside.

Once the sugar syrup reaches 238°F to 240°F [114°C to 115°C], pour it slowly into the gelatin, directing a thin stream down the side of the mixing bowl. It will start to foam, and this slow method prevents it from foaming over. Stir with a fork to dissolve the gelatin in the syrup until completely smooth with no undissolved clumps. While whisking the egg whites on medium-high speed, add the hot sugar-gelatin syrup in a thin, steady stream. Once

the syrup is added, continue to whisk for 1 additional minute, then increase the speed to high and whisk until the foam is shiny and satiny white and will hold stiff peaks, 8 to 10 minutes. Add the peppermint extract and whisk for 1 minute on high speed. Stop the mixer and add a few drops of the coloring and whisk for 3 to 4 seconds, just long enough to create a few swirls. Resist the urge to over-mix or it will turn uniformly pink.

Lightly grease a small offset spatula with a little neutral oil. Remove the bowl from the mixer and use a silicone spatula to quickly transfer the mixture to the prepared baking pan; it starts to set quickly once it begins to cool. Use the greased spatula to level the surface. Cover the pan and

allow it to rest for at least 4 hours and preferably 6 hours. The marshmallow is ready once it is completely cooled and spongy to the touch in the center.

To cut, dust a clean surface with a little bit of the reserved cornstarch mixture. Run a small knife around the edges of the pan to release the marshmallow. You might need to gently pull it from the sides to help release it. Cut into 1 in [2.5 cm] squares with a sharp serrated knife (you can grease the knife with a little neutral oil to prevent sticking). Dust the squares with a little bit of the cornstarch mixture and store in an airtight container for up to 1 week.



Hot Honeycomb Candy

Honeycomb candy (also called cinder toffee) is a marvel of science and ingenuity, and it's very easy and fun to make. I've added a pinch of cayenne to give it a little kick of heat. You might notice some darker brown spots; these are normal, indicating greater caramelization wherever the baking soda is a little more concentrated, so the pH is higher.

MAKES 10 ½ OZ [300 G] CANDY

- Neutral oil, for greasing
- 1¼ tsp baking soda
- ½ tsp ground cayenne
- 1 cup [200 g] sugar
- ½ cup [170 g] honey

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Honey, an invert sugar, prevents the crystallization of sugar as it heats to the hard crack stage.

The irresistible spongy-crunchy texture of the honeycomb candy is created by bubbles of carbon dioxide produced when the baking soda (sodium bicarbonate) is added to the hot syrup. Sodium bicarbonate breaks down at 176°F [80°C] to sodium carbonate and carbon dioxide, and the acids in the honey, such as gluconic acid, contribute to a minor degree as they react with the sodium bicarbonate.

Adding cayenne to the hot sugar infuses it with capsaicin, which gives the candy a “hot” taste. If you like it hot, use more cayenne.

A second way to achieve heat in this candy is to use a chilli-infused honey and skip the cayenne.

Grease an 8 in [20 cm] square baking pan with a little oil. Line the bottom and sides with a sheet of foil big enough to allow for a generous overhang on at least two sides; fold this down against the outside of the pan.

Mix the baking soda and cayenne together in a small bowl.

Place the sugar, honey, and ¼ cup [60 ml] of water in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat, stirring with a wooden spoon, until the sugar reaches 300°F [149°C] on a candy thermometer, 8 to 10 minutes. Working quickly, stir in the baking soda mixture with a whisk; the mixture will

foam. Pour the foaming mixture out onto the prepared pan and tilt the pan slightly so the mixture evenly covers the entire bottom. Resist the urge to level it or you will lose the bubbles. Let the pan sit undisturbed to cool completely and harden at room temperature, about 2 hours. Once the candy is set and hard, lift it out of the pan with the help of the overhanging foil around the sides and peel it away. Break the candy into chunks or cut with a sharp serrated knife. It will keep in an airtight container for 3 to 4 days.

No-Churn Falooda Ice Cream

Summers in India are extremely hot and humid, and people find ingenious ways to stay cool. Falooda, which originates from the Persian *faloodeh*, is a chilled milk drink. In its simplest form, it's made with sweetened rose syrup, basil seeds, and vermicelli noodles. Because chia seeds behave just like basil seeds when soaked in water, developing a soft gel-like cloud around each tiny black seed, they make the perfect substitute. The seeds might settle, so I usually stir the ice cream once it's partially frozen to redistribute them.

I first came across no-churn ice creams that use heavy cream and condensed milk in Nigella Lawson's now-classic masterpiece *How to Eat*, which forms the backbone of this recipe.

MAKES
APPROXIMATELY 6 CUPS [1.4 L]

1½ cups [300 ml] heavy cream

One 12 oz [355 ml] can
evaporated milk

1 tsp rose water

½ tsp ground green cardamom

½ tsp beet powder or a few
drops of red food coloring

One 14 oz [400 g] can
sweetened condensed milk

2 Tbsp chia seeds or sweet basil
seeds

¼ cup [30 g] chopped pistachios

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Here, heavy cream provides the structure for the ice cream's texture, which works beautifully in this rendition of falooda.

The chia seeds are soaked in heavy cream; they absorb the water but also get surrounded by a coat of dairy fat, which prevents them from freezing in the ice cream. Consequently, the chia seeds retain their chewiness as well as their crunch.

In this ice cream, sweetness comes from the sugar in the condensed milk as well as the caramelized lactose in the evaporated milk.

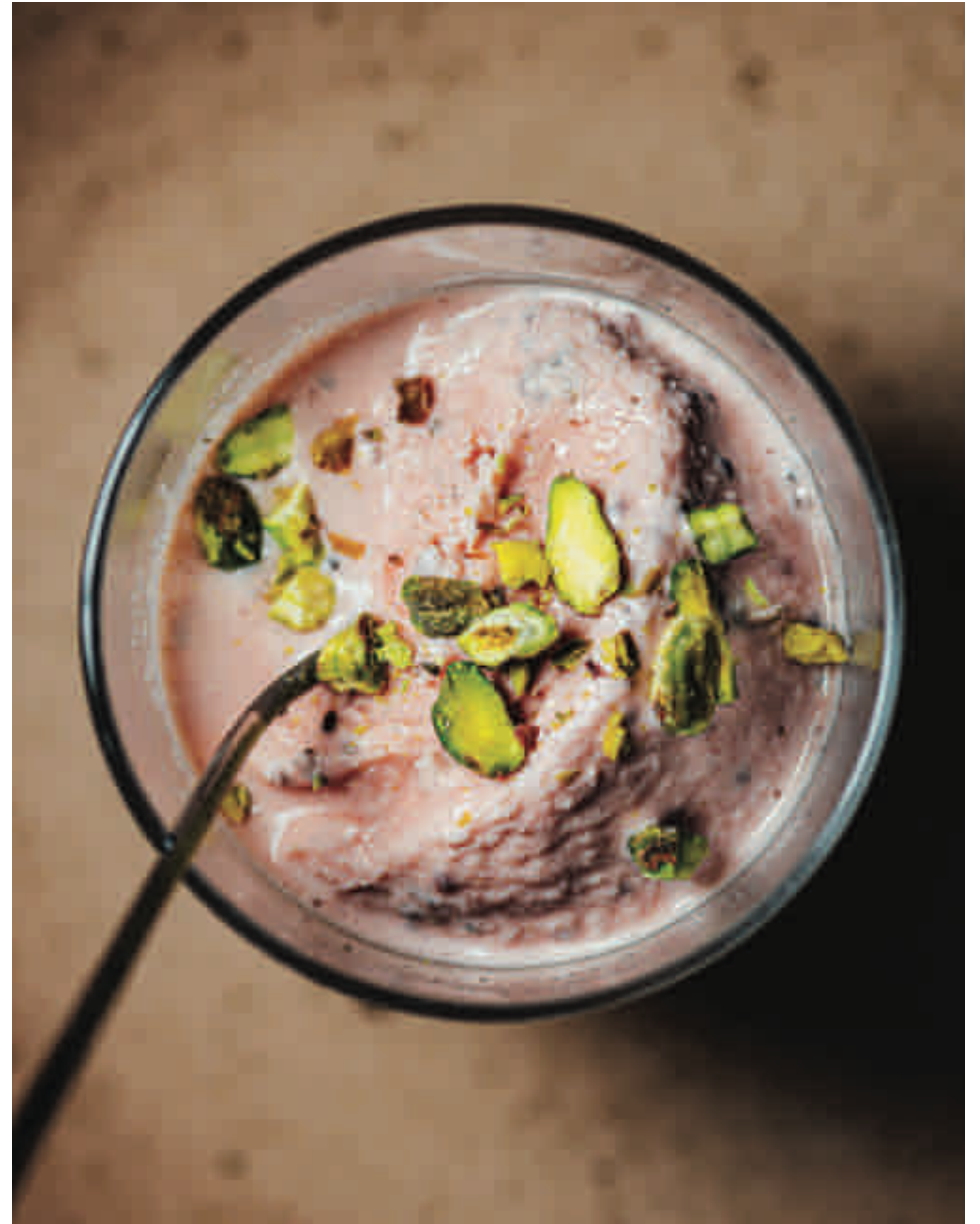
Whip 1 cup [240 ml] of heavy cream with a whisk in a large bowl until soft peaks form.

In a small bowl, mix 2 Tbsp of the evaporated milk with the rose water, cardamom, and beet powder to form a smooth mixture. There should be no visible specks of the red beet powder. Pour this liquid along with the remaining evaporated milk and the condensed milk into the heavy cream and whisk until the liquid is thick, 2 to 3 minutes. Transfer to a freezer-safe container, cover with plastic wrap, and freeze for 1 hour. Mix the remaining ¼ cup [60 ml] of heavy cream with the chia seeds in a

small bowl to swell. Cover and let sit in the refrigerator until ready to use.

Remove the container from the freezer; the mixture will have started to freeze around the edges of the container. Fold in the chia seeds and stir the liquid with a fork. Cover the container with plastic wrap and return it to the freezer. After 2 hours, stir the ice cream with a fork to redistribute the chia seeds and break up any ice crystals. Freeze until the ice cream is firm, at least 4 hours.

When ready to serve, leave the ice cream out for 5 minutes to soften. Garnish with a few chopped pistachios.



5

SAVORINESS





NUTRITIONAL YEAST



WALNUTS



SHIITAKE



BONITO FLAKES



FISH SAUCE

SOY SAUCE



Blistered Shishito/Padrón Peppers with Bonito Flakes

The excitement in eating shishito or padrón peppers is the gamble; you never know which pepper out of the lot will be blazing hot. Full disclosure: I eat only the tame ones but cautiously take a tiny bite every time. Typically, one or a few out of a batch of these curvy peppers will taste fiery. You can easily double this recipe to serve a larger group.

SERVES 4

- 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 12 oz [340 g] shishito/padrón peppers
- 2 Tbsp low-sodium soy sauce
- Flaky sea salt
- 3 to 4 Tbsp bonito flakes

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

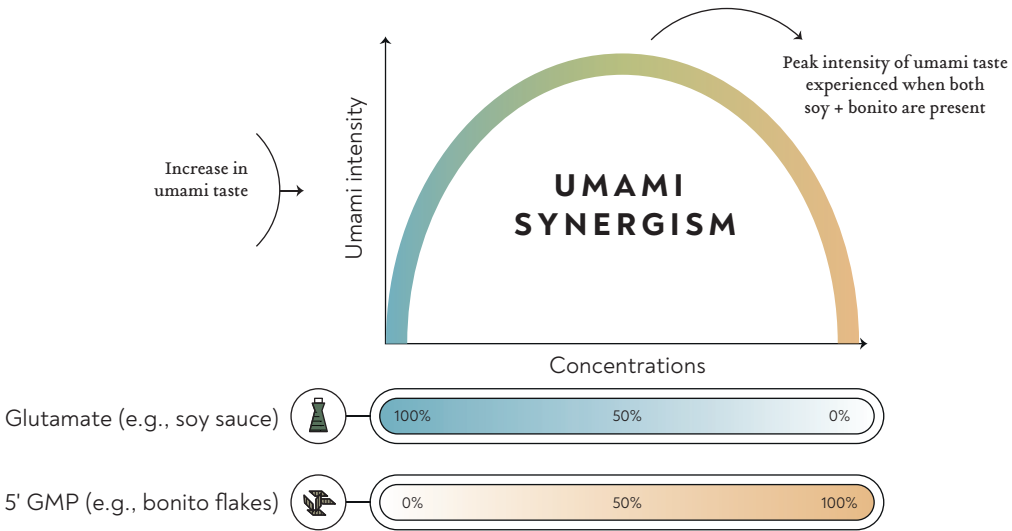
The synergistic effect of soy and bonito flakes comes together in this dish. Try tasting the dish before and after you add the bonito flakes to see for yourself how umami synergism works.

Using a low-sodium soy sauce gives you more control over the amount of salt to use.

Salt helps enhance the umami.

Heat the oil in a medium skillet over medium-high heat. When the oil is hot, add the peppers and sear, turning occasionally, until they develop a few blisters on each side, 2 to 3 minutes. Drizzle with the soy

sauce and toss to coat evenly, cooking for 30 seconds. Remove from the heat and transfer the peppers to a serving dish. Sprinkle generously with the salt and bonito flakes. Serve immediately.



Adapted from Yamaguchi S., Ninomiya K. "Umami and food palatability." *Journal of Nutrition* 130, 4S (2000).

Roasted Broccoli + Chickpea Pancakes

Besan chilla, chickpea pancakes—or chickpea omelets, as my dad calls them—are best eaten as soon as they come off the hot pan. Smear the pancake generously with the Indo-Sichuan Sauce (page 318), throw in a couple of roasted broccoli stalks, wrap, and take a big bite.

SERVES 4

For the broccoli:

2 bunches broccoli (total weight
1 lb [455 g])

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

½ tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

For the pancakes:

2 cups [240 g] chickpea flour

½ tsp red chilli powder

½ tsp ground turmeric

½ tsp fine sea salt

2 Tbsp chopped cilantro

1 green chilli, minced

4 Tbsp [60 ml] extra-virgin
olive oil to fry

½ cup [97 g] Indo-Sichuan Sauce
(page 318)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Broccoli and many other brassicas are rich in glutamates, which gives them a savory aspect that becomes much more apparent on roasting. To increase the umami taste, splash 1 Tbsp of soy or tamari sauce on the broccoli once they're cooked, and swap the fine salt out for an umami-infused salt.

Using a wire rack allows air circulation and prevents the broccoli from sitting in a pool of its own liquid and turning soggy. The broccoli are spread out between two baking sheets to prevent overcrowding. This gives the broccoli a crispy, roasted texture.

Variation: To make a lighter, airier pancake, like the classic American-style pancake, add 1 tsp baking powder along with ½ tsp baking soda and 1 Tbsp of apple cider vinegar to the batter.

To prepare the broccoli, preheat the oven to 425°F [218°C]. Line two baking sheets with aluminum foil and place a wire rack on top of each.

Trim the ends of the broccoli stalks. Rub them with the olive oil, black pepper, and salt. Divide and spread the broccoli over the two baking sheets. Roast the broccoli in the oven for 15 to 20 minutes, until the tops are slightly charred and crispy.

To prepare the pancakes, whisk the flour and 1½ cups [360 ml] of water to form a smooth batter. Whisk in the chilli powder, turmeric, and salt. Fold in the cilantro and chilli.

Heat 1 Tbsp of the olive oil in a cast-iron or stainless-steel skillet over medium-high heat. Stir the batter and pour ¼ cup [60 ml] into the pan, swirling to spread the batter. Cook until the pancake starts to release from the bottom, about 2 minutes. Flip and cook again until the pancake is completely cooked, slightly firm, and golden brown, about 2 minutes. Prepare the remaining pancakes similarly. Transfer to a serving plate and top with some of the roasted broccoli and Indo-Sichuan Sauce.



Chicken Hakka Noodles (Indo-Chinese)

Indo-Chinese food differs quite a bit from familiar Chinese food; to many, it bears little resemblance. But this special cuisine is an integral part of Indian cuisine and is highly celebrated all over the country. Born out of innovation by the original Hakka immigrants who first moved to Kolkata (Calcutta) and by local Indian chefs, an array of recipes that use spices lavishly and defy any rules gave rise, unexpectedly, to a whole new genre of Indian cuisine. It's not that easy to find some of these recipes in restaurants outside India, save for a few large metropolitan areas, and it's even rarer to see them mentioned in Indian cookbooks. Chicken hakka noodles are delicious on their own and really require no other accompaniment besides the Chilli-Soy Vinegar Sauce and the Indo-Sichuan Sauce (pages 317 and 318).

SERVES 4

- 12 oz [340 g] chow mein stir-fry noodles
- Fine sea salt
- 2 Tbsp sesame oil
- 2 Tbsp grapeseed oil or other neutral oil
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- One 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced
- 1 green chilli, minced
- 1 medium onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), halved and thinly sliced
- 1 bunch scallions (about 4 oz [115 g]), both white and green parts, thinly sliced
- 1 tsp ground black pepper
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp red chilli powder
- 7 oz [200 g] green cabbage, shredded
- 1 medium green bell pepper (7 oz [200 g]), thinly sliced
- 5½ oz [155 g] green beans, thinly sliced
- 5½ oz [155 g] carrots, sliced into 1 in [2.5 cm] matchsticks
- 7 oz [200 g] shredded rotisserie chicken, skin and bones discarded
- 2 Tbsp low-sodium soy sauce
- 2 Tbsp rice wine vinegar
- 2 tsp amchur

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The fruity sour taste of amchur is what really makes this noodle dish's flavors stand out against the savory soy and the warmth of the scallions, garlic, and ginger.

Select an oil with a high smoke point if you don't have grapeseed oil (see table of oils and smoke points, page 336). The temperature of the wok should be at about 350°F [177°C] when you stir-fry (I use an infra-red surface thermometer to measure the temperature). At this temperature, the oil starts to shimmer and will be hot enough to cook.

Cook the noodles in a large pot of salted water according to the package instructions. The noodles will be cooked in 3 to 4 minutes, once they are just tender. Drain, rinse under running tap water, and drain again. Place them in a large bowl and drizzle immediately with the sesame oil. Toss to coat the noodles evenly and prevent sticking. Season with salt.

Heat the grapeseed oil in a wok or saucepan over medium-high heat. Add the garlic, ginger, and chilli to the hot oil and sauté until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Add the onions and sauté until they turn translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the scallions and sauté for 1 minute, until they just start to soften. Add the black pepper,

cumin, and red chilli powder and cook until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds.

Add the cabbage, bell pepper, green beans, and carrots and stir-fry until the vegetables are tender-crisp, 3 to 4 minutes. Season with salt. Add the chicken and cook for 1 minute. Transfer the vegetables and chicken to the noodles in the large bowl.

Combine the soy sauce, vinegar, and amchur in a small mixing bowl. Pour the liquid over the noodles in the large bowl and toss to coat evenly with a pair of kitchen tongs. Serve warm.





Stir-Fried Cabbage

This is a simple side dish, yet one that packs savoriness in vegetables. Every ingredient here works in concert to support the umami notes in the cabbage.

SERVES 4 AS A SIDE

1¼ lb [800 g] green cabbage

1 Tbsp grapeseed oil or other neutral oil

1 garlic clove, peeled and smashed

½ tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

1 Tbsp low-sodium soy sauce

1 Tbsp toasted sesame oil

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Another brassica that's rich in glutamate is cabbage, which benefits from the addition of soy sauce as well as toasted sesame oil.

Be sure the cabbage leaves are dried after washing (a salad spinner is helpful); too much water will end up braising the cabbage rather than stir-frying, as the water will cool the wok down considerably.

Select an oil with a high smoke point if you don't have grapeseed oil (see table of oils and smoke points, page 336). The temperature of the wok should be at about 350°F [177°C] when you stir-fry (I use an infra-red surface thermometer to measure the temperature). At this temperature, the oil starts to shimmer and will be hot enough to cook.

Cut the cabbage into large chunks and separate the leaves.

Heat the grapeseed oil in a wok or large stainless-steel saucepan over high heat until it starts to shimmer. Add the garlic and cook until it just starts to brown, 30 to 45 seconds. Add the cabbage and stir-fry until the leaves begin to wilt and get slightly seared, 10 to 12 minutes. Add the pepper and season with salt. Drizzle in the soy sauce and sesame oil and toss to coat. Remove from the heat, transfer to a serving dish, and serve immediately.

Goan Shrimp, Olive + Tomato Pulao

Growing up on the coast, you quickly learn to appreciate the sea and all it offers. Shrimp, both fresh and dried, is a popular staple in Goan cuisine. This is a one-pot dish that really doesn't need anything but a salad on the side. My grandmother used to make this dish by cooking the shrimp with the rice, but there is the added risk of the shrimp overcooking and turning rubbery. Adding the shrimp toward the end avoids this. You can use fresh or frozen shrimp here, but stay away from precooked shrimp because it will leave an unpleasant aftertaste (similar to the reasons why the taste and aroma of fish change when cooked twice).

SERVES 4

- 2 cups [400 g] basmati rice
- 1½ lb [570 g] white onions, cut in half and thinly sliced
- 4 Tbsp [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil
- Fine sea salt
- Two 2 in [5 cm] cinnamon sticks
- 4 cloves
- 1 tsp ground green cardamom
- 4 garlic cloves, peeled and thinly sliced
- One 2 in [5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and cut into 1 in [2.5 cm] matchsticks
- ¼ tsp ground cayenne
- ¼ cup [55 g] tomato paste
- 4 cups [960 ml] low-sodium chicken stock or “brown” vegetable stock (page 57)
- 1½ lb [680 g] medium shrimp, peeled and deveined, tails left on
- 2 Tbsp fresh lemon juice
- One 6 oz can [170 g] large pitted black olives, cut in half, for garnish
- 2 Tbsp scallions, both white and green parts, thinly sliced, for garnish
- Plain unsweetened Greek yogurt, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The concentrated savory taste comes from the combination of tomatoes, olives, and shrimp, and salt helps enhance that effect.

I typically prepare this pulao with chicken stock; however, you can opt to use the “brown” vegetable stock (page 57) for a richer punch of umami.

Preheat the oven to 300°F [149°C]. Set a rack in the upper one-third position. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper.

Check the rice for any debris and soak it in enough water to cover for 30 minutes.

Toss the onions with 2 Tbsp of the oil, season with salt, and spread them out in a single layer on the prepared baking sheet. Roast in the oven until they turn crisp and golden brown, stirring occasionally to redistribute and ensure even browning, about 1 hour. Watch them carefully to prevent them from burning. If the oven is too hot, cook them at mid-level in the oven.

About 5 minutes before the rice soaking time is up, heat the remaining 2 Tbsp of olive oil in a medium saucepan or Dutch oven over medium-high heat. Fry the cinnamon, cloves, and cardamom until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Add the garlic, ginger, and cayenne and sauté until they just start to turn light brown and become fragrant, 1 minute. Stir in the tomato paste and cook for 4 minutes, stirring constantly, until the tomato paste just starts to brown and stick to the pan bottom. Drain the rice, add it to the pan, and fry carefully, stirring and taking care to avoid breaking the grains, until the rice starts to stick to the pan, 2 to 3 minutes.

cont'd



Pour in the stock, increase the heat to high, and bring to a boil. Lower the heat to a simmer, cover with a lid, and cook without stirring till the liquid at the base of the saucepan almost evaporates, 15 to 20 minutes. Season the shrimp with salt and layer the shrimp on top of the rice in the pan. Cover the pan with the lid and continue to cook till the shrimp turn pink, 3 to 4 minutes, and the water evaporates completely.

Sprinkle with the lemon juice. Remove from the heat and let sit for 5 minutes before serving. Fluff the rice with a fork, fold the shrimp in carefully, and transfer to a serving dish. Garnish with the olive halves and scallions and serve warm with yogurt.

Chicken Kanji

The Sanskrit *kanji* refers to the thick, starchy water that's left behind when rice is cooked for a while; it is also the origin for congee, which is also eaten in other parts of Asia where rice is a staple. While this is the dish my mother always served me when I was unwell (she cooked it with bits of chicken), I've given it a bit of a makeover and brought in a few spices.

SERVES 4

- For the kanji:

 - ½ cup [100 g] rice
 - 4 chicken thighs (about 1½ lb [680 g]), bone-in and skin left on
 - Fine sea salt
 - 1 Tbsp grapeseed oil or other neutral oil
 - ½ tsp ground black pepper
 - 4 cloves
 - 2 bay leaves
 - 3 shallots (total weight 6½ oz [180 g]), thinly sliced
 - 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- For the chutney:

 - 2 Tbsp [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil
 - ½ cup [20 g] chopped cilantro leaves
 - ¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lime juice
 - 2 garlic cloves, peeled and minced
 - ½ tsp red chilli flakes such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

You can use any kind of rice here; both short-grain and long-grain work well. Unlike the pulaos or other recipes in which long-grain basmati rice is left undisturbed while it cooks, here the rice must be stirred occasionally. This helps break up the grains as they soften, creating a thicker consistency.

The savory character of this porridge-like soup comes from the chicken, which is first seasoned and seared to build flavor molecules through the Maillard reaction.

Lime juice provides the necessary touch of sourness to the taste of the congee.

The crunchy shallots and the sour notes of the chutney provide a much-needed contrast to the smooth and soft texture of this simple dish.

To prepare the kanji, clean and pick through the rice for any debris. Rinse the rice in a fine-mesh sieve under running tap water. Transfer the rice to a small bowl, add enough water to cover, and let soak for 30 minutes.

Use clean paper towels to wipe the chicken and pat dry. Season both sides with salt. Heat the grapeseed oil in a medium saucepan or Dutch oven over medium-high heat. Sear the chicken on each side until the skin turns golden brown, 3 to 4 minutes. Add the black pepper, cloves, and bay leaves and cook until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Drain

the rice, add it to the pan with the chicken, and stir in 2 cups [480 ml] of water. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat, then lower the heat to low and let simmer until the chicken is completely cooked, the rice is falling apart, and the liquid is thickened, 45 minutes to 1 hour. Stir occasionally to break the rice grains. The liquid should have a thick, soupy consistency. Add more water if needed.

Once the chicken is cooked, remove the thighs with a pair of kitchen tongs and separate the meat from the bones. Shred the meat and discard the bones.

While the chicken and rice cook, prepare the shallots. Preheat the oven to 300°F [149°C]. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper.

Trim and discard the ends of the shallots and cut them into thin slices. Toss the shallots with the olive oil in a small bowl and season with salt.

Spread the shallots in a single layer on the prepared baking sheet and cook until the shallots turn golden brown and crisp, 30 to 45 minutes. Stir them occasionally during cooking to ensure even browning.

To prepare the chutney, in a small bowl, whisk together the olive oil,

cilantro, lime juice, garlic, and red chilli flakes. Taste and season with salt.

When ready to eat, serve the kanji warm or hot topped with chicken, shallots, and chutney on the side.





Roast Chicken Thighs + Vegetables

A quick, flavorful chicken recipe with minimal effort. If you have time to marinate the chicken overnight, the flavor will benefit. For a strong dose of umami, use an umami-flavored salt; it will give this a whole new dimension of taste.

SERVES 4

For the chicken:

4 chicken thighs (total weight about 2 lb [910 g]), bone-in and skin left on

For the marinade:

2 garlic cloves, peeled

One 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled

2 Tbsp white vinegar

2 Tbsp Worcestershire sauce

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 tsp fine sea salt

½ tsp black peppercorns

For the roasted vegetables:

1 lb [455 g] new potatoes

8 oz [230 g] sliced mushrooms

1 cup [120 g] fresh or frozen peas (no need to thaw)

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

½ tsp coarsely ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

For garnish:

2 Tbsp chopped chives

1 fresh green or red chilli such as bird's eye chillies, thinly sliced

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Worcestershire sauce acts as the savory booster for the marinade that seasons the chicken.

The fat in the chicken is released during roasting and renders, adding a second component of flavoring to the vegetables in the pan.

Garlic, ginger, peppercorns, and fresh chillies provide the “heat” molecules that act via chemesthesis.

To prepare the chicken, dry it with clean paper towels and place in a large resealable bag.

To prepare the marinade, blend the garlic, ginger, vinegar, Worcestershire sauce, olive oil, salt, and peppercorns on high speed for a few seconds until combined. Pour the marinade over the chicken, seal the bag, shake to coat, and let marinate in the refrigerator for at least 2 hours, preferably overnight.

When ready to cook, set the bag with chicken on the kitchen counter to reach room temperature, about 15 minutes.

Preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C].

To prepare the vegetables, toss the potatoes, mushrooms, and peas in a large bowl with the olive oil and pepper and season with salt. Spread the vegetables out in a large baking pan or roasting dish.

Remove the chicken from the bag and arrange the thighs, skin side up, over the vegetables. Pour any leftover marinade over the chicken thighs. Roast in the oven until the skin on the thighs is browned and crispy and the potatoes are soft and tender, 55 to 60 minutes. The chicken is ready when the internal temperature reaches 165°F [74°C] on an instant-read thermometer. Remove the pan from the oven and let sit for 5 minutes.

Garnish with the chives and chillies and serve.

Shepherd’s Pie with Kheema + Chouriço

Though our family served this only on special holidays such as Christmas or Easter, this is comfort food all the way. I usually use small or medium potatoes, as they take less time to cook than larger ones. Ground beef can be substituted for lamb.

SERVES 6 TO 8

- For the lamb kheema:

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 medium white onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), diced

4 garlic cloves, peeled and minced

1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

1 green chilli, minced

¼ cup [55 g] tomato paste

2 tsp garam masala, homemade (page 312) or store-bought

1 tsp ground turmeric

1 tsp red chilli powder

8 oz [230 g] peas

8 oz [230 g] carrots, cut into 1 in [2.5 cm] matchsticks

6 oz [170 g] chouriço

2 lb [910 g] ground lamb

2 Tbsp all-purpose flour

¼ cup [60 ml] malt or apple cider vinegar

¼ cup [10 g] chopped cilantro leaves

1 tsp fish sauce

- For the mashed potato topping:

1 medium russet potato (1 lb [455 g])

5 oz [140 g] crème fraîche or sour cream

¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter, cubed, at room temperature

1 tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

½ cup [25 g] panko crumbs

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Kheema, or minced meat, appears in several variations throughout India; in this version, chouriço adds a pop of sourness and heat to the savory profile of the meat.

A tiny splash of fish sauce amplifies the umami nature of the filling.

Vinegar adds sourness to balance the stronger flavors from the spices and meat.

Tomato paste adds to the savory character of the meat.

The mashed potatoes retain moisture and stay soft due to the addition of fat.

Panko crumbs provide a layer of crunchiness.



Preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C].

To prepare the lamb kheema, heat the oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add the onion and sauté until it turns translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the garlic, ginger, and green chilli and sauté for 1 minute. Add the tomato paste, garam masala, turmeric, and red chilli powder and cook until the spices are fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Add the peas and carrots, and sauté until tender, 8 to 10 minutes. Remove the chouriço from the casing and break it into small bits. Add it to the skillet and cook until the sausage starts to brown, 4 to 5 minutes. Break the lamb into chunks and add it to the

skillet. Sauté until the lamb starts to brown, 4 to 5 minutes. At this stage, you can remove some of the excess fat using a large spoon and discard. Sift the flour over the meat and fold it in to coat evenly. Add the vinegar and cook, stirring, over low heat until the liquid has almost completely evaporated. Remove from the heat and stir in the cilantro and fish sauce. Transfer the meat to a large baking dish and level with an offset spatula.

Rinse and scrub the potatoes under running tap water. Place the potatoes in a large pot with enough salted water to cover them by 1 in [2.5 cm]. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat, then lower the

heat to medium-low. Cook until the potatoes are completely tender but not mushy, 20 to 30 minutes. Drain the potatoes and set them aside until cool enough to handle.

Peel the potatoes and discard the skins. Mash the potatoes in a large bowl with the crème fraîche, butter, and pepper until smooth. Taste and season with salt. Spoon the mixture onto the meat in the baking dish. Level with an offset spatula. Sprinkle the panko over the layer of mashed potatoes and bake until the top is golden brown, 20 to 25 minutes. Remove from the oven and let rest for 10 minutes before serving.



Coffee-Spiced Steak with Burnt Kachumber Salad

Kachumber is an Indian condiment type of salad (we often serve our salads on the side as part of a larger meal) made with cucumber, onions, and tomatoes. In this version I've reconstructed it, roasting the onions and tomatoes, then adding bits of fresh cucumber—being rich in water, the cucumber is not heated. This “burnt” version pairs well with the grilled steak. Note: The salad can be made a few hours ahead of time.

SERVES 2

For the burnt kachumber salad:

- 12 oz [340 g] cherry or grape tomatoes, cut in half
- 1 medium red onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), peeled and cut in half
- 1 green chilli, cut in half
- 3 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 cucumber (12 oz [340 g]), diced
- 2 Tbsp chopped cilantro
- 2 Tbsp fresh lemon juice
- ½ tsp ground black pepper
- Fine sea salt

For the steak:

- 2 Tbsp coarsely ground coffee beans
- 1 Tbsp coriander seeds, cracked
- 1 Tbsp red chilli flakes, preferably Urfa
- 1 Tbsp fine sea salt
- 1 tsp ground green cardamom
- Two 1 in [2.5 cm] thick rib eye steaks (1 lb [455 g] each)
- 2 to 4 Tbsp melted ghee or extra-virgin olive oil

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Coffee is bitter to taste, but when added to meat in this spice blend, it enhances the savory character.

Urfa biber has a chocolate-like aroma that pairs well with the ground coffee in the steak seasoning.

As the tomatoes and onions cook in the oven, they not only change their flavor, but the tomatoes begin to fall apart and release their juices, which concentrate and create a salsa-like texture that makes it worthy to coat each slice of steak. The tomato flavor molecules concentrate on heating, which adds to the umami profile of the steak.

I've included the steak flipping method as an option in the instructions; this method lets the juices redistribute as the meat cooks by reducing the time for the juices to settle; consequently the risk of the meat drying out is reduced, as explained by Harold McGee in *On Food and Cooking*.

To prepare the kachumber, preheat the oven to 425°F [218°C]. Line a baking sheet with aluminum foil.

Toss the tomatoes, onion, and chilli with 1 Tbsp of the oil. Place the baking sheet on the top rack of the oven and roast for 15 to 20 minutes, until the vegetables just start to get charred and the tomato juices bubble. Turn the oven to the medium broil setting and cook for an

additional 5 to 8 minutes, until the vegetables develop deeper dark char marks and are slightly burnt. Do not overdo it or they will turn very bitter. Remove from the heat and let cool for 10 minutes. (If making ahead of time, store in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 2 days, then proceed with the recipe.)

cont'd



Once the vegetables are cool, chop them coarsely and place them with the cucumber and cilantro in a medium mixing bowl. Add the lemon juice, the remaining 2 Tbsp of olive oil, and the pepper and season with salt. Toss to coat. Keep covered and let rest for at least 30 minutes before serving.

To prepare the steaks, mix the coffee, coriander, red chilli flakes, salt, and cardamom together in a small bowl.

Pat the steaks dry with paper towels and press the spice mixture

generously onto the surface of both sides and let sit at room temperature for at least 45 minutes and up to 1 hour.

When ready to cook, preheat the grill to high and brush the grates with a little ghee. Drizzle about 1 Tbsp of ghee on each side of the steaks. Place them on the hot grill, close the lid, and cook the steaks 3 to 4 minutes per side for rare (120°F [49°C] on an instant-read thermometer) and 5 to 6 minutes per side for medium-rare (130°F [55°C]). Or, if using a grill pan,

heat 2 Tbsp of the ghee over high heat until it smokes and cook the steaks one at a time. If you don't care about the aesthetic of grill marks, flip the steaks as they cook over the hot pan every 30 seconds till they're cooked. Flipping the steaks often allows the juices to redistribute and the meat does not dry out. Transfer the steaks to a plate, tent loosely with foil, and let rest for 5 minutes before serving.

Serve with the burnt kachumber salad on the side.



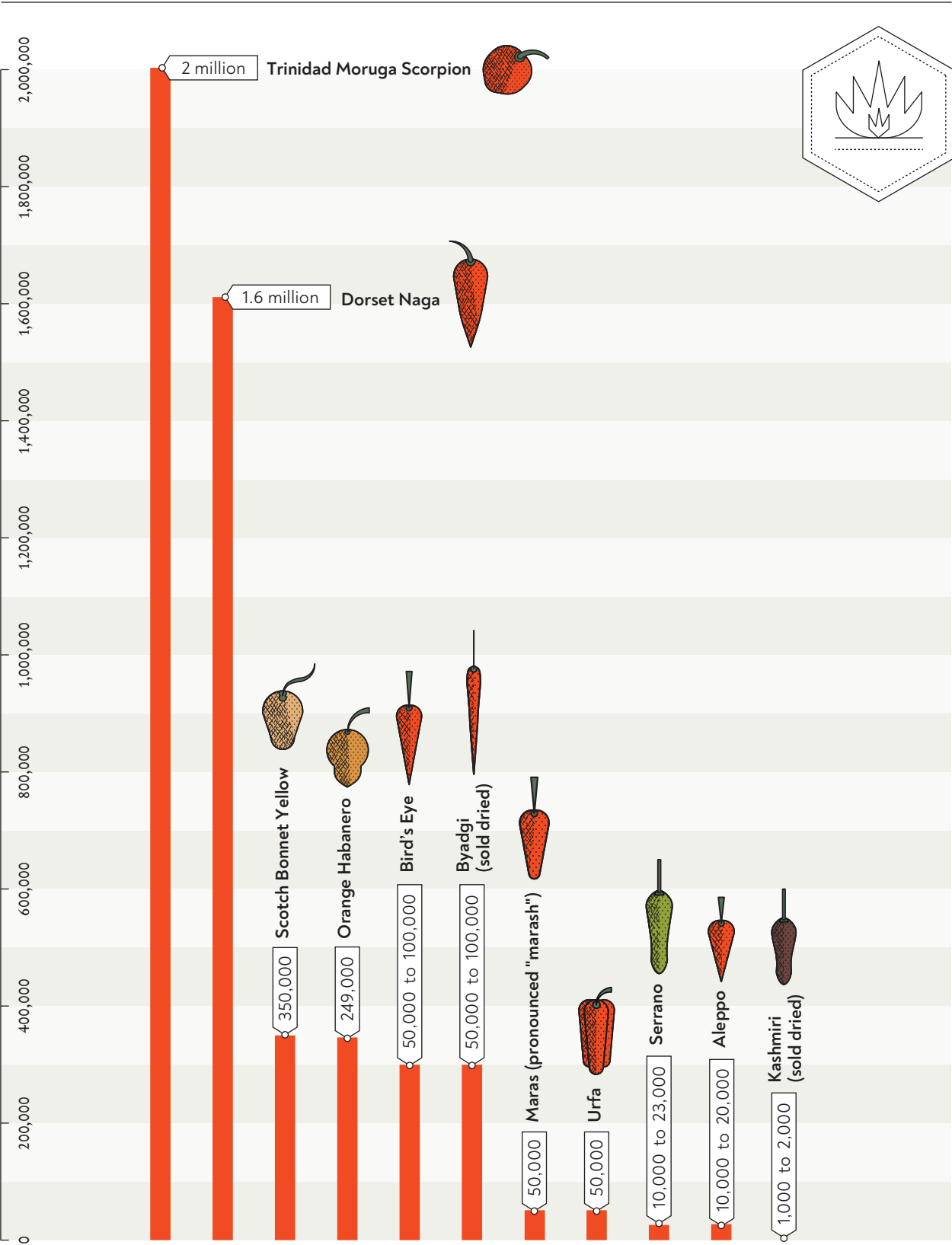
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FIERINESS



CHILLI HEAT SCALE

Total scale runs from 0 to 16 million Scoville Heat Units (SHU).







Chicken Lollipops

A few years ago, I introduced my husband, Michael, to this marvelous hot-and-spicy appetizer. It's become so popular in India that it's not only served at Indo-Chinese restaurants; it's also sold at some of the local bakeries near my parents' home in Bombay. The Indo-Sichuan Sauce (page 318) is the mandatory accompaniment to these lollipops. In many ways, I think of them as India's answer to chicken wings, and I think this is why Michael is so fond of them. And yes, you can adapt this recipe to make chicken wings (use 2 lb [910 g] of chicken wings)—skip the lollipop shaping step and proceed according to the recipe.

SERVES 4

For the chicken:

12 chicken drumettes (total weight 1 to 1½ lb [455 to 680 g])

For the marinade:

2 Tbsp low-sodium soy sauce

2 Tbsp sambal oelek

2 Tbsp rice wine vinegar or apple cider vinegar

8 garlic cloves, peeled and grated

2 in [5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated

1 tsp ground black pepper

½ tsp fine sea salt

¼ tsp cayenne powder

1 large egg white, lightly whisked

4 cups [960 ml] grapeseed oil or other neutral oil, for frying

¼ cup [35 g] all-purpose flour

2 Tbsp cornstarch

1 tsp beet powder or red food coloring

¼ tsp fine sea salt

For the final coating sauce:

1 Tbsp grapeseed oil or other neutral oil

2 Tbsp sambal oelek

2 Tbsp low-sodium soy sauce

4 garlic cloves, peeled and grated

1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated

Fine sea salt, as needed

1 cup [194 g] Indo-Sichuan Sauce (page 318)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Heat comes to these lollipops from a few different places: the fermented sambal oelek, black pepper, garlic, ginger, and cayenne.

Beet root provides the bright red color. The outer crust of flour and egg gives a nice crunchy texture when fried.

Since the marinade and the flour contain salt, I recommend tasting one lollipop to determine if you need to season the final coat of sauce with salt.

To prepare the lollipops, take each drumette by the bone end and make an incision around the exposed bone to release the skin and, using the edge of your blade, push it all the way toward the end. Using the knife tip, tuck the skin into the gap between bone and flesh. You can also remove the skin if you prefer. Nip any ligaments or tendons

that are attached to the bone. The result should resemble a lollipop with all the meat gathered at one end. Place the lollipop in a large bowl and repeat with the remaining drumettes.

cont'd



To prepare the marinade, mix the soy sauce, sambal oelek, vinegar, garlic, ginger, black pepper, salt, and cayenne in a small bowl. Pour this over the chicken lollipops and stir gently to coat evenly. Cover and let rest at room temperature for 30 minutes or in the refrigerator overnight. When ready to fry the lollipops, warm them to room temperature by leaving them out on the kitchen counter for about 15 minutes.

Pour the lightly whisked egg white over the marinated lollipops and turn to coat evenly.

lined with paper towels to drain the excess oil, then transfer them to a large bowl.

To prepare the final coating of sauce for the lollipops, heat the oil over medium-high heat in a small skillet. Add the sambal oelek, soy sauce, garlic, and ginger and cook until the spices are fragrant and the juices bubbling, 1½ to 2 minutes. Lightly season with salt (since the chicken is already seasoned with salt) and pour this mixture over the hot chicken lollipops. Turn to coat well and serve them hot with the Indo-Sichuan Sauce.

Fried Eggs with Masala Hash Browns + Seared Tomato Green Peppercorn Chutney

This was my breakfast on weekends all through grad school, the one meal that I consistently made in my tiny apartment. It works because it contains the proven mathematical combination of crunchy potatoes, fried eggs, and a salty tomato sauce that seems to be appropriate for a lazy Sunday just before the long week starts to rear its head. The seared tomato green peppercorn chutney is something I think you might want to make in a large batch; it is quick to make and pairs well with many different types of savory dishes—try it with roasted butternut or pumpkin slices. This chutney gets better with age.

SERVES 4 WITH 1 CUP [240 ML] SAUCE

For the hash browns:

3 Tbsp ghee

1 lb [455 g] Yukon gold potatoes, diced into ½ in [12 mm] cubes

1 medium yellow or white onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), diced

2 tsp garam masala, homemade (page 312) or store-bought

¼ tsp cayenne powder

Fine sea salt or kala namak

1½ to 2 tsp amchur

2 Tbsp fresh cilantro leaves, for garnish

For the chutney:

12 oz [340 g] cherry tomatoes

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 Tbsp apple cider vinegar

1 garlic clove, peeled

2 Tbsp brined green peppercorns, crushed

1 fresh green chilli

Fine sea salt

For the eggs:

4 Tbsp [55 g] ghee

4 large eggs

Fine sea salt or kala namak

Coarsely ground black pepper

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

I’ve built and layered heat in different ways into the different components of this dish. The warm spices in garam masala work in concert with the cayenne to create heat in the potatoes.

The acidity of amchur makes the heat even more prominent. For a tangier note, use more amchur.

The quality of your cherry tomatoes and the degree of charring will make the flavor of this chutney. Using a large skillet provides a larger surface area for the tomatoes to cook and prevents overcrowding, helping the steam escape.

The tomato chutney gets a mild dose of heat from the brined green peppercorns; the fried eggs get theirs from black pepper.

Additionally, this dish is served warm, which intensifies the chemesthetic quality of these ingredients.

To prepare the hash browns, melt the 3 Tbsp ghee in a large cast-iron or stainless-steel skillet over medium-low heat. When the ghee is hot, add the potatoes and onion. Sprinkle on the garam masala and cayenne and season with salt. Cook until the potatoes are completely tender, turning them every 6 to 8 minutes until they are evenly browned, 25 to 30 minutes. Remove from the heat and season with the amchur. Taste and season with salt. Garnish with the fresh cilantro.

While the hash browns cook, prepare the chutney. Heat a large, dry

stainless-steel skillet over high heat until smoking, 3 to 4 minutes. When the pan is hot, add the tomatoes and cook until they are seared and develop slight char marks all over and the skins start to split, 4 to 6 minutes. Transfer the tomatoes to the bowl of a blender or a food processor. Add the oil, apple cider vinegar, garlic, peppercorns, and chilli and pulse for a few seconds until combined and the peppercorns are broken into bits. The sauce can be slightly chunky or smooth. Taste and season with salt.

To prepare the eggs, heat the ghee in a small cast-iron or stainless-steel

skillet over medium-high heat, swirling to coat. Turn the heat to low. Crack an egg into a small bowl, tip it into the skillet, and cook until the egg white sets and the edges turn crispy, about 1½ minutes. Transfer the egg to a serving plate. (If you want the white to set on top of the yolk, cover the skillet while you cook the egg.) Repeat with the remaining eggs. Season with a little salt and pepper and serve immediately with the warm hash browns and the tomato green peppercorn chutney on the side.





Potato Pancakes

Potato pancakes are the best side to any dish; served warm, their crispy, crunchy texture is perfection. Served as a side with a meal, they work well with Beef Chilli Fry with Pancetta (page 160) or the dal recipes (Garlic + Ginger Dal with Greens, page 256, or Dal Makhani, page 292). I sometimes serve this at lunch with Roasted Eggplant Raita (page 288) and a bowl of Plain Rice (page 310).

SERVES 4 TO 6 AS A SIDE

- 1½ lb [680 g] Yukon gold potatoes, peeled
- 1 medium onion (9¼ oz [260 g])
- 2 fresh chillies, minced
- 2 Tbsp minced cilantro
- 1 tsp amchur
- 1 tsp ground coriander
- ½ tsp ground cumin
- Fine sea salt
- 2 large eggs, lightly whisked
- 1 Tbsp plus 1 tsp ghee, melted

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Fresh chillies give this pancake its fiery note.

The protein in the eggs denature on heating and form a network that binds and holds the ingredients together to form the pancake.

Squeezing the grated potato and onion helps get rid of excess water that would otherwise affect the formation of the egg pancake.

Preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C].

Grate the potato and onion using the large holes on a grater. Over a fine-mesh sieve, squeeze and discard as much liquid as possible out of the potatoes and onion. Place these in a large mixing bowl. Add the chillies, cilantro, amchur, coriander, and cumin and season with salt. Stir gently with a fork to combine evenly. Add the eggs and stir again to combine.

Pour 1 Tbsp of the ghee over the surface of a 10 in [25 cm] oven-proof

cast-iron or stainless-steel skillet over medium-high heat. Spread out the potato mixture to form an even layer, drizzle the remaining 1 tsp of ghee over the surface, and cook until the base just starts to set, 3 to 4 minutes. Remove from the heat and transfer the skillet to the oven. Bake until the top is crispy and golden brown and the potatoes are completely cooked, 15 to 20 minutes.

Slice and serve warm or at room temperature.

New Potatoes with Mustard Oil Herb Salsa

This salsa, a cross between Mexican salsas and Indian chutneys, is my love letter to the wasabi lover. If mustard oil is unavailable, use a good-quality extra-virgin olive oil with a strong, pungent flavor. To make this a more wholesome salad, I sometimes add a chopped shallot, bits of chopped smoked salmon, and even a soft- or hard-boiled egg or two. Note: The nuts must be cooled before they meet the mint, or the mint will turn black.

SERVES 4 PLUS 1 CUP
[256 G] SALSA

For the potatoes:

2 lb [910 g] new potatoes

Fine sea salt

For the salsa:

½ cup [60 g] raw pistachios,
coarsely chopped

½ cup [20 g] packed chopped
mint leaves

½ cup [20 g] packed chopped
cilantro or flat-leaf parsley

½ cup [120 ml] mustard oil or
extra-virgin olive oil (see The
Flavor Approach)

4 or 5 garlic cloves, peeled and
minced

2 Tbsp fresh lime juice

½ tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The pungent flavors of mustard oil and garlic work together to give the potatoes a pop of heat, while the oil brings the fat-soluble taste molecules together.

Lime juice helps embolden the coolness of the fresh herbs.

Potatoes absorb salt very well, so you will need to taste them after they're coated with the salsa and decide if you want to season them further.

If you prefer a milder dose of wasabi flavor, then prepare a mixture with equal parts mustard oil and extra-virgin olive oil and use that.

To prepare the potatoes, scrub them under running cold tap water to remove any dirt. Place them in a medium saucepan with enough water to cover them by 1½ in [4 cm]. Add salt and bring the water to a rolling boil over medium-high heat. Turn the heat to low and let simmer until the potatoes are completely cooked and tender, 15 to 20 minutes. Your cooking time might vary depending on the size of the potatoes and the variety. Drain the potatoes and pat them dry with a clean kitchen towel.

When the potatoes are cool enough to handle, cut them in half and place them in a large mixing bowl.

To prepare the salsa, toast the pistachios in a small skillet over medium-low heat until they just start to brown, 1½ to 2 minutes. Transfer to a small mixing bowl and let cool completely. Add the mint, cilantro, mustard oil, garlic, lime juice, and black pepper. Fold and season with salt.

Add the salsa to the potatoes and toss gently to coat evenly. Taste and season with salt. Serve warm or at room temperature.





Roasted Delicata Squash with Herbed Yogurt Dressing

Delicata is one of the thin-skinned squashes that you do not need to peel before you eat it. Roasting it in oven tenderizes the flesh as well as the skin, making the vegetable easy to eat. This dish is the perfect balance of warm and cool flavors but also temperature.

SERVES 4 AS A SIDE

For the squash:

2 delicata squash (total weight
2 lb [910 g])

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

½ tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

For the herbed yogurt dressing (makes about 1½ cups [300 ml]):

1 cup [240 g] plain unsweetened
Greek yogurt, chilled

1 bunch [75 g] cilantro

1 shallot (2 oz [60 g]), diced

4 garlic cloves, peeled and
minced

1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger,
peeled

1 green chilli

2 tsp fresh lemon juice

Fine sea salt

For serving:

2 Tbsp raw pepitas (pumpkin
seeds)

½ cup [120 ml] Tamarind-Date
Chutney (page 322, optional)

2 Tbsp thinly sliced scallions

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

To make this sauce less allium intense, I've used a shallot, but if you want to tone it down even more, sauté the shallot and garlic (you can also sauté the ginger) in 1 Tbsp of ghee until translucent, then blend it with the rest of the ingredients.

Temperature plays an important role in appreciating the flavors of this dish. The squash is served warm, the Herbed Yogurt Dressing is chilled, and the Tamarind-Date Chutney can be served chilled or at room temperature. This results in different sensations on the surface of the tongue, as your taste receptors are simultaneously sampling and experiencing flavor molecules at different temperatures.

To prepare the squash, preheat the oven to 350°F [177°C]. Line two baking sheets with parchment paper.

Trim the squashes and cut in half lengthwise. Hollow each half out with a spoon to remove and discard the seeds. Cut the squash halves into ¾ in [1 cm] thick crescents and place them in a medium bowl. Drizzle with 1 Tbsp of the olive oil, sprinkle with the pepper, and season with salt. Arrange the squash on the baking sheet in a single layer and roast until the squash is tender and golden brown, 25 to 30 minutes. Remove from the oven and transfer to a serving plate.

To prepare the dressing, place the yogurt, cilantro, shallot, garlic, ginger, green chilli, and lemon juice in a blender. Blend on high speed until combined. Taste and season with salt. Keep chilled.

Toast the pepitas in a small dry skillet over medium-high heat for 2 to 3 minutes, until they just start to brown. Remove from the heat and transfer to a small bowl.

When ready to serve, garnish the squash slices with some of the scallions. Drizzle a few tablespoons of the dressing and the Tamarind-Date Chutney over the squash slices and serve with the remaining dressing and chutney, pepitas, and scallions on the side.



Manchow Soup

This hot and fiery soup is seen only in the Indo-Chinese restaurants of India. When the weather is cold or I'm feeling unwell, I often make this soup. To boost the protein, you can add bits of leftover rotisserie chicken or tofu. Serve this with rice wine vinegar, Chilli-Soy Vinegar Sauce (page 317), or Indo-Sichuan Sauce (page 318) on the side.

SERVES 4

2 Tbsp grapeseed or other neutral oil

8 garlic cloves, peeled and minced

2 in [5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and minced

2 green chillies, minced

5½ oz [160 g] cabbage, finely chopped

5½ oz [160 g] mushrooms, thinly sliced

3½ oz [100 g] green beans, finely sliced

3½ oz [100 g] carrots, finely diced

3½ oz [100 g] green bell pepper, finely diced

3 Tbsp low-sodium soy sauce

1 tsp ground black pepper

3 Tbsp cornstarch

2 large eggs, lightly whisked (optional)

Fine sea salt

3 scallions, both white and green parts, finely chopped

2 Tbsp finely chopped cilantro leaves

4 oz [115 g] fried noodles, store-bought

Rice wine vinegar, for serving

Chilli-Soy Vinegar Sauce (page 317), for serving

Indo-Sichuan Sauce (page 318), for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Using fat extracts the heat from the capsaicin of the chillies as well as the gingerol in ginger and the allium products from the garlic.

Umami-rich flavor boosters like garlic, ginger, and soy sauce are used to take advantage of the synergism effect.

Cornstarch is added at the end at 140°F [60°C] to thicken the soup. Don't add the vinegar until just before serving; added sooner, it would destroy the gel-like structure created by the cornstarch.

Heat a carbon-steel wok or large stock pot over high heat. When the wok is hot, add the oil and stir-fry the garlic, ginger, and chillies for 1 minute.

Add the cabbage, mushrooms, green beans, carrots, and bell pepper and stir-fry until the cabbage just starts to wilt, 2 minutes. Add the soy sauce, black pepper, and 2½ cups [600 ml] of water. Bring to a boil. Remove from the heat and let cool to 140°F [60°C].

Whisk the cornstarch with ½ cup [120 ml] of water in a small bowl to form a slurry, and slowly stir this into the soup. Return the wok to the stove and let it simmer. Cook until the soup thickens, stirring slowly and gently. If you're running low on time, don't cool the soup. Remove the wok from the stove and stir the cornstarch slurry

directly into the hot soup. Return the wok to the stove and let it simmer until it thickens.

Slowly pour in the eggs, if using, while gently stirring the soup; it will form ribbons. Taste and season with salt. Remove from the heat. Stir in the scallions and cilantro.

To serve, divide the hot soup among four bowls and top each with 1 Tbsp of the fried noodles. Offer rice wine vinegar, Chilli-Soy Vinegar, and Indo-Sichuan Sauce on the side.

Garlic + Ginger Dal with Greens

The trick to cooking dal (as with cooking rice) is to leave the lentils alone as they simmer and avoid disturbing them too much. In this case, the lentils will cook slowly and will be creamier in texture when you whisk them gently. There are lots of fun things to do with this dal. Fry a chopped tomato or use fresh green chillies instead of the dried red powder in the tadka. Make it your own!

SERVES 4 TO 6

1 cup [212 g] red lentils

½ tsp ground turmeric

2 Tbsp ghee or a neutral oil

1 cup [60 g] packed chopped kale or spinach leaves

Fine sea salt

1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and cut into matchsticks

2 garlic cloves, peeled and thinly sliced

¼ tsp red chilli powder

¼ tsp asafetida (optional)

Rice or flatbread, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The fat-soluble heat-creating substances in the garlic, ginger, and dried chilli powder are drawn out by heating them in hot oil. This infusion, or tadka, is then poured over the dal as the final garnish.

In addition, the oil also takes on the fat-soluble red pigment from the chillies.

Asafetida (sold as *hing* in Indian stores) is used as an allium substitute in Indian cooking; here it complements the garlic.

Pick through the lentils and remove any stones or debris. Place the lentils in a fine-mesh sieve and rinse under running tap water. Cover the lentils with 2 cups [480 ml] of water in a medium bowl and soak for 30 minutes.

Place the lentils and the soaking water with the turmeric in a medium saucepan and bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Turn the heat to low and let simmer for 10 to 15 minutes, until the lentils are cooked and completely tender. Resist the urge to stir the lentils while they're cooking. If you notice the water getting too low while cooking, add a little more boiling water from a kettle, about ½ cup [120 ml] at a time. If the dal feels too watery, simmer a little longer to cook off some of the liquid. Remove from the heat and lightly whisk the lentils to break them apart. The dal will start to thicken.

Melt 1 Tbsp of the ghee in a separate medium saucepan over medium-high heat. Add the kale and season with salt. Sauté until the leaves start to wilt slightly, 3 to 4 minutes. Fold the kale into the dal. Taste the dal and season with salt.

Next, make the tadka. In a medium saucepan, heat the remaining 1 Tbsp of ghee over medium-high heat. Once the ghee is hot, sauté the ginger and garlic until they just start to turn golden brown, 45 to 60 seconds. (Be careful not to let them burn or they will taste bitter. If that happens, discard and start over.) Remove from the heat and add the chilli powder and asafetida, if using. Pour the hot oil with its contents over the dal. Serve the dal warm with rice or flatbread.



Masala Shrimp

On a trip to Auckland to visit my cousins, we decided to rent out a *bach* (a beach house) and spend Christmas at the beach. We grilled all week and ate a lot of ice cream, as one does in New Zealand. Because shrimp cooks quickly, it became the appetizer of choice to eat while our food cooked on the grill. This dish brings back fond memories of that special holiday.

**SERVES 4 TO 6 AS AN
APPETIZER**

1 lb [455 g] raw medium shrimp,
peeled and deveined, tails left on

2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

2 garlic cloves, peeled and grated

1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger,
peeled and grated

2 Tbsp tomato paste

1 Tbsp fresh lime juice

1 tsp garam masala, homemade
(page 312) or store-bought

½ tsp ground cayenne

¼ tsp ground cinnamon

Fine sea salt

2 Tbsp minced chives, for garnish

1 lime, quartered, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The heat from the cayenne and spices in the garam masala are amplified by the addition of the lime juice.

Lime juice also helps denature the proteins in the shrimp, which cook even faster once heated, so do not over-marinate the shrimp, or they will get rubbery.

Rinse the shrimp under cold running water, pat dry with clean paper towels, and place in a large bowl.

Combine 1 Tbsp of the oil and the garlic, ginger, tomato paste, lime juice, garam masala, cayenne, and cinnamon in a small bowl. Add the shrimp, season with salt, and fold to coat evenly. Let sit for 5 minutes.

Heat the remaining 1 Tbsp of oil in a medium stainless-steel or cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. Add the shrimp with the liquids in the bowl to the hot oil and sauté until they turn pink, 3 to 4 minutes. The tomato paste and shrimp might make it tricky to determine the pink color, so cut a piece of the shrimp in half; the flesh inside should be completely tender and white in addition to the outer surface and tail turning pink.

Transfer the shrimp to a serving plate. Garnish with the chives. Serve immediately with the lime quarters on the side.



Black Pepper Chicken

Before chillies arrived in India, black pepper was an important ingredient that provided heat in cooking. There are a few different versions of black pepper chicken, some dry and some with a more gravy-like sauce. If you prefer a drier chicken, use half the amount of coconut milk indicated in the recipe.

SERVES 4 TO 6

- 2 Tbsp black peppercorns
- 1 tsp coriander seeds, ground
- 1 tsp fennel seeds, ground
- 2 tsp ground turmeric
- 2 Tbsp fresh lime juice
- Fine sea salt
- 3 lb [1.4 kg] boneless, skinless chicken thighs
- 2 Tbsp coconut oil
- 2 large onions (total weight about 1½ lb [800 g]), cut in half and thinly sliced
- 4 garlic cloves, peeled and grated
- 2 in [5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated
- One 13.6 fl oz [403 ml] can full-fat unsweetened coconut milk
- 2 Tbsp chopped cilantro, for garnish
- Plain Rice (page 310), for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The heat in this dish comes from the pepper. For a more pronounced aroma and taste, use Tellicherry peppercorns, inspired by the South Indian stew of the same name.

Fennel seeds and slow-cooked onions provide sweetness to counteract the heat. Onions contain long chains of fructose molecules called *fructans* that break down on heating to release the sweeter-tasting fructose molecules.

Coconut milk is an emulsion of water, fat, proteins, and sugars that provides creaminess.

Use a fragrant coconut oil to get the full impact of coconut fragrance and flavor in this dish.

Grind the peppercorns to a coarse powder. In a small dry skillet or saucepan, toast the pepper, coriander, and fennel until they just turn fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Immediately transfer to a small bowl. Stir in the turmeric and lime juice and season with salt to form a paste.

Place the chicken in a large bowl and massage it with the spice paste. Transfer to a large resealable bag or wrap the bowl with plastic wrap and refrigerate for at least 4 hours, preferably overnight, to marinate.

When ready to cook, set the chicken on the kitchen counter to reach room temperature, about 15 minutes.

Heat the coconut oil in a large saucepan over medium-high heat. Add the onions and sauté for 4 to 5 minutes, until they just turn translucent. Add the garlic and ginger and sauté until fragrant, about 1 minute. Add the marinated chicken with any liquid and the coconut milk, bring to a boil over high heat, then turn the heat to low and cook for 10 to 15 minutes, until the chicken is completely cooked and the liquid becomes a thick sauce. Stir occasionally to prevent burning. Remove from the heat, taste, and season with salt. Garnish with the cilantro and serve with warm rice.





Spiced Roast Chicken

This is an aromatic, colorful, flavorful roast chicken that I make often at home. I shred and store the leftover chicken and use it in wraps or salad. Serve the chicken with Quick Pickled Nectarines with Mint + Serrano (page 319) or Green Apple Chutney (page 321) and Roasted Eggplant Raita (page 288).

SERVES 6

- ¼ cup [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil or melted unsalted butter
- 4 large garlic cloves, peeled and grated
- 2 tsp ground coriander
- 2 tsp dried oregano
- 1 tsp ground black pepper
- 1 tsp ground turmeric
- 1 tsp smoked red paprika
- 1 tsp ground Kashmiri chilli
- 1 tsp kosher salt, plus extra as needed
- One 4 lb [1.8 kg] whole roasting chicken
- Fine sea salt
- 2 cups [480 ml] low-sodium chicken stock
- 1 lemon, cut into wedges, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Placing the chicken on a wire rack set over a roasting pan allows the chicken juices to drip down into the pan, and the chicken skin cooks evenly.

Turmeric and paprika provide both color and flavor.

Paprika and Kashmiri chilli both add a mild yet delicious aroma of smokiness to the meat.

Chicken stock provides moisture and flavor. As the chicken cooks and the juices drip into the pan, the liquid's flavor is enriched, making it a strong basting liquid.

Prepare the seasoning by mixing the olive oil, garlic, coriander, oregano, black pepper, turmeric, paprika, chilli, and salt in a small bowl.

Pat the chicken dry with clean paper towels. Place the chicken on a wire rack set over a large roasting pan or a large, deep baking dish wide enough to hold the chicken comfortably. Slip your fingers between the skin and flesh to loosen the skin. Rub the spice mixture all over the meat and the skin. Sprinkle a little salt over the chicken. Refrigerate the chicken, uncovered, for at least 1 hour, preferably overnight.

Position a rack in the lower third of the oven and preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C]. Place the chicken on the rack and pour the broth into

the pan. Roast the chicken for at least 70 to 80 minutes, basting it with the broth from the pan every 15 to 20 minutes, until the internal temperature registers 165°F [74°C] on an instant-read thermometer and the skin turns golden brown. During roasting, if the liquid in the pan starts to evaporate, add a bit more water, about 1 cup [240 ml]. Remove the chicken from the oven, tent it loosely with foil, and let sit for 10 minutes. Carefully transfer the chicken to a serving platter. Collect any juices that remain in the pan, spoon off the excess fat, and transfer to a small serving bowl.

Serve the chicken warm with the cut lemon wedges on the side and the reserved juices.

Lamb Koftas in Almond Gravy

Koftas are to India what meatballs are to the West. They can be made with any type of ground meat and can be either baked in the oven or fried on the stove. Koftas are typically served in some kind of sauce or gravy. The koftas in this recipe are served with a golden-yellow turmeric sauce thickened with almond flour. My accompanying carbohydrate of choice is the Parathas (page 297) or a bowl of Plain Rice (page 310) with the Cucumber + Roasted Corn Salad (page 287). I often make a large batch of koftas and freeze them, uncooked, on a large plate or tray and then transfer them to a resealable bag and freeze for up to 2 months. When you plan to cook, thaw them overnight in the refrigerator and proceed as instructed in the recipe. I treat koftas like meatballs and sometimes add them (without the almond gravy) to my sandwiches as well as to pizza.

SERVES 4

For the koftas:	1 tsp ground coriander
1 lb [455 g] ground lamb or beef	½ tsp ground turmeric
1 medium white onion (9¼ oz [260 g])	½ tsp red chilli powder
1 tsp ground turmeric	½ cup [30 g] almond flour, blanched or unblanched
1 tsp ground coriander	2 Tbsp white vinegar or lemon juice
1 tsp red chilli powder	Fine sea salt
4 garlic cloves, peeled and minced	
1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated	1 Tbsp fresh mint, for garnish
1 green chilli, minced (optional)	Parathas (page 297) or Plain Rice (page 310), for serving
1 large egg, lightly whisked	
1 tsp fine sea salt	

¼ cup [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil (if frying)

For the gravy:
2 Tbsp ghee, extra-virgin olive oil, or neutral oil
1 medium white onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), minced
2 garlic cloves, peeled and minced
1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Almond flour is used to thicken the sauce; this can occur through the combined action of carbohydrates as well as the fiber in the almonds.

For a silkier texture, blend the sauce at high speed in a blender just before the meatballs are added. Blanched almond flour gives a smoother texture than unblanched because the skins are removed.



To prepare the koftas, line a baking sheet with parchment paper or foil.

Place the lamb in a large mixing bowl. Add the onion, turmeric, coriander, chilli powder, garlic, ginger, green chilli, egg, and salt. Fold to combine evenly. Divide the meat into 12 equal portions by weight and shape into balls using your hands. Place the koftas on the lined baking sheet.

If baking the koftas, preheat the oven to 400°F [204°C]. Bake for 20 minutes, until the koftas turn golden brown all over and are completely cooked, with the internal temperature reaching 160°F [71°C] on an instant-read thermometer. It’s

completely fine if the meatballs are slightly pink in the center. Remove from the oven and reserve any collected juices on the baking sheet.

If frying the koftas, set a wire rack on a baking sheet. Warm the oil in a medium saucepan over medium heat. Fry the koftas in batches until they turn golden brown all over and are completely cooked, 8 to 10 minutes, with the internal temperature reaching 160°F [71°C] on an instant-read thermometer. It’s completely fine if the meatballs are slightly pink in the center. Using a slotted spoon, transfer the koftas to the wire rack to drain any excess oil.

To prepare the gravy, heat the ghee in a medium saucepan or Dutch oven over medium heat. Add the onion and sauté until translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the garlic and ginger and sauté for 1 minute, until aromatic. Add the coriander, turmeric, and chilli powder and cook for 30 to 45 seconds, until fragrant. Stir in the almond flour and cook for 1 minute. Stir in 1 cup [240 ml] of water and add the koftas along with any juices. Bring to a rolling boil over high heat, then reduce to a gentle simmer, cover with a lid, and cook for 5 minutes. Stir in the vinegar. Taste and season with salt. Remove from the heat and garnish with fresh mint. Serve with parathas or plain rice.

Hibiscus (Ginger Pepper) Refresher

This is a wonderful drink to enjoy when the weather gets warm, but I'll admit that I've made it in the cold winter too (it works well with Christmas colors).

SERVES 8

8 oz [230 g] fresh ginger,
preferably young

2 cups [400 g] sugar

½ cup [40 g] packed dried edible
hibiscus petals

5 or 6 long peppers, lightly
cracked

¾ cup [180 ml] chilled water
or club soda

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Hibiscus petals, when steeped in hot water, impart a glorious deep red from their anthocyanin pigments, as well as their aroma and their innate acidity, to create a bold statement.

Hibiscus petals also contain acids, which give this drink a sourness that works with the combination of heat and sweetness. In addition, the low pH of the acids keeps the anthocyanins red in the drink.

Long pepper and ginger provide a subtle note of heat and aroma. If you can't find long pepper, use 1 Tbsp whole black peppercorns and crack them gently before steeping.

Rinse and gently scrub the ginger to remove any traces of dirt. If the ginger is young with a thin skin, leave the skin on; otherwise peel it. Cut into thin slices.

In a medium saucepan, combine the ginger, sugar, and 2 cups [480 ml] of water. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Turn the heat to low, add the hibiscus petals and long pepper, and boil for an additional 5 minutes. Remove from the heat, cover, and let it cool completely to room temperature. You can also leave it overnight in the refrigerator to cool, for a stronger flavor.

Line a fine-mesh sieve with a layer of cheese cloth and set it over a small bowl. Strain the liquid through it, and squeeze the solids left behind in the cloth to extract as much liquid as possible. You can reserve a few teaspoons of the petals to use as a garnish for the drink; discard the remaining solids.

To serve the drink, fill eight tall glasses with ice. Pour ¼ cup [60 ml] of the concentrate into each glass, top with the chilled water, and stir. Garnish with the reserved hibiscus petals. Store any remaining hibiscus syrup in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 1 week.



Gingerbread Cake with Date Syrup Bourbon Sauce

I'm of the opinion that all gingerbread cakes must have ginger in both the ground spice form and a bit of the crystallized form. The Date Syrup Bourbon Sauce gives it that extra edge of smooth richness and is inspired by one of the top-ten desserts I've eaten: the date cake with whiskey sauce at Gjelina in Los Angeles. Use a Microplane zester for the lime zest to get a fine grate.

SERVES 12 / MAKES ONE 9 IN [23 CM] SQUARE CAKE AND 2 CUPS [480 ML] SAUCE

- For the cake:

¾ cup [165 g] unsalted butter, at room temperature, plus extra for greasing

1 Tbsp ground ginger

1 tsp ground black pepper

1 tsp ground green cardamom

1 tsp lime zest

2½ cups [350 g] all-purpose flour

1½ tsp baking soda

½ tsp fine sea salt

2 oz [55 g] crystallized ginger, chopped

¼ cup [50 g] sugar

¼ cup [85 g] honey

1 cup [320 g] unsulfured molasses or sorghum

½ cup [120 g] crème fraîche

2 large eggs, at room temperature

1 cup [240 ml] water warmed to 158°F [70°C]

- For the date syrup bourbon sauce:

2 Tbsp unsalted butter

1 cup [240 ml] date syrup, homemade (page 324) or store-bought

1 cup [240 ml] heavy cream

- 2 Tbsp honey bourbon or whiskey

¼ tsp fine sea salt

For serving:

Lightly sweetened crème fraîche

Fresh lime zest

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Ginger and black pepper give this cake its warmth.

The aromatic molecules in the spices and lime zest are extracted into the butter, where they are highly soluble, before they are incorporated into the cake batter.

There are a few ways to tell if a cake is done: You can insert a skewer through the center, and it should come out completely clean. But you can also tell if a cake is done by gently pressing the surface; it should spring back to its original form in a few seconds. If the cake isn't done, it will remain depressed after the pressure is removed, as the flour has not yet formed the necessary structure.

Grease a 9 in [23 cm] square baking pan with a little butter and line with parchment paper. Grease the parchment paper.

Melt the butter in a small saucepan over medium heat. Remove from

the heat and stir in the ginger, black pepper, cardamom, and lime zest. Let steep for 10 minutes.

Sift the flour, baking soda, and salt through a fine-mesh sieve into a large bowl. Reserve 2 Tbsp of the flour

mixture in a small bowl, add the crystallized ginger to it, and toss to coat well.

Preheat the oven to 325°F [163°C]. Place the sugar, honey, and molasses in the bowl of a stand mixer. Scrape out the melted butter from the saucepan with a silicone spatula and add it to the mixer bowl. Using the paddle attachment, mix on medium speed until it turns a toffee-brown color, 4 to 5 minutes. Stop the mixer and scrape the sides of the bowl, add the crème fraîche, and mix on low speed until combined, 1 minute. Stop and scrape down the bowl. Mix in 1 egg at a time on medium speed until combined. Add the sifted dry ingredients and mix on low speed until combined,

about 30 seconds. Stop and scrape down the sides of the bowl. On low speed, add the water and mix until combined. Remove the bowl from the mixer and scrape the sides. Fold in the crystallized ginger and transfer the cake batter to the prepared baking pan. Bake until the cake is golden brown on the surface and a skewer inserted in the center comes out clean, 50 to 60 minutes. Remove from the oven and let cool completely in the pan. Run a knife along the edges of the pan to release the cake and transfer to a serving plate.

To prepare the date bourbon sauce, melt the butter in a small saucepan over medium-high heat. Swirl the butter in the saucepan until the milk

solids start to turn red. Whisk in the date syrup and bring to a boil. Remove from the heat and whisk in the cream, followed by the bourbon and the salt. Transfer to an airtight jar and refrigerate until ready to use. You can make this sauce 2 days ahead of time.

To serve, cut the cake into slices and serve with sweetened crème fraîche, a little lime zest, and a generous drizzle of the date bourbon sauce.



7

RICHNESS





GRAPSEED OIL



EXTRA-VIRGIN
OLIVE OIL



TOASTED SESAME OIL



MUSTARD OIL



BUTTER

CREAM

GHEE





Burrata with Chilli Oil + Thai Basil

There are two methods for extracting the flavor from Sichuan peppercorns. The first involves toasting for a few seconds, then infusing them into hot oil. The second, and the one that I share here, is from the exemplary Chinese cooking textbook *Phoenix Claws and Jade Trees* by Kian Lam Kho. Here the peppercorns are left to infuse in cold oil for several hours, after which the oil is warmed, keeping it below its smoke point.

To garnish the burrata, I prefer the smaller baby leaves of the Thai basil plant, but you can use the larger leaves; just tear them up into smaller bits.

SERVES 2 TO 4 AS AN APPETIZER

- 1 Tbsp Sichuan peppercorns
- ¼ cup [60 ml] sesame oil
- 1 tsp coriander seeds
- 1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo or Maras
- 8 oz [230 g] burrata cheese
- 1 tsp fresh baby Thai basil leaves
- Flaky sea salt
- Toasted slices of sourdough bread or flatbread, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

In my opinion, using both cold and hot infusions gives a stronger punch of flavor.

Sesame oil carries a nutty aroma. The dairy fats in cheese provide creaminess.

The textures here are a combination of soft, crunchy, smooth, and luscious.

Gently crush the Sichuan peppercorns with a mortar and pestle. Place the peppercorns and sesame oil in a small jar or bowl. Cover with a lid, shake, and leave in a cool, dark place for at least 8 hours, preferably overnight.

Transfer the oil with the peppercorns to a small saucepan. Crush the coriander with a mortar and pestle to form a coarse powder and add it with the chilli flakes to the oil. Heat the saucepan over low heat and bring to 250°F [121°C]. Remove from the heat and let it cool completely to room temperature. Transfer to a small bowl.

Place the burrata on a serving plate. Drizzle 2 to 3 Tbsp of the flavored oil with the spices over the burrata. Garnish with the Thai basil leaves and sprinkle generously with flaky salt. Serve with slices of toasted bread.

Crab Tikka Masala Dip

This is a playful take on tikka masala; it's not as hot or spicy as the usual dish, but still has that edge of flavor that makes this seasoning unique. You can also serve this with a bit of hot sauce on the side; just make sure you eat this while it is warm.

SERVES 6 TO 8

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
2 shallots (total weight 4½ oz [120 g]), minced
2 garlic cloves, peeled and grated
1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and grated
2 tsp ground paprika
2 tsp Kashmiri red chilli powder
1 tsp ground coriander
1 tsp ground cumin
1 tsp ground black pepper
½ tsp grated nutmeg
¼ cup [55 g] tomato paste
8 oz [230 g] cream cheese, at room temperature
5 oz [140 g] crème fraîche
Fine sea salt
1 lb [455 g] precooked jumbo lump crab meat
2 Tbsp fresh lime juice
1 green or red chilli, minced (optional)
2 Tbsp thinly sliced scallions, for garnish
Crackers, toasted slices of naan, or sourdough, for serving

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The generous amount of paprika and chilli powder (along with the tomato paste) provides color. If you decide to substitute a different red chilli powder, keep the level of heat in mind; Kashmiri chilli powder is extremely mild, so you'll need to reduce substitute amounts accordingly.

Cream cheese and crème fraîche provide the fat necessary to give this dish its rich mouthfeel.

Observe how the combination of fat and dairy in this dish reduces the intensity of heat.

Heat the oil over medium-high heat in a medium saucepan. When the oil is hot, sauté the shallots until they turn translucent and just start to brown, 5 to 6 minutes. Add the garlic and ginger and sauté for 1 minute. Lower heat to low. Add the paprika, chilli powder, coriander, cumin, black pepper, and nutmeg and cook until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Stir in the tomato paste and sauté until the tomato paste just starts to brown, 2 to 3 minutes.

Stir in the cream cheese and crème fraîche. Season with salt and fold to combine. Remove from the heat and fold in the crab meat, lime juice, and fresh chilli, if using. Taste and adjust the seasoning if necessary. Transfer to a serving bowl and garnish with the scallions. Serve warm with crackers, toasted slices of naan, or sourdough.





Cucumber + Roasted Corn Salad

A good cucumber salad for summer, this also works well for a barbecue meal. Watch the mustard seeds carefully; if they fry for too long, they will turn bitter. If that occurs, discard and repeat. If you don't want to cook the corn on a cast-iron skillet, you can cook the corn over a grill as done in the Potato + Roasted Corn Herbed Raita (page 78).

SERVES 4

For the salad:

1 sweet corn cob (8 oz [230 g])

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 English cucumber (12 oz [340 g]), diced

1 shallot (2 oz [60 g]), thinly sliced

2 Tbsp cilantro or flat-leaf parsley leaves

2 Tbsp pepitas (pumpkin seeds)

For the dressing:

¼ cup [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil (can be debittered, see case study on page 104)

1 tsp black mustard seeds

¼ cup [60 ml] sherry vinegar

1 tsp fish sauce

1 tsp honey

1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo, Maras, or Urfa

½ tsp ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Extra-virgin olive oil provides the backdrop for the fish sauce that gives this salad a bold kick of umami.

Sweet corn and honey add a pop of sweetness.

Fish sauce adds an umami character to the dressing.

To prepare the salad, heat a large cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. Cut the corn cob in half cross-wise to its length. Coat the skillet with half of the oil and brush the remaining oil over the corn halves. Sear them until they develop deep char marks all over, turning them around in the pan with kitchen tongs every 4 to 5 minutes, 15 to 20 minutes total. Remove the cob halves from the pan and let rest for 5 minutes to cool. Strip the corn kernels from the cob by slicing with a knife, and discard the cob. (For an alternative method, see Potato + Roasted Corn Herbed Raita, page 78). Place the corn kernels in a large mixing bowl with the cucumber, shallot, and cilantro.

Toast the pepitas in a small skillet over medium-high heat until they just start to brown, 1 minute. Add the pepitas to the mixing bowl.

To prepare the dressing, heat 1 Tbsp of the oil over medium-high heat in a small skillet. Add the mustard seeds and fry until the seeds start to sputter and get fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Remove from the heat and pour the liquid into a small mixing bowl. Add the remaining oil, sherry vinegar, fish sauce, honey, red chilli flakes, and black pepper and whisk to emulsify. Taste and season with salt. Pour the dressing over the ingredients in the large mixing bowl and toss to coat evenly. Serve immediately.

Roasted Eggplant Raita

I'm a strong advocate for grilled vegetables and fruits in raitas; you end up with a big boost of flavor. This raita makes an excellent side and could be a meal in itself.

SERVES 4

1 medium eggplant (13 oz [370 g])
1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
Smoked sea salt or fine sea salt
3 shallots (total weight 6½ oz [180 g]), minced
1 green chilli, minced
2 Tbsp chopped cilantro
2 Tbsp chopped mint
½ tsp freshly ground black pepper
1 cup [240 g] plain unsweetened Greek yogurt, chilled
¼ cup [60 ml] water, chilled
1 tsp fresh lime juice
2 Tbsp grapeseed oil or other neutral oil
1 tsp black or brown mustard seeds
1 tsp cumin seeds
1 tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Smoked sea salt amplifies the perception of smokiness in the roasted eggplant.

For a kick of heat, use mustard oil instead of grapeseed oil when tempering the spices. These oils, unlike ghee or coconut oil, remain liquids at low temperatures and will not congeal on the yogurt.

Heating the spices in the hot oil of the tadka helps extract and infuse their flavor molecules into the oil and also adds a crunchy texture.

Preheat the oven to 425°F [218°C].

Cut the eggplant in half lengthwise. Brush the cut surfaces with the olive oil and arrange them in a baking dish or roasting pan, cut side facing up, and roast until the tops are golden brown and slightly charred and they're completely cooked on the inside, about 45 minutes. Remove from the heat, cover with aluminum foil, and let cool completely. Once cooled, remove and discard the skin and chop the flesh. Place the eggplant flesh in a large bowl and season with salt.

Add the shallots, chilli, cilantro, mint, and black pepper.

In a separate bowl, whisk the yogurt with the water and lime juice. Pour the mixture over the vegetables in the large mixing bowl and stir to combine. Taste and season with salt.

In a small, dry saucepan, make the tadka. Heat the grapeseed oil over medium-high heat. Once the oil is hot, add the mustard and cumin seeds and fry until the cumin turns brown and the spices are fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Remove from the heat. Add the red chilli flakes and swirl to mix. Pour the hot oil with the spices over the raita and serve.





Braised Cabbage with Coconut

As a young child, I ate very few different vegetables. In fact, I restricted my vegetable intake to potatoes and cabbage. This was a constant source of frustration for my parents, who tried their best to make me love vegetables. At least once a week, I'd request cabbage *foogath*, in which slender shavings of cabbage leaves are braised and then finished off with a generous sprinkling of soft fresh coconut. (*Foogath* is the Konkani word for braising; the Portuguese name for this dish is *fugad de repolho*.) Serve this dish as a side with rice or bread and a bowl of warm stew or curry. You can also fry a few curry leaves with the spices for added aroma.

SERVES 4 TO 6

2 lb [910 g] green cabbage, shredded

2 Tbsp grapeseed oil or other neutral oil

1 tsp black mustard seeds

1 tsp red chilli flakes

1 medium yellow onion (9½ oz [260 g]), thinly sliced

2 garlic cloves, peeled and minced

½ tsp freshly ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

3 Tbsp grated fresh or thawed unsweetened coconut, for garnish

2 Tbsp chopped cilantro, for garnish

1 green or red chilli, thinly sliced, for garnish

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

The greener parts of the leaves turn brighter as the cabbage cooks, as the breakdown of cell material makes the green pigment appear more intense.

The water trapped inside the cells of the cabbage leaves provides the liquid needed to braise the vegetable. Use a cabbage with thick, firm leaves for this dish; the thinner varieties release a lot of water when braised and fall apart quickly.

The softer texture of fresh coconut pairs well with the tender texture of the braised cabbage leaves.

Coconut is added at the end as a garnish rather than fried or toasted. In this dish, I find fresh and frozen coconut works best; the drier texture of desiccated coconut simply doesn't work as well.

Rinse the cabbage and remove any excess water by patting it dry with clean kitchen towels or using a salad spinner.

Heat the oil in a large saucepan over medium-high heat. When the oil is hot, add the mustard seeds and chilli flakes and cook until the seeds start to pop and sizzle, 20 to 30 seconds. Add the onions and sauté until they turn translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add

the garlic and sauté for 1 minute. Add the cabbage and black pepper and season with salt. Lower the heat to medium-low, cover with a lid, and cook, stirring occasionally, for 10 to 12 minutes, until the leaves are tender but not falling apart. Remove from the heat. Taste and season with salt if needed. Garnish with the coconut, cilantro, and chillies. Serve warm.

Dal Makhani

In India, the word *dal* is an all-encompassing term that includes not only the dish but also lentils and some beans. Dal is a staple in many Indian homes across the world; it's easy to make, comforting, and a great source of protein. One of the things I love about dal is that regardless of the lentil or bean you cook it with, it's a blank slate for flavor. You can use my simple flavor guide to build and layer flavors into your own dal recipes at home; feel free to tweak it and make your own combinations of flavors. Technically, urad dal is not a lentil but the bean of the *Vigna mungo* plant, sometimes sold as black gram. You will need to plan a day in advance to soak the beans.

SERVES 4 TO 6

- 1 cup [200 g] whole urad beans with skin
- ½ cup [60 g] kidney beans (optional)
- ⅞ tsp baking soda
- 1 medium white onion (9¼ oz [260 g])
- 6 garlic cloves, peeled
- 2 in [5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and cut in half
- ¼ cup [55 g] ghee or unsalted butter
- 1 tsp garam masala, homemade (page 312) or store-bought
- ½ tsp ground turmeric
- ¼ cup [55 g] tomato paste
- ¼ tsp cayenne powder
- Fine sea salt
- 2 Tbsp heavy cream or crème fraîche
- 2 Tbsp loosely packed chopped cilantro leaves, for garnish (optional)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Presoaking provides several benefits. The seeds soften and plump up to almost twice their original volume, and their chemical composition changes. The amount of sugars and starches decreases, which helps with cooking, palatability, and digestion.

Adding baking soda to the beans softens the fiber by acting on the pectin and hemicellulose and drastically reduces the cooking time, from several hours to 30 to 45 minutes. Use filtered water if you live in an area with hard water or it might take a bit longer to cook.

Dal makhani is one of the creamiest dals; it leaves a luxurious texture on your tongue imparted by the cream and butter but also by the soft beans. For an extra-rich flavor, top the dal with a few small dabs of salted butter before you add the garnish.

This comfort food contrasts pleasingly with plain rice or flat bread like paratha, and yogurt or raita on the side provide cool contrast.

This dal is special because it gets its unique fiery flavor from the large amount of garlic and ginger used; if you prefer a milder dose of heat, reduce their quantities by half. The hint of cayenne in this dal adds a third note of heat.

The dhungar method of smoking utilizes the principle of smoking fat and infusing it into food by entrapping the smoke in a small enclosed space.

cont'd





Pick through the beans and discard any dirt or stones; transfer to a medium bowl and rinse under running tap water, then add enough clean water to cover the beans by 1 in [2.5 cm] and soak overnight.

The next day, discard the water. Place the beans in a medium saucepan or Dutch oven. Add 4 cups [960 ml] of water and the baking soda and bring the contents to a rolling boil over high heat. Lower the heat to a simmer, cover with a lid, and cook for 30 to 45 minutes, until the beans are tender and almost falling apart. Remove from the heat and transfer the beans with the liquid to a large bowl. Rinse the saucepan and wipe it dry.

Quarter the onion and add it with the garlic in a blender. Mince half of the ginger, add it to the blender, and pulse until it forms a smooth paste. If needed, add a bit of the water from the dal to the blender to help things move around.

Melt 2 Tbsp of the ghee in the saucepan over medium-high heat. Add the garam masala and turmeric and cook for 30 to 45 seconds, stirring constantly, until the spices start to release their aroma. Add the tomato paste and sauté for 2 to 3 minutes. Turn the heat to medium-low, stir in the onion mixture, and cook for 10 to 15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until most of the liquid has cooked away and the ghee separates from the mixture. Return the cooked beans

with their liquid to the saucepan and stir in the cayenne. Season with salt. Increase the heat to high and bring the contents to a boil. Stir occasionally to prevent the beans from sticking to the bottom of the saucepan. Lower the heat to a gentle simmer. Stir in the cream and remove from the heat.

Make the tadka. Melt the remaining ghee in a small, dry saucepan over medium-high heat. Cut the remaining ginger into matchsticks and fry them in the hot ghee for about 1 minute, until the strips just start to turn golden brown. Pour the fried ginger and ghee over the dal. Garnish with the cilantro, if using, and serve hot.

OPTIONAL

The Dhungar Method

This method is used by some to add a smoky aroma to the dal (and other dishes). Do this after the cream is added to the dal, then proceed with fried ginger step. Don't forget to switch the stove off while doing this. The density of the dal will keep the onion or bowl afloat, and it won't sink.

Place the metal bowl or onion in the center of the dal. Using a pair of tongs, burn the charcoal over a flame until it turns red hot. Carefully place the live charcoal in the center of the bowl and drop the ghee on the hot charcoal. It will start to smoke.

Cover the saucepan with a lid to trap the smoke and let it sit for 5 minutes. Remove the lid, the wire rack (if using), and the bowl or onion and safely discard the charcoal. Proceed with the fried ginger in the recipe.

- A small, shallow metal bowl or a medium onion, hollowed out in the center
- 1 to 2 in [2.5 to 5 cm] piece charcoal
- 1 Tbsp ghee



Parathas + Masala Parathas

Parathas were the flatbreads that I ate at home in India. With breakfast, I'd lightly butter the bread and scoop in a bit of marmalade; for dinner, it served as the vehicle to scoop up the various savory dishes served with it. Parathas are soft, flaky, unleavened flatbreads. In principle, they're similar to the idea behind puff pastry, with the dough folded into layers and a fat like ghee keeping those layers separate. As the dough cooks, the moisture is converted to steam, further supporting the flaky layers.

Parathas are shaped by several different methods. The method here is the one used for the *lachha* (pronounced "lutch-ha") paratha, in which the dough is rolled out, drawn into a rope, coiled, and then rolled out again to form a disc. This method introduces many layers into the bread, giving it a flaky texture. Because ghee solidifies at room temperature, the parathas will become stiff when cold. Simply rewarm them on a hot skillet or wrap 4 or 5 parathas in a layer of parchment paper, then in foil, and warm them in an oven at 300°F [149°C] for 6 to 8 minutes.

MAKES 8 PARATHAS

2 cups [320 g] atta or 1½ cups [210 g] all-purpose flour plus ½ cup [70 g] whole-wheat flour

1 tsp fine sea salt

½ cup [100 g] plus 2 Tbsp melted ghee

1 cup [240 ml] water, warmed to 160°F [71°C]

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

In India, unleavened whole-wheat breads, such as parathas and rotis, are made with a stone-ground flour called *atta*. American whole-wheat flours do not yield the same texture as atta for several reasons. There are two types of wheat: hard and soft. These labels are used in reference to the amount of force needed to break the grain (in hard wheat, the protein and starch are tightly bound).

When wheat is ground, the grains pass through a mill, where they are fractured and then broken down to a fine flour using smooth rollers. During this process, the starch granules inside the grain fracture and "damage." Greater *starch damage* leads to more water absorption, a more pliable dough, and increased starch gelatinization.

Because American whole-wheat flour is less finely ground, its starch damage values are much lower than atta's. Atta, made from hard wheat, has a starch damage value between 13% and 18%. American soft wheat is between 1% and 4%, and hard wheat is between 6% and 12%. Atta also contains a higher protein content.

American whole-wheat flours contain larger bits of bran than atta does. These bits of bran act like blades and cut the gluten strands that form in the dough.

To achieve the same texture as atta in my Indian breads, I use a mixture of American whole-wheat and all-purpose flours and reduce the kneading time.

I prefer ghee for its richer flavor, but canola or grapeseed oil can be used.

Sift the atta and salt over the bowl of a stand mixer with a fine-mesh sieve. Using your fingers, massage 2 Tbsp of the ghee into the atta. Attach the paddle attachment to the stand mixer and set the speed to low. While mixing, slowly drizzle in the warm water, 2 Tbsp at a time. Stop adding water when the dough just comes together; you may not need all the water. Stop the stand mixer and scrape any dough off the paddle. Switch in the dough blade and knead the dough for 10 minutes on low speed. For the combination of all-purpose and whole-wheat flours, knead for 5 minutes. If the dough sticks to the bottom of the bowl, stop and scrape it with a bowl scraper, bring the dough together, and continue to knead. The dough

will be soft and pliable when done. Transfer the dough to a clean, dry, lightly floured surface. Knead it for 1 minute and shape it into a ball. Cover the dough with bowl or a wet kitchen towel and let it rest for at least 30 minutes. At this stage you can wrap the dough and refrigerate it in an airtight container for up to 1 week. Be sure to leave it out on the kitchen counter to warm up for at least 30 to 45 minutes and then roll out the parathas.

To prepare the parathas, divide the rested dough into 8 equal parts by weight and shape them into individual balls. Flatten one ball of dough on a dry, flat, lightly floured surface. Roll out the dough into a 6 in [15 cm] disk. Spread a minimal amount of ghee, about 1 tsp, over the surface.

Starting from one edge of the circle, pleat the dough over itself in strips, back and forth, until you reach the other edge, to resemble the pleats of an accordion. Press down the pleats so the stack forms a thick strip. Take one end of the strip and coil it into a solid spiral. Press gently so the spiral becomes a flattened disk. Sprinkle a little flour over the dough and roll it out to again form a 6 in [15 cm] disk. Prepare the remaining balls of dough in this way.

To cook, heat a large skillet over medium-low heat. Once the skillet is hot, set the paratha on the skillet, spread a little ghee on the surface, and cook until the bread starts to turn golden brown and develops blisters, 2 to 3 minutes per side.

Masala Parathas

- 1 shallot (2 oz [60 g]), finely minced
- 1 tsp garam masala, homemade (page 312) or store-bought
- 1 green or red chilli, thinly sliced
- 2 Tbsp chopped cilantro
- 2 tsp dried mint
- 1 tsp amchur

Make sure these ingredients are chopped extremely fine. This helps prevent the dough from tearing while you gently roll out the parathas.

Combine all of the ingredients. Follow the preceding paratha recipe, and after the ghee is massaged into the atta, add this mixture. Then continue with the remainder of the recipe.





Caldine (Goan Yellow Fish Curry)

In terms of heat, this is a mild fish curry from Goa that's very popular with kids; as a bonus, it's a quick and easy recipe. You can use a milder fresh green chilli or skip it, as you prefer. Serve this with bread or rice and a fresh salad or pickle (see Cauliflower Achar, page 320). Any type of white fish and even shrimp work great here but avoid salmon; it doesn't work as well in curries.

SERVES 4

- 4 garlic cloves, peeled
- 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and chopped
- 1 green chilli
- ½ tsp ground black pepper
- ½ tsp cumin seeds
- ½ tsp coriander seeds
- 2 Tbsp coconut oil, ghee, or extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 medium white onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), diced
- ½ tsp ground turmeric
- One 13½ fl oz [400 ml] can full-fat unsweetened coconut milk
- 1 lb [455 g] fish such as cod, cut into 1 in [2.5 cm] cubes
- 1 Tbsp tamarind paste, homemade (see page 67) or store-bought
- Fine sea salt
- 2 Tbsp whole cilantro leaves, for garnish

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Coconut milk, rich in fat, gives this curry its creamy feel.

Coconut milk is an emulsion made up of water, fat, and proteins; the addition of an acid such as that present in the tamarind can destabilize the emulsion in the presence of heat and stirring, so the coconut proteins separate and form aggregates. To avoid this, stir gently, and add the tamarind at the end when the fish is cooked.

Grind the garlic, ginger, green chilli, black pepper, cumin seeds, and coriander seeds to a smooth paste in a blender. Add a few tablespoons of water if needed to loosen things up in the blender.

Heat the coconut oil in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat. When the oil is hot, sauté the onions until they turn translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Add the ground garlic mixture and turmeric and cook, stirring occasionally, until most of the liquid is cooked off and the fat starts to separate from the mixture, 4 to 8 minutes.

Turn the heat to low and stir in the coconut milk. Bring the mixture to simmer. Add the fish and cook until the fish turns opaque and flakes easily, 3 to 4 minutes. Stir in the tamarind and let it simmer for 1 minute. Taste and season with salt and remove from the heat. Garnish with the cilantro and serve warm.

Chicken Coconut Curry

Whenever my grandfather picked up extra coconuts on his trips to the market, my grandmother would separate the flesh from the mature coconuts and dry them in the sun to increase their shelf life. The dried coconut pieces were then ground as needed, and they often made an appearance in curries like this one. Serve this chicken curry over a bowl of warm rice or with large chunks of sourdough bread to sop up the flavorful liquid.

SERVES 4

1 cup [115 g] packed unsweetened fresh, thawed, or desiccated coconut
4 cloves
1 tsp black peppercorns
1 tsp ground coriander
½ tsp ground cumin
6 garlic cloves, peeled
1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and chopped
1 green chilli
2 Tbsp coconut oil, ghee, or a neutral oil
1 large white onion (14 oz [400 g]), halved and thinly sliced
1 tsp ground turmeric
½ tsp Kashmiri red chilli powder
3 lb [1.4 kg] bone-in chicken thighs and drumsticks
2 Tbsp cider vinegar
Fine sea salt
2 Tbsp chopped cilantro, for garnish

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

As in the Caldine (page 301) and the Black Pepper Chicken (page 260), coconut provides the luxurious texture of fat as the foundation of this dish.

Toasting shredded coconut amplifies the aroma and creates a deeper and richer flavor in this curry. I prefer either frozen or fresh coconut, but you can also use desiccated; just make sure your blender pulverizes the shreds completely.

Vinegar is added at the end to reduce the risk of the coconut milk emulsion falling apart.

Heat a large saucepan over medium-low heat. Add the coconut and toast, stirring occasionally, until it turns golden brown, 5 to 6 minutes. Add the cloves, peppercorns, coriander, and cumin and cook until the spices get fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Remove from the heat and transfer the contents of the saucepan to a blender. Add the garlic, ginger, and chilli. Boil 1 cup [240 ml] of water in a kettle and pour it over the coconut spice mixture in the blender. Pulse until it forms a smooth paste.

In the same saucepan, heat the coconut oil over medium-high heat. Sauté the onion slices until they turn golden brown, 8 to 15 minutes. Add the turmeric and cook for 30 seconds. Transfer the coconut spice paste from the blender to the saucepan, add the chilli powder, and cook for 2 minutes. Add the chicken pieces and brown for 4 to 5 minutes. Stir in 1 cup [240 ml] of water, bring to a boil, and lower the heat to low. Simmer until the chicken is completely cooked, 30 to 45 minutes. Stir in the vinegar. Taste and season with salt and cook for 1 more minute. Remove from the heat, garnish with the chopped cilantro, and serve hot or warm.



Chickpea, Spinach + Potato “Samosa Pie”

Samosas are individual hand pie–size creations that encase tasty fillings in an equally tasty crust. The choices for fillings are endless, including the popular spiced potatoes, spiced chickpeas, paneer, and ground lamb. I make this larger version that I’ve nicknamed the “samosa pie” whenever I want the flavor and texture of a samosa for dinner but I’m low on time. I’ve replaced the samosa pastry with store-bought phyllo sheets; they give the crust a delicate, paper-thin texture that crumbles with a crunch in every bite.

SERVES 4

- For the filling:**

 - Fine sea salt
 - 2 medium russet potatoes (total weight 15½ oz [440 g]), peeled and diced
 - 2 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil
 - 1 medium white or yellow onion (9¼ oz [260 g]), diced
 - 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, cut into matchsticks
 - 1 tsp garam masala, homemade (page 312) or store-bought
 - 1 tsp ground black pepper
 - ½ tsp ground turmeric
 - ½ tsp red chilli powder
 - 5 oz [140 g] fresh baby spinach leaves, chopped
 - Two 15½ oz [445 g] cans chickpeas, rinsed and drained
 - 1 tsp amchur
 - 2 Tbsp chopped cilantro
 - 1 fresh chilli, minced
- For the phyllo crust:**

 - ¼ cup [55 g] unsalted butter, melted
 - ¼ cup [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil
 - 10 sheets phyllo, thawed
 - 1 tsp cumin seeds
 - 1 tsp nigella seeds

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

A mixture of butter and olive oil moisturizes the phyllo sheets and helps turn them crisp as they cook in the oven.

Black pepper and chilli with ginger and the spices in the garam masala add heat and flavor as well as aroma.

Nigella and cumin seeds add flavor and crunchiness to the pastry.

Set a rack on the lower one-third level of the oven and preheat to 350°F [177°C].

Set a large pot of salted water to boil over medium-high heat. Add the diced potatoes and cook until they are just tender but retain their structure, 4 to 5 minutes. Drain the potatoes.

Heat the olive oil in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat. Add the onions and sauté until they turn pale and translucent, 4 to 5 minutes. Lower the heat to

medium-low and add the ginger, garam masala, black pepper, turmeric, and chilli powder. Sauté until the spices are fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Add the potatoes and cook for 2 minutes, until they are completely tender in the center. Add the spinach and cook until the leaves have wilted and released most of their liquid, 2 to 3 minutes. Fold in the chickpeas and amchur, season with salt, and cook for about 1 minute. Remove from the heat. Add the cilantro and chilli. Taste and season with salt if needed.



To prepare the phyllo crust, combine the butter and olive oil in a small bowl. Brush a 9 by 12 by 2 in [23 by 30.5 by 5 cm] rectangular baking pan with the butter–olive oil mixture. Line the base of the pan with 5 sheets of phyllo, brushing each sheet with a little bit of the butter–olive oil mixture. Make sure any overhanging phyllo sheets are also brushed with the mixture. Add the

chickpea mixture and level it with a large spoon or spatula.

Add the remaining phyllo sheets on top, brushing each with the butter–olive oil mixture. As you place each one, pleat slightly to create a ruffled surface. Sprinkle the cumin and nigella seeds on top. Fold in any overhanging phyllo and neatly tuck

them in around the sides. Bake the pie in the preheated oven until the crust is golden brown on top and on the sides, 30 to 45 minutes, rotating halfway through baking. Let cool in the pan for 5 minutes before serving.

The pie is best eaten the day it is prepared.

Coconut Milk Cake

This coconut cake was born out of two very different cakes. As coconuts are a staple in Goan kitchens, we make a coconut cake with semolina, called *baath*, that’s highly fragrant. The second cake that gave inspiration for this dessert was the Mexican tres leches, a marvelous cake made soft and rich by the addition of milk, which I find extremely soothing at all times of the year. Let the cake soak in the infused coconut milk, and serve some extra milk on the side in a pitcher for your guests.

MAKES ONE 9 IN [23 CM] SQUARE CAKE

- For the cake:**
- 1 cup [115 g] packed unsweetened shredded fresh or desiccated coconut
 - ½ cup [110 g] unsalted butter, cubed, at room temperature, plus a little extra for greasing
 - 2 cups [320 g] fine-grade semolina flour
 - ½ tsp baking powder
 - ¼ tsp fine sea salt
 - One 13½ fl oz [400 ml] can full-fat unsweetened coconut milk
 - One 5.4 fl oz [160 ml] can unsweetened coconut cream
 - 2 cups [280 g] sugar
 - 4 large eggs, at room temperature
 - 1½ tsp rose water
- For the coconut-cardamom milk:**
- Two 13½ fl oz [400 ml] cans full-fat unsweetened coconut milk
 - ½ cup [50 g] sugar
 - ½ tsp ground green cardamom

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

Coconut comes into play at several stages in this cake. Toasting shredded coconut intensifies the nutty, tropical aroma.

Adding coconut milk and coconut cream adds the next layer of flavor and also provides the fat that, along with the butter and eggs, gives this cake its structure.

Rose water and cardamom help intensify the perception of sweetness in the cake.

- Preheat the oven to 300°F [149°C].
- Line a baking sheet with parchment paper and spread the coconut out in an even layer. Toast the coconut in the oven until it starts to turn a light golden brown, 5 to 8 minutes. Remove from the oven and let cool completely before using. Increase the oven temperature to 350°F [180°C]. Grease a 9 by 9 by 2 in [23 by 23 by 5 cm] square baking pan with a little butter.
- In a large bowl, whisk together the semolina, baking powder, and salt. In a small bowl, whisk together the coconut milk and coconut cream.
- In the bowl of a stand mixer fitted with a paddle attachment, cream the butter with the sugar on medium-high speed until light and fluffy, 4 to 5 minutes. Stop and scrape the
- sides and bottom of the bowl. Add the eggs, one at a time, beating after each addition. Lower the mixer speed to medium-low and add half the dry ingredients, beating until combined, 1 to 1½ minutes. Beat in the coconut milk–cream mixture and rose water and then the remaining dry ingredients, and beat until well combined. Transfer the batter to the prepared pan.
- Bake for 60 to 75 minutes, rotating the pan halfway through baking, until the surface is golden brown, the center is firm yet spongy, and a skewer inserted into the center comes out clean.
- Meanwhile, to prepare the coconut-cardamom-milk, mix the coconut milk with the sugar and cardamom and stir until the sugar is dissolved. Store, refrigerated, until ready to use.



- Set the pan on a wire rack to cool for 10 minutes. Run a knife around the edges of the pan to loosen the cake. Using a skewer, poke several holes in
- the cake. Pour 2 cups [480 ml] of the milk over the cake. Wrap with plastic wrap and refrigerate until chilled, at least 4 hours and up to 2 days.
- Warm the cake and leftover coconut-cardamom-milk before serving.

PANTRY ESSENTIALS



Plain Rice

For the most part, I cook with basmati rice at home. Basmati rice is renowned not only for its spectacular long grains but also for its aroma. Being a creature of habit, I purchase my basmati rice from my Indian food market. When purchasing basmati, always ask for rice that’s from India and has been aged for at least 1 year; the aroma will be richer.

When I cook basmati for plain rice, pulaos, or biryani, I follow these three rules:

- 1. Once water is added to the rice on the stove, avoid stirring or mixing it.
- 2. For plain rice, I do not add any salt or oil because they reduce the natural fragrance of basmati rice.
- 3. To add a bit of color, add a pinch of ground saffron, a few drops of beet juice, or turmeric powder.

SERVES 2 (ABOUT 1¼ LB [570 G] COOKED RICE)

- 1 cup [200 g] basmati rice
- 4 cups [960 ml] water

Pick through the rice and remove any stones or debris. Place the rice in a fine-mesh sieve and rinse under cool running water until the water is no longer cloudy. Transfer the rice to a medium bowl, cover with 2 cups [480 ml] of the water or enough water to cover the grains by at least 1 in [2.5 cm], and soak for 30 minutes. Drain the water. Place the rice in a medium saucepan or a small Dutch oven with a lid and add the remaining 2 cups [480 ml] of water or enough water to cover the grains by at least 1 in [2.5 cm]. Bring to a rolling boil over medium-high heat. Turn the heat to low, cover, and cook until most of the water has evaporated, 10 to 12 minutes. Remove from heat and let sit, covered, for another 5 minutes. Just before serving, fluff the rice with a fork.

Rice Crumbs

While breadcrumbs and semolina have long been staples in my kitchen for adding a crunchy coating when I bake or deep-fry food and as a binding agent in meatballs and meatloaf, recently I’ve been trying to re-create those same textures with rice. These rice crumbs are a fantastic way to achieve this, and a great way to use up leftover cooked



rice. You’ll probably want to double this recipe and make some extra.

MAKES APPROXIMATELY 3½ OZ [90 G]

2 cups (12 oz [340 g]) leftover plain boiled basmati rice

Preheat the oven to 250°F [120°C].

Line a baking sheet with parchment paper. Spread the rice out in a single layer on the prepared baking sheet, breaking any clumps of rice with your hand. Place the rice in the oven until the grains dry out completely, at least 45 to 60 minutes. The rice crumbs should not turn golden brown; if you notice that happening, this means your oven is too hot and you need to lower the temperature. Your drying time will vary depending on your oven; it can take an additional 30 minutes or more than the suggested time.

Remove the baking sheet from the oven and let the rice cool completely to room temperature. Grind the cooled toasted rice grains in a spice grinder or coffee mill to a tiny but coarse consistency. The degree of grinding will depend on your preference. Transfer the rice crumbs to an airtight container and store in a cool, dark place for up to 1 month.

SPICE BLENDS

Spice blends and masalas (the Hindi word for any spice blend) are a fantastic resource to keep on hand in your kitchen. To make them last longer and get their maximum flavor, make them in small batches and store them in dark containers in a cool spot away from sunlight.

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- ✦ Toasting spices provides heat, helping drive out the moisture that accumulates in the dried spices during storage.
- ✦ Heat also helps draw out the flavor molecules in the seeds, and some of these molecules undergo changes in their chemical structure, which changes their flavor and makes them tastier.
- ✦ Grinding whole spices breaks them down into tiny particles, which increases their surface area. Extraction of the flavor molecules is more efficient when the particles are smaller. When added to a dish in a ground powder form, their flavor and pigments are released at a higher rate than if they were kept whole.



Garam Masala

I’m including two different versions of garam masala that I cook with at home. You can use either version in the recipes here. Let the spices cool before you grind them or they will release moisture, which can cause a bit of clumping when the spices are ground.

My Shahi Garam Masala

A bit different from the classic garam masala, this *shahi* (“royal” in Urdu) version is highly aromatic and is used on special occasions to flavor rice, lentils, meats, and vegetables. But you don’t need to wait for a special celebration to use it; I certainly don’t!

You can prepare an intensely floral and aromatic version of shahi garam masala by adding 1 Tbsp of edible dried rose petals to the toasted spice mix when grinding the mixture. I find this version goes well with meat dishes.

MAKES JUST UNDER ½ CUP [40 G]

- 2 Tbsp cumin seeds
- 2 Tbsp coriander seeds
- 2 Tbsp fennel seeds
- 1 Tbsp whole black peppercorns
- 2 dried bay leaves
- One 2 in [5 cm] cinnamon stick
- 12 whole cloves
- 8 whole green cardamom pods
- 1 whole black cardamom pod
- 1 whole star anise
- 1 tsp freshly grated nutmeg

Heat a small, dry stainless-steel or cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. Turn the heat to medium-low and add the cumin seeds, coriander seeds, fennel seeds, black peppercorns, bay leaves, cinnamon, cloves, green and black cardamom pods, and star anise. Toast gently by rotating the pan to circulate the spices until the spices become fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Be careful not to burn them; if they do burn, discard them and start fresh.

Transfer the toasted spices to a small plate and let cool completely. Transfer the cooled spices to a mortar or spice

cont’d

grinder. Add the nutmeg and grind to a fine powder. Store the spice mix in an airtight container in a cool, dark place for up to 6 months.

My Garam Masala

This is my regular garam masala; note the absence of a few aromatic spices such as fennel and a smaller amount of green cardamom in this version.

MAKES ABOUT ¼ CUP [25 G]

- 2 Tbsp cumin seeds
- 2 Tbsp coriander seeds
- 1 Tbsp black peppercorns
- 2 dried bay leaves
- One 2 in [5 cm] cinnamon stick
- 12 whole cloves
- 1 whole black cardamom pod
- 3 or 4 green cardamom pods
- 1 tsp freshly grated nutmeg

Follow the method for the Shahi Garam Masala (page 311).



My “Gunpowder” Nut Masala

The classic fiery gunpowder masala of Southern India is made with a mixture of lentils and served as a seasoning alongside a variety of foods. This nut-based version of gunpowder masala arose out of necessity, because I don’t regularly stock my pantry with the specific lentils used, but this turns out to be a great way to use up extra bits of nuts and seeds stored in the back of your freezer.

To use, generously sprinkle the masala over savory dishes like dals, vegetables, and salads.

MAKES 2 CUPS [210 G]

- 3½ oz [100 g] raw cashews
- ½ cup [35 g] raw pepitas (pumpkin seeds)
- 1 oz [30 g] dried red chillies
- 20 to 25 fresh curry leaves
- 2 Tbsp white or black sesame seeds
- ½ tsp asafetida

Heat a small, dry skillet over medium heat. When the pan is hot, add the cashews, pumpkin seeds, chillies, curry leaves, and sesame seeds and toast for 4 to 5 minutes until the seeds start to turn brown and the leaves begin to slightly curl. Transfer to a medium bowl and let cool to room temperature. Once cooled, grind the mixture with the asafetida to a coarse or fine powder, depending on your preference, in a food processor or a blender. Transfer to an airtight container and store for up to 2 weeks in the refrigerator.

Salt-Cured Egg Yolks

Salt-cured egg yolks are used for their savory appeal; when shaved, they taste like finely grated Parmesan. Use them over pasta or as a garnish in dishes to give an extra bit of saltiness and umami. They must be prepared a few days ahead of when you want to use them.



MAKES 2 CURED YOLKS

- 1½ cups [450 g] fine sea salt
- ½ cup [50 g] sugar
- 2 large eggs
- Oil spray, such as canola

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- + Salt and sugar draw out the water from the yolk through osmosis. The reduced availability of water helps preserve the yolk.
- + The glutamic acid in the yolk concentrates it and gives a richer umami taste.
- + The kala namak variation provides a stronger sulfurous aroma in addition to the rich umami notes.

In a small flat container or dish, spread out half of the salt. Make two small depressions in the center.

Working with one egg at a time, carefully separate the yolk from the white and place the yolk in a depression in the salt. Reserve the whites for another purpose. Cover



the yolks with the remaining sea salt. Cover the container loosely with a lid and leave in the refrigerator for 1 week.

After a week, position a rack in the middle of the oven and preheat the oven to 200°F [93°C]. Remove the lid and carefully remove the yolks. The yolks will be firm but slightly sticky to the touch; be careful when handling them. Using a pastry brush, lightly dust off the excess salt. Quickly rinse the yolks under running tap water and dab dry with a clean paper towel. Set a wire rack on a baking sheet and spray the rack with the oil. Set the cured yolks on the rack and place it in the oven to dry completely, at least 45 minutes to 1 hour. Once the yolks are dried, remove them from the oven and allow to cool completely before storing in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 2 weeks or in the freezer for up to 1 month.

To use, shave the yolk with a zester or grater and use it as a topping or garnish for salads, soups, and so on, as you would a hard cheese.

VARIATION: *For a stronger sulfurous flavor, use kala namak mixed in with the salt and sugar.*

1 cup [300 g] fine sea salt + ¼ cup [50 g] kala namak + ½ cup [100 g] sugar



DIPS + SPREADS

Dips and spreads are a great resource for entertaining. Serve either of these dips with toasted bread or a bright, colorful platter of crisp vegetables as a crudité.

Burnt Shallot Dip

MAKES APPROXIMATELY 1½ CUPS [350 G]

2 shallots (total weight 4¼ oz [120 g])

1 Tbsp grapeseed oil or other neutral oil

1 cup [240 g] plain unsweetened Greek yogurt

1 Tbsp fresh lemon juice

1 tsp fresh lemon zest

½ tsp coarsely ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

1 Tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

1 tsp nigella seeds

1 Tbsp chopped chives, for garnish

Trim and discard the ends of the shallots and peel them. Cut them in half lengthwise and brush them generously with the grapeseed oil.

Heat a small skillet over high heat. When the pan is hot, char the shallots on each side for 3 to 4 minutes; the surface should be slightly burnt. Remove from the heat and transfer the shallots to a bowl to cool. When the shallots are cool enough to handle, mince them and add to a mixing bowl along with the yogurt, lemon juice and zest, and pepper. Season with salt. Fold to combine. Taste and adjust the seasoning.

In the same skillet, heat the olive oil over medium-high heat. When the oil is hot, add the nigella seeds and cook until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Pour the hot oil with the nigella over the dip in the bowl. Garnish with the chives and serve.

Sundried Tomatoes + Red Bell Pepper Spread

Bright red, with sweet, rich flavors, this spread can be used as a dip with a platter of crudité or in sandwiches (it’s especially great in grilled cheese sandwiches and even as a dip on the side). For an extra kick of garlic, use 3 garlic cloves.

MAKES APPROXIMATELY 2½ CUPS [590 G]

1 medium red bell pepper (7 oz [200 g])

8½ oz [240 g] sun-dried tomatoes, packed in olive oil

6 scallions

2 garlic cloves, peeled

2 Tbsp fresh lemon juice

1 tsp coriander seeds

1 tsp nigella seeds

1 tsp red chilli flakes

1 tsp fine sea salt

Trim the stalks off the bell pepper and discard the seeds. Cut the bell pepper into chunks and place them in a blender. Add the tomatoes and ¼ cup [60 ml] of their oil; reserve the remaining oil for another purpose. Add the scallions, garlic, lemon juice, coriander and nigella seeds, red chilli flakes, and salt and pulse on high speed until it forms a smooth paste. You might need to add 1 to 2 Tbsp

of water to get the ingredients to move in the blender. Taste and adjust the seasoning.

DIPPING OILS

One of my earliest experiences with Italian food involved the simplest yet the most splendid appetizer—warm focaccia served with dipping oil and balsamic vinegar on a large plate. The formula for this is very straightforward:

[Spices + Herbs + Good Oil] + Good Vinegar + Flaky Salt + Warm Bread = Happiness

Here are some playful takes on this concept. Serve the oil with 1 to 2 Tbsp of a good fruity or sweet vinegar, like balsamic, fig, plum, or sherry vinegar.

FLAVOR MAP FOR DIPPING OILS

Basic Recipe (feel free to tweak the amounts here):

½ cup [120 ml] oil + ½ tsp spices and/or chillies + 1 tsp fresh herbs or ½ tsp dried herbs + 2 to 3 Tbsp acid (vinegar) + salt and pepper

EMULSIONS

Here are two types of emulsions that use different emulsifiers to stabilize the emulsion created by the oil and water. Tourné uses the pectin in garlic, while mayonnaise relies on the lecithin in egg yolks and mustard to hold that luscious texture together.

Tourné

You don’t need to restrict yourself to using tourné as a dipping sauce. Because it lasts for a long time, you can use it as a quick garlic flavor booster in various ways: Fold a spoonful or two into soft goat cheese to serve with crostini, the Oven “Fries” (page 144), or the Lamb Chops with Scallion Mint Salsa (page 163); or combine it with the Goat Cheese Dip (page 144) and use it as a condiment on sandwiches or as a dip.

MAKES ABOUT 1 QT [960 ML]

1 large head garlic (4¼ oz [120 g])

¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lemon juice

½ cup [120 ml] ice-cold water



3 cups [720 ml] grapeseed oil or debittered extra-virgin olive oil (see case study, page 104)

Fine sea salt

Peel the garlic cloves and trim the bottom ends. Remove and discard any green parts.

Place the garlic with the lemon juice and water in the bowl of a food processor and pulse until combined. Continue to pulse as you slowly drizzle in the grapeseed oil, one drop at a time, until the mixture is completely emulsified and smooth. Taste and season with salt.

Store the tourné in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 1 month.



Curry Leaf + Mustard Oil Mayonnaise

The wasabi-like heat of golden-yellow mustard oil matched with the perfume of curry leaves gives this mayonnaise its bold flavorful character. Use it as you would regular mayonnaise, over your fries, and on your summer tomato sandwiches as I do, with a few crispy fried curry leaves.

MAKES JUST OVER 1 CUP [150 G]

½ cup [120 ml] debittered mustard oil or debittered extra-virgin olive oil (see case study, page 104)

12 to 15 fresh curry leaves

1 large egg yolk, at room temperature

2 Tbsp fresh lime juice or rice vinegar

1 Tbsp prepared yellow mustard

2 tsp honey

½ tsp red chilli powder

½ tsp freshly ground black pepper

Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- + Here the fiery-tasting substances in mustard oil come into play when making an emulsion.
- + The yellow mustard is optional; it acts as a second emulsifier along with the lecithin (in the egg yolk) and honey.

Heat the oil in a small, dry stainless-steel saucepan over medium-high heat. While the oil is heating, rinse the curry leaves under cold tap water and dab them dry with a clean kitchen towel. When the oil is hot, add the curry leaves, cover the saucepan with a lid, and remove from the heat. Once the oil has cooled to room temperature, transfer it to small container. Transfer the fried leaves to a small plate lined with a paper towel to get rid of any excess oil, and reserve to use as a garnish.

Place the egg yolk, lime juice, yellow mustard, honey, chilli powder, and black pepper in a medium mixing bowl. Whisk the mixture until smooth and combined. Slowly drizzle the cooled infused mustard oil into the center of the egg yolk mixture and whisk. The mixture will start to thicken. Once the oil is incorporated, taste and season with salt. Store the mayonnaise in an airtight container in the refrigerator for 3 to 4 days.

VARIATION: *For an extra kick of heat, use cayenne instead of red chilli powder. To give the mayonnaise a deeper yellow color, mix in ¼ tsp of ground turmeric with the egg yolk.*

My Quick Marinara

When I don't have a marinara sauce on hand for pizza, this is my go-to. It's a bit unconventional but works beautifully. Use a good-quality tomato paste; I like to buy it in tubes.

Depending on your preference, you can use the olive oil that the anchovies were packed in or just regular extra-virgin olive oil.

MAKES 1 CUP [ABOUT 200 G]

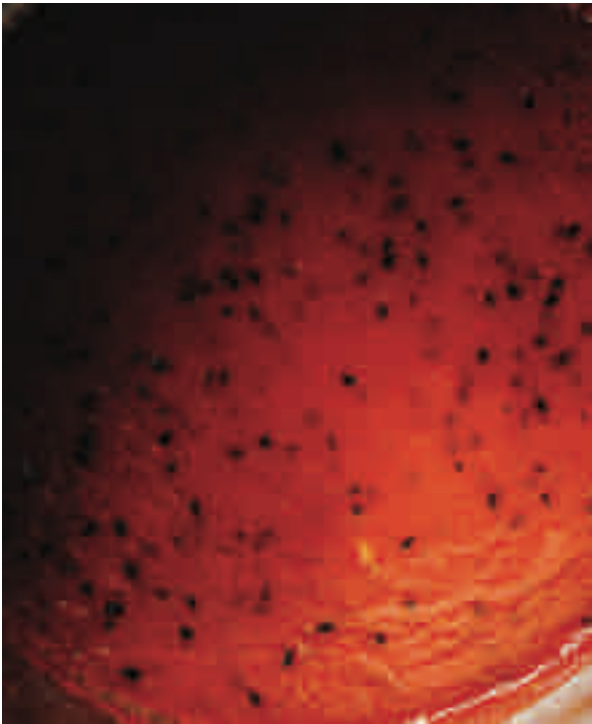
2 Tbsp unsalted butter or extra-virgin olive oil

1 tsp nigella seeds

1 garlic clove, peeled and finely grated

½ tsp dried oregano

½ tsp ground black pepper



4½ oz [130 g] tomato paste

2 anchovies, packed in olive oil, drained

Sea salt

Sugar

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- + Anchovies and tomatoes add umami character. The anchovies fall apart and melt away as they cook.
- + Nigella seeds are often erroneously referred to as onion seeds or black cumin, even though they are completely unrelated. Nigella produce an onion-like aroma when cooked; this becomes evident here when they're added to the hot oil.

Heat the olive oil in a small saucepan over medium-low heat. When the oil is hot, add the nigella seeds and garlic and cook for 15 seconds, until fragrant, taking care to prevent the garlic from burning. Add the oregano and cook for an additional 10 seconds. Stir in the black pepper, tomato paste, anchovies, and ½ cup [120 ml] of water and whisk to combine. Increase the heat to medium-high and bring to a boil, then turn the heat to low and simmer for

5 minutes. Taste and season with salt and sugar. Store in an airtight container in the refrigerator and use within 1 week.

INDO-CHINESE CONDIMENTS

Heat plays a significant role in many Indo-Chinese dishes. Whenever we ate at the Chinese restaurants in India, these two sauces were always provided on the side. And if we ordered takeout, you can bet I asked for a couple extra servings of these.

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- + Vinegar in both sauces provides sourness.
- + In the Indo-Sichuan Sauce (page 318), the vinegar also acts as preservative along with the chillies and garlic.

Chilli-Soy Vinegar Sauce

This sauce is usually prepared without the addition of soy sauce; however, I find mixing the two together with the chillies gives a more robust flavor. A quick and easy sauce to prepare, it's got acidity, umami, and heat all rolled into one. Sprinkle a few drops of the liquid into your Manchow Soup (page 255) or over your noodles to kick things up.

MAKES ½ CUP [120 ML]

¼ cup [60 ml] rice vinegar

¼ cup [60 ml] soy sauce

1 green chilli, such as serrano or bird's eye, thinly sliced

Fine sea salt

Place the vinegar, soy sauce, and chilli in a small serving bowl. Season with salt and let sit for 1 hour before serving. Store in a covered container in the refrigerator for up to 2 days.

Indo–Sichuan Sauce

The name of this sauce is a bit misleading; it does not use Sichuan peppercorns but instead refers to the Hakka.

While this sauce is served with Chinese food in India, I use it as a dipping sauce for everything; it even goes on top of my fried eggs. The oil extracts the bright red pigment of the red chillies, and you end up with a brilliant shade of rouge. While Kashmiri chillies are mild in their level of heat, you can further reduce the level of fieriness in the dish by simply removing and discarding the seeds from half the chillies, then proceeding with the recipe.

MAKES 1¼ LB [570 G], 3 TO 3½ CUPS

1½ oz [40 g] dried whole Kashmiri chillies,
stalks removed and discarded

1 cup [240 ml] boiling water

½ cup [120 ml] grapeseed oil or other neutral oil

2 Tbsp minced shallot or red onion

¾ oz [90 g] garlic, peeled and minced

2¼ oz [65 g] fresh ginger, peeled and minced

¼ cup [55 g] tomato paste

½ cup [120 ml] cider vinegar

2 Tbsp soy sauce

½ tsp sugar

Fine sea salt

Place the chillies in a medium bowl or cup and cover with the boiling water. Push down the chillies to submerge them and let stand for 30 minutes to soften and rehydrate.

Remove the chillies and transfer them to a blender with half of the soaking water. Reserve the remaining water. Pulse for a few short seconds until a coarse paste forms.

Heat the oil in a medium saucepan over medium heat. When the oil is hot, add the chilli paste and cook, stirring constantly, for 1 minute. Add the shallot and cook for 1 minute. Add the garlic, ginger, and tomato paste and cook for 2 minutes. Lower the heat to a simmer and add the vinegar, soy sauce, sugar, and the reserved water. Cover the saucepan with a lid and cook, stirring occasionally, until the ginger is completely tender and cooked, almost all the water has cooked off, and the oil separates, 25 to 30 minutes.



Taste and season with salt. Transfer the sauce to an airtight container and refrigerate for up to 1 month.

PRESERVED LEMONS, TWO WAYS (CLASSIC + QUICK)

You can certainly purchase preserved lemons in most stores now, but for those of you who want to give it a try, here are two methods. Meyer lemons remain my top choice for this preserve because of their thin skins, but any type of lemon will work in this recipe. Before serving, rinse the preserved lemons under running tap water, then scrape and discard the flesh. Dice the peel and use as needed. You can blend it into mayonnaise, fold it into sauces, or add it to salad dressings.

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- ✦ Salt works by masking the bitterness in the lemon.
- ✦ Using a combination of salt and acid (citric acid) helps soften cell structure and preserve lemons.

Classic Method

I first learned to make preserved lemons via the legendary writer Claudia Roden, from her book *Arabesque: A Taste of Morocco, Turkey, and Lebanon*. Here, the combined actions of the salt and the acid (citric acid) of the lemon soften the fruit. The salt also plays a second role: It helps alleviate the perception of bitterness from the white pith. If a white mold develops on the exposed skin of the peel, simply rinse it off. Classically, the lemons are not cut all the way but in a crisscross pattern that holds the entire lemon together. I've tried this in a few different ways and haven't noticed any difference in taste.

MAKES 1½ CUPS, OR APPROXIMATELY 15¾ OZ [450 G]

4 lemons (total weight about 10 oz [280 g])

¼ cup [50 g] fine sea salt

½ cup [120 ml] fresh lemon juice from 4 additional lemons

Wash and scrub the lemons under warm tap water. Cut the lemons in quarters and remove and discard the seeds. Rub the lemons with the salt and transfer them to a sterilized preserving jar. Press the lemons down with a ladle



to crush them and cover the lemons with the remaining juice. Seal the jar and keep in a dark cool spot for at least 1 month before using. Store indefinitely, refrigerated.

Quick Method

The quick method is a shortcut that I use when I've run out of my jars of preserved lemons. First, heat is applied by dropping the lemons into a bath of boiling water to soften them. They are then chopped up to increase the surface area so the salt and acid can rapidly penetrate the lemons' flesh.

MAKES 1½ CUPS, OR APPROXIMATELY 15¾ OZ [450 G]

4 lemons (total weight about 10 oz [280 g])

¼ cup [50 g] fine sea salt

½ cup [120 ml] fresh lemon juice from 4 additional lemons

Wash and scrub the lemons under warm tap water. Cut the lemons in quarters, then cut each in half. Remove and discard the seeds. Rub the lemons with half the salt and place them in a small bowl for 2 hours. Rinse the lemons under cold running tap water and discard the liquid left behind in the bowl. Place the lemons in a small saucepan with the remaining salt, the lemon juice, and ½ cup [120 ml] of water. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat, then lower the heat to a simmer and cook until the liquid volume is reduced by half and it is thick and syrupy, 25 to 30 minutes. Remove from the heat, transfer to a sterilized, nonreactive (glass or plastic), airtight container, and refrigerate overnight. The preserves will be ready to use the next day.

Quick Pickled Nectarines with Mint + Serrano

This is a fresh pickle made with sweet, ripe nectarines; you can use peaches in a pinch.

Because capsaicin is soluble in fat and alcohol and only weakly soluble in water, most of the heat stays concentrated in the chilli to give a pop of heat when you bite into the chilli slices. I find this pickle delicious with soft cheeses such as fresh creamy burrata or with salads or grilled meats and seafood.



SERVES 4

- 1 tsp coriander seeds
- 2 ripe but firm yellow nectarines (total weight 15½ oz [440 g])
- ¼ cup [5 g] fresh mint leaves
- 1 green chilli such as serrano, thinly sliced
- ¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lime juice
- 2 to 3 Tbsp date syrup, homemade (page 324) or store-bought
- ½ tsp coarsely ground black pepper
- Fine sea salt

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- + Capsaicin does not dissolve well in water; as a result, you'll notice different grades of heat in this dish; it's more concentrated when you bite into the chilli rather than in the pickle's liquid.
- + As time progresses and the acids break the cells down, the capsaicin will start to spread and the heat will become more uniform.

Heat a small, dry skillet over medium-high heat. Once the pan is hot, toast the coriander seeds until they just start to release their aroma, about 30 seconds. Transfer the seeds to a mortar and pestle and crush into a coarse powder, then transfer to a small mixing bowl.

Cut the nectarines into halves and remove and discard the stones. Cut the nectarine halves into thin slices and place them in a large bowl with a lid. Tear the mint leaves and add them with the chilli to the nectarines in the bowl.

Add the lime juice, date syrup, and black pepper to the crushed coriander seeds and mix with a spoon until evenly combined. Pour this liquid over the nectarines in the bowl. Season with salt. Fold carefully, cover the bowl with the lid, and let sit at room temperature for 30 minutes. Serve at room temperature or chilled. This pickle will keep for up to 1 day.

Cauliflower Achar (Pickle)

There are two types of people in my life—those who love this cauliflower pickle slightly sweet and those who prefer it spicy—so I leave the decision whether to add jaggery (or sugar) entirely to you.

Mustard oil is the classic choice for this achar or Indian-style pickle, and it imparts its special note of pungency, but you can replace it with extra-virgin olive oil, sesame oil, or a neutral oil such as grapeseed. To make the pickle more visually exciting, I sometimes use equal parts black and yellow mustard seeds. In this recipe, asafetida acts as an allium flavor substitute. The pickle does not need to be canned.

Serve a little bit of this achar on the side with meals, and add a generous spoonful to your sandwiches (make a sandwich with the Lamb Koftas, page 264) for an extra bump of texture and flavor. Use up the leftover oil and vinegar mixture as a dip served with bread.

MAKES ABOUT 2 LB [910 G]

- 2 lb [910 g] cauliflower, broken into bite-size florets—after trimming you should have 1.7 lb [760 g]
- 1 cup [240 ml] mustard oil, extra-virgin olive oil, sesame oil, or grapeseed oil
- ¼ cup [36 g] black or yellow mustard seeds (or both)
- 2 Tbsp cumin seeds
- 1 Tbsp red chilli powder

- 2 tsp ground turmeric
- 1 tsp asafetida
- 2 Tbsp fine sea salt
- 2 Tbsp jaggery or dark brown sugar (optional)
- ¾ cup [180 ml] cider or malt vinegar

Clean, wash, and sterilize a 3 qt [2.8 L] canning jar. Keep the jar dry.

Rinse the cauliflower florets and arrange them on a clean kitchen towel to drain off any excess water. A salad spinner will also do a fantastic job of removing any excess water.

Warm the oil in a large saucepan over medium heat. Lightly crush the mustard and cumin seeds with a mortar and pestle and add them to the hot oil. Cook for 30 seconds, until the spices just start to get fragrant. Remove from the heat and add the red chilli powder, turmeric, and asafetida. Fold in the cauliflower to coat well. Transfer the cauliflower with the oil-spice mixture to the prepared jar.

In a medium bowl, dissolve the salt and jaggery in the vinegar. Pour this mixture over the cauliflower in the jar, seal with a lid, and shake to coat well. Leave the jar at room temperature overnight, after which the achar will be



ready to eat. This achar can be stored in the refrigerator for up to 1 month.

CHUTNEYS

I could happily devote an entire chapter to the luscious, gorgeous nature of savory and sweet chutneys. Chutneys are condiments that provide a complex assortment of flavors, and a little bit goes along way. Serve them alongside snacks or as a condiment with a large meal.

Green Apple Chutney

This recipe is based on one that I found in my late maternal grandmother's recipe notebook for apple chutney. Every year, she'd make a few jars and I'd eat it on a plate filled with rice, her cabbage foogath (page 291), and Cal-dine (page 301). This chutney pairs well with grilled pork chops. Cooking the apples in a large, wide skillet increases the available surface area for evaporation. Adjust the amount of red chilli flakes based on your preference.

cont'd



MAKES 1 QT [985 G]

- 2 lb [910 g] Granny Smith or other firm, tart green apples, peeled and cored
- ½ cup [70 g] packed raisins or sweetened cranberries
- 2 in [5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and cut into 1 in [2.5 cm] matchsticks
- 2 tsp to 1 Tbsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo
- 1 cup [200 g] packed brown sugar
- 1 cup [240 ml] cider or malt vinegar
- 1 tsp fine sea salt

Prepare four clean, sterile 8 oz [250 ml] canning jars.

Shred the apples using the coarse blades of a grater or a food processor.

Combine the shredded apples, raisins, ginger, and chilli flakes with ¼ cup [60 ml] of water in a deep nonreactive stainless-steel skillet and heat over medium-high heat. Bring to a boil, then lower the heat to a simmer and cover with a lid. Cook until the apples get soft, stirring occasionally with a silicone spatula, 10 to 12 minutes. Stir in the sugar, vinegar, and salt and continue to cook, uncovered, stirring occasionally, until the apple mixture gets thick and most of the liquid evaporates, 30 to 40 minutes. Remove from the heat and pack into a clean, sterile jar. This pickle is good for 1 month.

Tamarind-Date Chutney

This chutney is sweet from the date syrup and gets its acidity from the tamarind. Dried ginger gives it heat, while kala namak adds a special note of saltiness. This chutney is served with fried snacks such as samosas and is a part of the family of street foods called *chaat* in India. Drizzle the chutney over fresh or grilled ripe fruit; serve it with a little sweetened crème fraîche as a dessert.

MAKES 1 CUP [280 G]

- ½ tsp ground cumin
- ½ cup [120 ml] date syrup, homemade (page 324) or store-bought
- 2 Tbsp tamarind paste, homemade (page 67) or store-bought
- 2 Tbsp ground jaggery or dark brown sugar
- 1 tsp amchur

- 1 tsp dried ground ginger
- ½ tsp red chilli flakes, such as Aleppo or Maras
- ½ tsp kala namak, plus more as needed

Toast the cumin in a small saucepan over medium heat until fragrant, 30 to 45 seconds. Whisk in the date syrup, ½ cup [120 ml] of water, the tamarind, jaggery, amchur, ginger, and chilli flakes. Bring to a boil over high heat. Lower the heat to a simmer and cook until the liquid reduces to 1 cup [240 ml], scraping the sides of the saucepan as it cooks, 5 to 8 minutes. Remove from the heat and add the kala namak. Taste and add more kala namak if needed. Serve at room temperature or chilled. Store in an airtight container for up to 2 weeks in the refrigerator.

Mint Chutney

This classic chutney is served with fried Indian snacks such as samosas and pakoras; it reduces some of the heaviness associated with these foods. The cooling effects of the menthol in mint along with the heat of fresh green chillies come through in this chutney. The acids from lime juice and vinegar provide a sour note but also stop the polyphenol oxidases in the leaves from turning the green



chlorophyll pigment dark black. This chutney works great on wraps and especially well with roasted vegetables.

MAKES 1 CUP [240 G]

- 1 bunch [75 g] cilantro
- 1 bunch [55 g] mint
- 2 green chillies such as serrano
- 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled and chopped
- ¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lime juice
- 3 Tbsp rice vinegar
- Fine sea salt

Place the cilantro, mint, chillies, ginger, lime juice, and vinegar in a blender or a food processor. Pulse for a few seconds at intervals until the ingredients are completely pulverized to a paste. You might need to use a spatula to move things around in the blender. Taste and add salt as needed. Transfer to an airtight container and store in the refrigerator for up to 3 to 4 days.

Pumpkin Seed Chutney

This chutney arose out of necessity. Several years ago, I learned to make dosas and idlis, and while I could find other ingredients, it was trickier to find a source for fresh or frozen coconut. Pumpkin seeds and olive oil helped me re-create that texture with a similar flavor profile. As with the Mint Chutney (left), the addition of lime juice provides a sour note and inactivates the polyphenol oxidase, which reduces the chances of the green chlorophyll pigment turning brown. A second level of protection comes from the olive oil; chlorophyll is soluble in oil, which helps reduce access to the oxygen necessary for the oxidase enzyme. Grinding the herbs in the olive oil first helps with this. This chutney is a much brighter green than the Mint Chutney.

MAKES 2 CUPS [380 G]

- 1 cup [130 g] pepitas (pumpkin seeds)
- 1 bunch [75 g] cilantro
- ½ cup [6 g] packed fresh mint
- ¼ cup [60 ml] fresh lime juice
- ¼ cup [60 ml] extra-virgin olive oil

- 12 black peppercorns
- 2 garlic cloves, peeled
- 2 green chillies such as serrano
- 1 in [2.5 cm] piece fresh ginger, peeled
- ½ tsp cumin
- Fine sea salt

Place the pumpkin seeds, cilantro, mint, and lime juice in a blender or food processor. Pulse for a few seconds at intervals until you get a coarse paste. Add the olive oil, peppercorns, garlic, chillies, ginger, and cumin. Pulse for a few seconds at intervals until the ingredients are pulverized to a paste. Taste and season with salt. Store this chutney in an airtight container with a piece of plastic wrap pressed against the surface to block off any air; it will keep for up to 1 week in the refrigerator.

Cardamom Toffee Sauce

This is my all-purpose toffee sauce. I drizzle it over cakes and tart crunchy slices of apples—pretty much anywhere I can squeeze it in, this sauce will make an appearance. Toffee gets its rich flavor notes from the molasses present in brown sugar.

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- + Brown sugar undergoes caramelization as it starts to heat up.
- + Cream of tartar prevents recrystallization of the sugar by “inverting” sucrose, and it splits to produce glucose and fructose, which interferes with crystal formation.
- + Cardamom is added toward the end, once the sauce is warm, to prevent the spice from burning.

MAKES 1½ CUPS [360 ML] SAUCE

- 1 cup [200 g] packed dark brown sugar
- ¼ tsp fine sea salt
- ⅓ tsp cream of tartar
- ½ cup [120 ml] heavy cream
- 2 Tbsp unsalted butter, cubed
- ½ tsp ground green cardamom



Place the sugar, ¼ cup [60 ml] of water, the salt, and cream of tartar in a medium heavy-bottomed saucepan and heat over medium-high heat, stirring continuously. Cook until the sugar dissolves completely and starts to caramelize and develop a deep amber color. Remove from the heat and carefully stir in the heavy cream. Add the butter and stir until the liquid is completely smooth. Transfer the caramel sauce to a heatproof glass jar and let it cool until it is warm to the touch. Stir in the cardamom, cover with a lid, and let cool completely. Refrigerate for up to 1 month.

Homemade Date Syrup

For those who want to try making your own date syrup at home, this recipe is for you.

Homemade date syrup can take some time to prepare, and often dried dates, despite being soft, can be resistant to creating the right texture needed in a syrup. Dates contain about 0.5% to 3.9% pectin by weight, which contributes to this resistance. You can solve this problem by adding a bit of baking soda combined with heating and blending in a high-speed blender. It is fascinating to see how the color and the texture of the date purée evolves during the processing; it will transform from a viscous

toffee-colored substance to a smooth reddish-brown syrup.

Do not concentrate the molasses too much; it will continue to thicken and can even harden as it cools. If it becomes too stiff on cooling, add a few tablespoons boiling water to thin it out, or warm the jar in a pot of simmering water for a few minutes until it loosens.

MAKES JUST UNDER 1 CUP [240 ML]

1 lb [455 g] Medjool dates

½ tsp baking soda

4 cups [960 ml] warm filtered water at 100°F [35°C]

1 tsp lemon juice or rice wine vinegar

Fine sea salt (optional)

THE FLAVOR APPROACH

- + Baking soda helps dissolve the pectin in the dried dates.
- + Heat and the mechanical action of the blades will aid in pulverizing the dates and increasing the surface area of the dates for the baking soda to act on.
- + Dried dates typically contain very low amounts of pH-sensitive anthocyanin pigments (compared to fresh dates). Despite this, the color of dried dates changes along with the pH during various stages of cooking. This is likely due to the activity of residual anthocyanin or other pigments. Baking soda will increase the pH, turning the dates a light toffee brown. As the puréed dates are heated, the baking soda breaks down at 176°F [80°C], producing sodium carbonate, which is more alkaline than baking soda. Heating the date mixture at an alkaline pH promotes caramelization and the Maillard reaction, turning the dates a dark brown color and then dark violet. Add acid (lemon juice or vinegar) and the pH decreases, turning the liquid a dark wine red. Using filtered water is recommended, as it includes less dissolved substances than tap water, which could interfere with the baking soda. Notice how the date syrup gives off a toasty sweet perfume.

Cut the dates to extract the pits from the centers; discard the pits. Chop the dates and transfer them to a medium bowl. Sprinkle the baking soda over the dates and, using a



fork, toss to coat well. Add the warm water and mash the dates with the fork. Let the dates sit covered for 30 minutes; stir them occasionally with the fork.

After 30 minutes, the date pulp will resemble a thick, gloopy, soup-like mass. Using a spatula, transfer the mixture to a blender or the bowl of a food processor fitted with a blade. Pulse for a few seconds until you get a smooth toffee-brown purée. Transfer the date purée to a deep, medium saucepan, cover partially with a lid, and bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Lower the heat to low and cook, stirring occasionally, for 30 minutes, until you get a thick purée and the color switches to a dark reddish brown. Scrape the bottom of the saucepan to avoid burning. Stir in the lemon juice and remove from the heat.

Set a fine-mesh sieve lined with a few layers of cheesecloth over a funnel set over a bottle or medium bowl. Filter the date syrup through it in batches. Squeeze out any liquid and discard the date pulp left behind in the cloth. You should get about 2½ cups [600 ml] of liquid.

Transfer the liquid to a wide medium saucepan and bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Lower the heat to medium and cook until the liquid reduces to about 1 cup



[240 ml]; it should be the consistency of a thick syrup and coat the back of a metal spoon or a plate; when you draw a line through the syrup, you should be able to leave a clean trail on the back of the spoon or the plate. This takes 25 to 30 minutes. If the syrup starts to stiffen on cooling, add a few tablespoons of boiling water to loosen it up. Transfer to a clean, sterile jar, seal with a lid, and store in the refrigerator for up to 3 to 4 weeks.

A FEW POINTS ABOUT PURE WATER THAT YOU MIGHT FIND HELPFUL IN THE KITCHEN

Boiling point	212°F [100°C] at sea level
Freezing point	32°F [0°C] at sea level
Weight	0.034 fl oz [1 ml] weighs 0.04 oz [1 g]
pH of pure water	7.0 at 77°F [25°C]



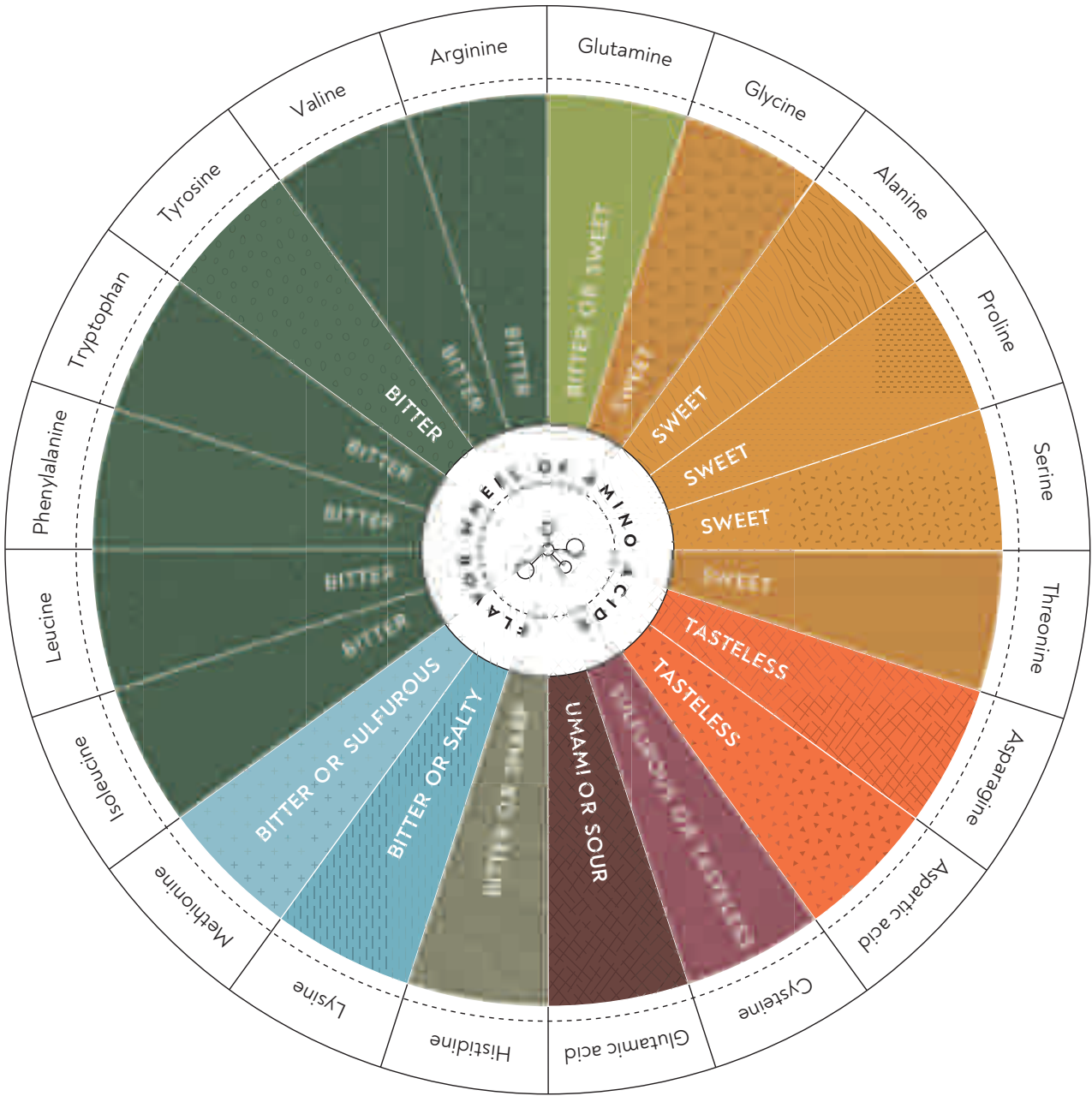
Paneer

Firm Paneer: Add ½ tsp [2 g] calcium chloride to ½ gal [1.9 L] whole milk and heat over medium heat to 185°F [85°C]. Remove from the heat and stir in 2 Tbsp fresh lemon juice. Strain the curdled milk proteins through a fine-mesh sieve lined with cheese cloth. Rinse under running tap water several times. Squeeze the cloth tight to drain excess water, and hang the cloth with the paneer over a bowl at room temperature for 1 hour. Remove and then set a heavy weight like a Dutch oven over the cheesecloth for 1 hour. Remove the drained paneer from the cloth and cut as needed. Paneer can be stored in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 3 days or in the freezer for up to 3 weeks. Makes 10 oz [280 g].

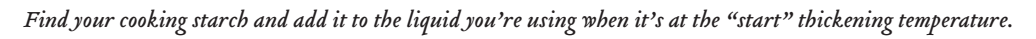
Soft paneer: Mix ½ gal [1.9 L] milk with ½ cup [120 ml] fresh lemon juice instead of calcium chloride and proceed as above. Makes 8¾ oz [250 g].

FLAVOR WHEEL OF AMINO ACIDS

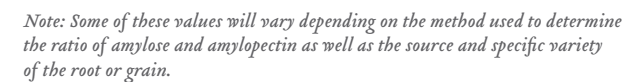
Of the twenty-two amino acids we use, only twenty are encoded by the genes in our DNA. Here is a summary of their taste profiles.



A summary of the smoke points and physical and chemical changes of common cooking fats and oils.



FATS AND OILS UNDERGO DIFFERENT PHYSICAL AND CHEMICAL CHANGES DURING DEEP FRYING AS TIME PROGRESSES



**Sago is sometimes used to refer to tapioca but can also refer to starch extracted from palms.*

Differences between Grain and Root or Waxy Starches

	Grain Starches	Root and Waxy Starches
Examples	Wheat flour, cornstarch, rice starch	Arrowroot, potato, tapioca
Contains	High amylose content	High amylopectin content
Appearance	An opaque finish when cool	A transparent, glossy finish when cool
Thickening temperature	Starts to thicken near the boiling point of water and is stable at (212°F [100°C]). Will become even thicker as it cools and can be cut into pieces.	Starts to thicken at a low temperature (167°F [75°C]) and overheating might thin it. It thins slightly once it cools.

Troubleshooting Starches

	Things to Watch Out For	Solutions
Stirring after thickening	Will thin down	Add flavoring agents before the sauce is thickened so you can minimize stirring.
Reheating	Does not thin	Use a mix of grain and root/waxy starch when thickening.
After freezing and thawing	Weeps water	Use a mix of grain and root/waxy starch when thickening.
Exposure to air	Might form a skin on cooling	Press a piece of parchment or plastic wrap against the surface of the sauce to avoid skin formation.

Because cooking usually involves the use of different types of ingredients, these can in turn affect the thickening capacity of a starch (see table, *Ingredients Affecting Sauces Thickened by Starches*, following).

**Adapted from Cookwise by Shirley O. Corriher (William Morrow and Company, 1997).*

Ingredients Affecting Sauces Thickened by Starches

Problem	Source	What It Does	Solution
Salts	Table salt (sodium chloride), baking soda, baking powder, bones (in bone broth), naturally present salts in fruits and vegetables	Sodium chloride decreases the thickening temperature slightly, depending on how much is present.	Since almost every ingredient contains some type of salt, including tap water, it is harder to control. Add salt at the end if possible, once the sauce has thickened to the desired consistency.
Sugars	Natural sweeteners like table sugar (sucrose) and sugars present in foods, like milk sugar (lactose)	They lock water molecules, making them unavailable for starch granules. Increases the thickening temperature.	Start by adding less sugar while thickening. Once thickened, dissolve the remaining sugar in a small quantity of water and fold it in.
Acids	Acids naturally present in fruits or those, like vinegar, added during cooking	Acids break starch granules and reduce their ability to thicken.	Preferably add them toward the end, after the liquid has thickened to the desired consistency.
Amylases (a special type of protein molecule called enzyme)	Raw fruits, vegetables, grains, yeast, fermented food products like beer, eggs, and animal tissues	Amylases tear starch molecules apart and prevent the sauce from thickening.	Heating the liquid close to the boiling point of water for about a minute helps to avoid this by destroying the enzyme's function. Some recipes might call for the addition of cornstarch to egg-based custards to ensure thickening. Pay extra attention and heat the liquid to 185°F [85°C] for 1 minute to get the “nappe” or coat. By the time the liquid reaches this temperature, the egg proteins change their shape just enough to thicken the base, and the amylase's activity is also destroyed.

Percentage of Umami Substances in Common Ingredients

ND = not detected
Blank space = not measured

Ingredients		Glutamate	IMP	GMP	AMP	Theanine
Meat + Poultry	Beef	0.01	0.07	0.004	0.008	
	Pork	0.009	0.2	0.002	0.009	
	Aged Cured Ham	0.34				
	Chicken	0.022	0.201	0.005	0.013	
	Egg Yolk	0.05				
Seafood	Tuna		0.286	ND	0.006	
	Snow Crab		0.005	0.004	0.032	
	Scallop		ND	ND	0.172	
	Blue Crab	0.043				
	Alaska King Crab	0.072				
	Shrimp	0.02				
	Anchovies	0.63 to 1.44				
	Dried Bonito		0.47 to 0.80			
Seaweed	Dried Sardine					
	Dried laver	1.383				
	Kelp	1.608				
	Wakame	0.009				
Vegetables + Fruit	Carrot	0.04 to 0.08				
	Cabbage	0.05				
	Tomato	0.246	ND	ND	0.021	
	Garlic	0.11				
	Green Peas	0.106	ND		0.002	
	Onion	0.02 to 0.05				
	Shiitake Fresh	0.071	ND	0.016 to 0.045		
	Shiitake Dried	1.06	ND	0.15		
	Avocado	0.018	ND			
Fish Sauce	China	0.828				
	Japan	1.383				
	Vietnam	1.37				
Soy Sauce	China	0.926				
	Japan	0.782				
	Korea	1.262				
Cheese	Emmenthaler	0.308				
	Parmigiano-Reggiano	1.68				
	Cheddar	0.182				
Milk	Cow	0.001				
Fermented Beans	Locust Beans	1.7				
	Soy Beans (Douchi)	0.476				
Tea	Green Tea	0.22 to 0.67				1.78
	Darjeeling Black					1.45
	Assam					1.05

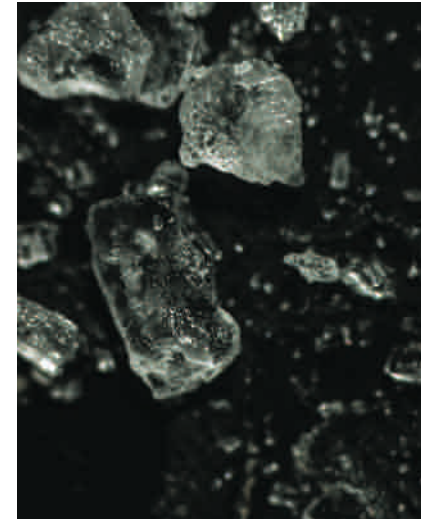
Adapted from Yamaguchi S., Ninomiya K. “Umami and food palatability.” *Journal of Nutrition* 130, 4S (2000).



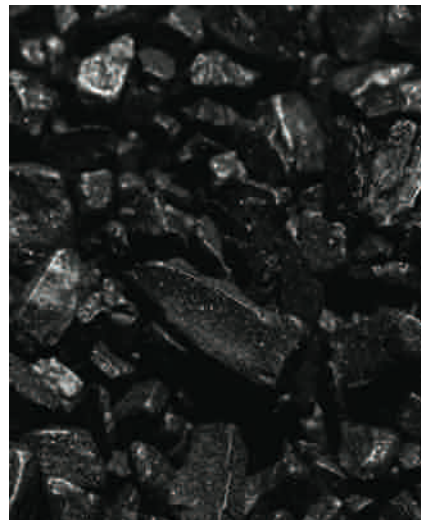
BONITO FLAKES



BROWN SUGAR



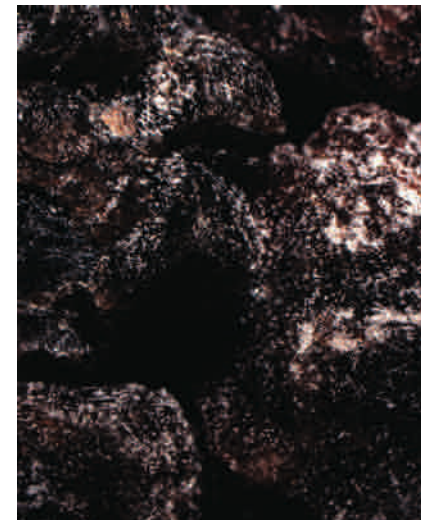
COARSE SALT



HAWAIIAN BLACK SALT



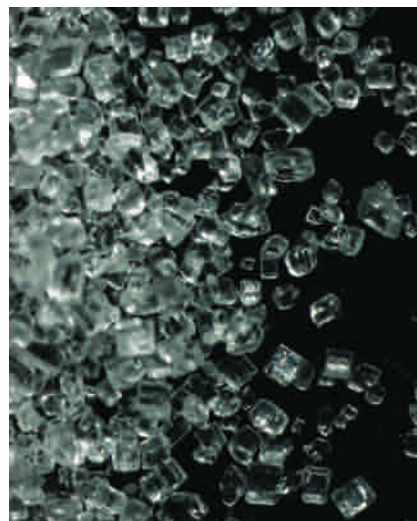
JAGGERY



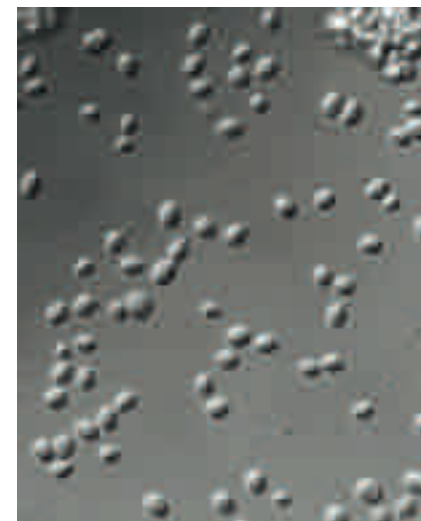
KALA NAMAK INDIAN BLACK SALT



MALDON SALT



SUPERFINE SUGAR



YEAST IN VINEGAR